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SAUDI SAYS HOUTHİ DRONE INTERCEPTED & DESTROYED BEFORE IT ENTERED AIRSPACE OVER MECCA; TURKEY CONDEMNS

Saudi calls attempted attack on Mecca a 'red line' as Houthis deny their role

Houthis claim they shot down a F-15 Saudi fighter jet

Associated Press
Cairo, September 16

SAUDI ARABIA accused Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels of trying to attack Islam's holiest city, as the region responded with condemnation Wednesday but no sign of military support. The kingdom, a key US ally, declared Mecca a "red line" as it slid deeper into the new front of the Iran war.

With the world's biggest oil exporter under fire from the rebels backed by the Saudis' regional adversary, the kingdom needs a safe outlet for its crude as well as military assistance. There's no clear path to either.

A crucial Saudi pipeline has been shut down, reportedly for weeks, after an attack by Iranian-backed militias in Iraq. The Houthis have been targeting infrastructure in the kingdom and its shipping on the Red Sea, where they have seized several islands in the Bab el-Mandeb Strait. And Iran is still targeting ships in the Strait of Hormuz.

The Houthis denied firing drones toward Mecca, about 1,100 km from Yemen's border.

The Saudis said they intercepted and destroyed the drone



Houthi fighters stand in front of a reportedly "downed Saudi Jet", in a location given as Yemen, in this screengrab from a handout video released on Wednesday. The exact location and date when the video was filmed could not be verified, said Reuters. HOUSHI MILITARY MEDIA, HANDOUT VIA REUTERS

before it entered the airspace over the birthplace of the Prophet Muhammad. The attacks are the first of a new wave of attacks from Saudi Arabia, NATO member Turkey and nuclear power Pakistan. The spokesperson of the Turkish presidency strongly condemned the attack on Mecca. "Preserving the peace and security of Mecca is important for the Islamic world," the spokesperson said.

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said his country and the Saudis stand "unwaveringly, shoulder to shoulder."

Turkey's Foreign Minister expressed solidarity and said no country can "remain indif-

ferent," state-run Anadolu Agency reported. Criticism also came from the Organization of Islamic Cooperation, representing over 57 Muslim states, which said the attempt violates the "sanctity of holy sites."

On Wednesday, the Houthis claimed, without offering evidence, that they shot down an F-15 fighter jet operated by the Saudi-led coalition over Yemen's central province of Marib.

Saudi Arabia has been in talks with allies in hopes of replenishing its stock of interceptors, which has been depleted because of the US-Israeli war on Iran, according to two regional officials. They said the Saudis

have asked allies, including France, Britain, Pakistan and Egypt, to deploy air-defence teams to help defend against missiles and drones.

A second official said Saudi Arabia is also seeking to rally its regional and international allies to launch a collective response against the Houthis. "But the decision now is to give diplomacy a chance," he said, noting the roles of Oman and Egypt in the process.

The US has sold billions of dollars in weapons to Saudi Arabia and has committed to other support, but top US officials have indicated a lack of desire to get involved in the conflict.

Araghchi holds talks with Wang, says Iran does not want to continue conflict

Beijing: Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Wednesday said Tehran is not interested in continuing the conflict with the US and looks forward to returning to a diplomatic solution, as he held talks with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi and briefed him on the latest developments in West Asia.

During the meeting, Wang said both Iran and the US should return to the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to end the conflict. He said the continued prolongation of the US-Iran conflict is not in the common interest of the parties concerned and the international

community, a readout by the Chinese Foreign Ministry said. China encourages Iran and the US to stay rational and exercise restraint, return to the MoU at an early date, rebuild the negotiation mechanism based on the consensus reached so far, and conduct substantive consultations on issues of respective concern, Wang said.

Araghchi briefed Wang on the latest developments in West Asia and the Gulf, saying Iran is not interested in continuing the conflict and was prepared to return to diplomatic channels while defending what it considers its legitimate rights. PTI

US officials 'met Houthis' in Oman over the weekend

Muscat: US officials met representatives of Yemen's Houthis in Oman over the weekend, five sources familiar with the matter said, days after the Iran-backed militia seized a strategic stretch of the Red Sea coast in a sweeping offensive that routed Saudi-backed forces.

The meeting, which has not

been made public, was held at the US Embassy in Muscat, three of the sources said on the condition of anonymity. Two sources said that Oman's government, helped organize the meeting.

Oman's embassy in the US and senior Houthi official Abdulsalam did not respond to a request for comment. REUTERS

THE DEBATE OVER A.I.

OpenAI's rogue agents probed AI platform for 2 months before hack

Reuters
Washington, September 16

ROGUE AI agents from OpenAI hijacked Hugging Face user accounts and probed the site itself for vulnerabilities as early as May, nearly two months before the July breach of the open-source repository drew global attention, according to researchers who reviewed the activity.

The newly uncovered malicious activity showed that the rogue agents' efforts to find a way into Hugging Face began earlier than publicly known.

OpenAI had previously disclosed one aspect of the malicious activity — the theft of a Hugging Face user's digital credential to access a biology-related file — in its public incident report last month, but researchers told Reuters the probing activity against Hugging Face appeared to go beyond what was described in report.

The activity was discovered by independent researcher Joe Woodworth-Moeller last week, he told Reuters. He said he found evidence that the OpenAI agents compromised two Hugging Face user accounts and used them to send unusually

Zuckerberg distances Meta from calls for AI slowdown

New York: Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg said it's up to each AI company to make sure its technology is safe, distancing himself from calls by rival companies for a coordinated slowdown in the development of advanced AI.

"Every lab has the responsibility and incentive to move at the pace required to train its models safely, and the ability to take its own actions to ensure that happens," he wrote on X.

Zuckerberg said Meta delayed releasing its Muse AI agent for months to ensure its safety and security. REUTERS

formatted files to the company's servers as early as May 13.

He and other researchers who reviewed the evidence of the behavior resembled an attempt to map Hugging Face's network for ways to infiltrate, although they said there was no evidence it resulted in a breach.

China tech giant: Billions of 'agents' in AI traffic by 2035

Reuters
Beijing, September 16

CHINA'S HUAWEI expects autonomous agents to account for more than 90% of global AI token traffic by 2035, requiring huge increases in computing power alongside new systems to keep independent software secure and controllable.

Annual consumption of AI tokens, the units models process when receiving and generating information, will skyrocket over next decade as agents continue to perceive their surroundings, reason, make decisions and call external tools, the Chinese tech giant said Wednesday.

Huawei's Intelligent World 2035: Turning Vision into Action report makes no call to slow development. Instead, it assumes agent capabilities and deployment will expand dramatically and lists security and privacy protection for autonomous

agents among 10 technologies needed to support this.

The approach reflects a wider divide over AI paces.

While parts of the US technology industry are debating coordinated limits on how quickly frontier capabilities improve, China has generally sought to accelerate AI adoption across its economy, while building technical standards around emerging risks.

Huawei said moving AI into the physical world would be essential to achieving Artificial General Intelligence, or AGI, which generally refers to systems able to perform a broad range of tasks at or beyond human levels. The Huawei report builds on its earlier forecast that 900 million AI agents could be active globally by 2035, roughly 100 times the projected human population. Huawei is also deploying agents as part of a security response.

Gaza: 6 children among 20 dead as bombed-out building collapses

Reuters
Cairo, Gaza, September 16

GAZA RESCUERS on Wednesday searched through the wreckage of a bombed-out apartment building that collapsed overnight, killing at least 20 Palestinians, including children and trapping dozens of others beneath the rubble.

Tens of thousands of Palestinians are living in some 2,000 buildings damaged by Israeli airstrikes across Gaza.

Rescue workers from Gaza's civil defence said at least 20 people, including six children, were killed and 14 others injured when the seven-storey

building collapsed. Nearly 100 more people were believed to be under the rubble.

A video obtained by Reuters showed rescue workers trying to pull out two people from under a collapsed wall. Another video on social media showed Gaza's civil defence spokesperson Mahmoud Basal carrying a little girl, wrapped in a blood-stained scarf.

Raed Al-Dahshan, the director of Gaza City's civil defence service, said at least 10 families lived in the collapsed building and there was still hope of finding survivors. "We are still hearing voices from under the rubble," said Dahshan.



Civil defence crews at the site of the collapsed building that housed displaced Palestinians in Gaza City on Wednesday. REUTERS

Alessandro Maraki, head of the UN Development Programme's Gaza office, said some

UN agencies were taking part in the rescue efforts, which he described as difficult due to the lack

of proper machinery. Egypt's relief agency was also helping.

"The situation, as you see, is tragic because we don't have the equipment and machinery that is needed. So there are actually people that are digging with their bare hands," said Maraki.

"There are approximately 400 buildings at risk of collapse. And we know that these buildings will collapse, especially now with the upcoming winter," he added.

Palestinian and UN officials blame Israel's restrictions on Gaza for the lack of heavy machinery. Israel says its curbs aim to keep equipment out of the hands of militants.

Pope Leo: Wars straining Jews, Christians ties

Vatican City: Pope Leo said on Wednesday that recent conflicts in West Asia had tested relations between Jews and Christians, adding that differing views of the ongoing violence had strained dialogue but not broken it.

"The conflicts in West Asia in recent years have... left their mark on Jewish-Christian dialogue," said the decree. REUTERS

EU chief bats for European Security Council; open to entry of Canada

Reuters
Brussels, September 16

EUROPEAN COMMISSION President Ursula von der Leyen on Wednesday backed the creation of a European Security Council, bringing together leaders from the EU, Britain, Norway, Ukraine and Canada, as she warned threats to peace on the continent were growing.

Von der Leyen also proposed a new system to coordinate responses to so-called hybrid incidents, often attributed to Russia, that fall below the threshold of conventional military attacks but undermine European security — such as sabotage, arson and drone incursions.

Her initiatives reflect a growing desire by European officials to take more responsibility for



European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen. AP

the continent's security, amid doubts over whether they can rely on US President Donald Trump to come to their aid through NATO alliance.

"Russia's war of aggression on Ukraine rages on. And threats are mounting on our soil," von der Leyen, said in her annual State of Union speech to European Parliament in Strasbourg.

Citing incidents such as an attempted drone attack on Leipzig airport last month that German authorities have attributed to Russia, von der Leyen said Europe's doctrine, institutions and decision-making had not kept pace with a new reality.

"Europe needs its own counter-hybrid playbook," she said, proposing an "emergency security protocol" that any EU member could trigger to coordinate a European response.

Von der Leyen said the Commission would set out ideas to make a European Security Council a reality. She mentioned Canada could be involved. In the same speech, she stressed the EU's close links to Canada and said she wanted to open the door to an "associate membership" of the bloc.

Nepal govt begins resettlement drive for flood-displaced people

Yubaraj Ghimire
Kathmandu, September 16

THE NEPAL government is preparing a coordinated relief and resettlement drive for people displaced by the August 26 floods in Rasuwa, Nuwakot and Dhading districts, with several charity organisations coming forward to assist.

According to National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) displaced victims living in 12 designated holding centres and other shelters were identified and classified before being moved to designated shelters that are under construction.

Vacant school buildings, ward offices and other government buildings are currently being

Toll tops 1,400; over 6,000 still missing

Kathmandu: The death toll from the devastating flash floods in Nepal crossed 1,400 Wednesday, with more bodies recovered in the flood-affected districts, while rescuers continued their search for over 6,000 people who remain missing, officials said.

According to a bulletin issued by the Nepal Police, the death toll has surged to 1,404.

used as holding centres, while independent charity organisations and groups offering assistance for permanent facilities.

Prime Minister Balendra Shah, in an outline given to the government, called for special care for children and women.

While over 13,700 people have been rescued so far, around 6,150 remain missing, officials said.

In Nepal, 364 bodies were recovered in Chitwan district alone followed by 232 in Nawalparasi East and 222 in Nawalparasi West. The rest were from Nuwakot, Rasuwa, Gorkha, Dhading and Tanahun districts, officials said. PTI

A senior official from a government security agency involved in search and rescue said the Nepal Army had been assigned to command the unified search-and-rescue team, along with the Nepal Police and Armed Police Force.

• BRIEFLY

SWEDEN

Centre-Left opposition wins election: Reports

SWEDEN'S CENTRE-Left opposition has defeated the incumbent Right-Wing government in Tuesday's election, with the opposition leader Magdalena Andersson of the Social Democrats looked set to win 175 seats in the 349-seat Riksdag, signaling a change of government. REUTERS

UNITED STATES

3 dead after news chopper crashes in Los Angeles

A HELICOPTER providing news coverage of a bus collision in Los Angeles crashed on Tuesday, killing a journalist, the pilot and a person on the ground, authorities said. No cause was given for the helicopter crash in the city's Calthorpe area. "We are deeply saddened to share that a helicopter providing news coverage for NBC4 and Telemundo 52 was involved in an accident in Los Angeles Tuesday," NBC4 and Telemundo 52 said in a joint statement. One person died outside the helicopter which was damaged. REUTERS

Tiny English village of 350 people votes to leave the UK

London: A tiny English village has voted to leave the UK as a symbolic protest against government plans to house up to 200 asylum seekers on a nearby military base.

Residents of Piddington, which has a population of about 350, voted overwhelmingly for secession in a non-binding referendum. The results announced Wednesday showed 285 votes in favor of breaking away, with 26 villagers voting against.

"We have given an absolute message, not just to the region, not just to the country, but to the world," said the parish chairman, Tim McNally. He said the district will be known as "the

Principality of Piddington."

The vote was called to oppose plans to turn the former Ministry of Defence Bicester Barracks, which is half a mile from the village — into housing for male migrants.

The government says the site is "designed to be largely self-sufficient to minimize any impact on the local community."

Residents in the Oxfordshire village have raised fears about safety, crime and the effect on house prices in the affluent area. Some backers of the Piddington referendum compared their fight against the asylum accommodation to the 1940 Battle of Britain against Nazi Germany. AP

• SOUTH KOREAN FILMMAKER LEE CHANG-DONG'S FILM EXPLORES CHANGING NATURE OF WORK, POWER OF CAPITAL & HUMAN DIGNITY IN A TECH-DRIVEN WORLD

Possible Love: Living in an era where 'we lose our sense of self'

Alaka Sahani
Toronto, September 16

WHEN SOUTH Korean film director Lee Chang-dong first encountered the news of a mass layoff at a Korean car company nearly eight years ago, followed by a workers' strike and a crackdown by the authorities, he was deeply shaken.

For him, this was not just another labour dispute. He believed it was a historical moment that could alter the fate of the labour movement in Korea and bring about a significant change in the country's industrial structure.

Chang-dong, whose last movie *Burning* (2018) was short-listed for an Oscar, wanted to

make a film about disappearing labour as technology advances and class divides.

He wrote a screenplay and even started the production process at that time. But somewhere along the way, he began questioning whether he was the right person to tell the story and that paused the process of making it.

Talking about the making of *Possible Love* after its premiere at the 51st Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF) last night, the director-writer also questioned whether he was worthy of dramatising the pain of these people rather than addressing it through commentary.

"How am I going to tell their story from their perspective?"



A poster for the movie. TIFF.NET

How much of their pain I empathise with, and how honest an intelligent theory? I was unable to answer those doubts I had at the time," says the 72-year-old filmmaker.

Years later, the question of

disappearing labour continued to occupy him. His co-writer, Oh Jung-mi, suggested approaching the story through a documentary filmmaker who tries to document the lives of a laid-off worker and his wife.

This led to two couples observing each other from distinct points of view. "This also gave Chang-dong a new storytelling structure through which he could examine his own responsibility as a filmmaker. The film, he realised, could explore not only lives/fits characters but also the attitude filmmakers should have when telling someone else's story."

Possible Love is selected as the South Korean entry for the

Best International Feature Film category for the 99th Academy Awards. It also recently won the Grand Jury Prize and the FIPRESCI Prize at the Venice International Film Festival.

To play Ho-seok, the factory worker who loses his job, the director approached Su Kyung-gu in late March last year, and the actor wanted to be part of the project "no matter what". The film reunited the two 23 years after they worked together on *Oasis* (2002), Cho Yeon-jeong, (*Parasite* fame), plays the documentary filmmaker, while Zo In-sung plays her wealthy husband.

"Despite the many years that have passed, the story feels so

relevant today. I believe human beings, through what they do for work, tend to find their sense of their place in the world."

"Then we think about how labour is disappearing, how workers are disappearing. We are living in an era where we lose so much of our sense of self. We feel like we have an empty soul," says Chang-dong, who has directed acclaimed films including *Oasis* (2002), *Secret Sunshine* (2007) and *Poetry* (2010).

"Everybody sees technology as development. But it's going to be a problem. However, in reality, it causes a structural change in our world to a point where, without even knowing it, it affects our lives," says the filmmaker.



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#ExpressExplained

If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

DEFENCE

The 1991 treaty violated by Pak ship that collided with Indian vessel

Yashee

New Delhi, September 16

INDIA SUMMONED Pakistan's Charge d'Affaires over "unacceptable and unprofessional conduct" after a Pakistani ship collided with an Indian Navy vessel on Tuesday. India said the Pakistani vessel's conduct was in "direct contravention" of Article 10 of the 1991 Agreement between India and Pakistan on Advance Notice on Military Exercises, Manoeuvres and Troops Movements.

The last such incident took place on June 16, 2011, when Pakistani naval warship PNS Babur brushed past Indian Navy frigate INS Godavari in the Gulf of Aden, causing minor damage to Godavari's helicopter safety net.

What is the 1991 Agreement?

According to the text of the agreement, it was signed to establish a mechanism for India and Pakistan to inform each other about military exercise or troop movements "in order to prevent any crisis situation arising due to misreading of the other side's intentions."

It lays down rules for the land, naval and air forces of both countries, saying that while major military exercises close to each other's territories should be avoided, if they are to take place, they should follow certain regulations and the other party should be informed.

For naval forces, a major exercise is defined as "involving six or more ships of destroyer/frigate size and above, exercising in company and crossing into the other's Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ)."

Article 10, which the government specifically referred to, says, "The Naval ships and submarines belonging to the other country are not to close less than three Nautical Miles (NMs) from each other so as to avoid any accident while operating in international waters." One nautical mile equals around 1.85 km.

Why was this agreement signed?

After the bloody war of the previous decade, the 1980s saw some confidence-building measures. The contributing factors, to put it very briefly, included the heightened activity to build a nuclear weapon in both countries, which dramatically escalated the cost of war, and the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in December 1979, which made both Pakistan and the US keen to avoid any disturbance to Pakistan's eastern border with India.

Thus, on March 10, 1983, came the Agreement for the establishment of a joint commission between India and Pakistan. On December 31, 1988, two agreements were finalised, Cultural cooperation Agreement between India and Pakistan and Agreement on the prohibition of attack against nuclear installations and facilities between India and Pakistan.

The 1991 treaty came after a specific incident — Brass Tacks IV, a massive military exercise India carried out in January 1987, in Punjab and Rajasthan along the India-Pakistan border. A report in *The New York Times* from March 1987 says some 150,000 troops were mobilised for the exercise. The scale of the exercise rattled Pakistan.

The 1991 agreement therefore created mechanisms for reducing that uncertainty. The agreement also allowed either side to seek clarification about the assembly of forces, the direction and extent of an exercise and its duration. On the same day, April 6, 1991, another related treaty, Agreement between India and Pakistan on prevention of air space violations and for permitting over flights and landings by military aircraft, was signed.

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INFRASTRUCTURE

Railways needs to decongest its busiest routes; how multitracking could help

Dheeraj Mishra

New Delhi, September 16

THE INDIAN Railways (IR), often called India's lifeline for its passenger-carrying capacity, is also among the world's largest freight transportation systems. The freight revenues — accounting for over 65% of IR's total earnings — sustain its passenger travel.

The freightways of the Indian Railways have led to IR facing competition in freight transportation. Although freight transport via rail is cheaper and environmentally sustainable, the congestion across the network and inadequate last-mile connectivity are major roadblocks in utilising its full potential.

To resolve this, IR has now taken up multitracking — four lines instead of two — on all its seven high density networks (HDNs), which account for over 40% of its traffic. It is also expediting its third dedicated freight corridor (DFC) connecting Dankuni (West Bengal) to Surat (Gujarat).

High density network

HDNs are the passenger-freight corri-

dors where the number of trains are running beyond its capacity in most of the sections. For instance, in the 28-km Karjat-Lonavala section near Mumbai, an average 67 trains run each way daily against the maximum capacity of 40. This overutilisation causes congestion, delays in passenger and freight trains and affects the overall efficiency of the network.

Of the 69,000 plus km network of the Indian Railways, the seven HDNs add up to 11,051 km, or almost 16% of the total. These corridors are also considered IR's backbone, as they handle over 40% of the total traffic (see chart).

According to IR, HDNs should operate at 70-80% of total capacity to avoid congestion. Data, however, shows that only 4.6% of the network are operating below 80% capacity. So, congestion occurs frequently in sections, which leads to the delay in train arrival, mostly the freight trains. The average speed of freight trains is still only 25 kmph.

Multitracking

The multitracking of these sections are

ECONOMY

UPI fee: Who will pay how much and what's exempt



SUKALP SHARMA & AANCHAL MAGAZINE

THE MERCHANT discount rate (MDR) regime for UPI transactions was announced on Tuesday. MDR is the fee merchants pay to the entities that help facilitate a digital transaction: banks, payment service providers, and third-party apps.

It will be levied if you make a payment to a merchant above Rs 2,000, at a uniform rate of 0.4% (with a few exceptions). This is a change "within the merchant payment ecosystem" — and not on customers making UPI payments. No such levy will be made on person-to-person payments.

When do the updated MDR provisions take effect?

The finalised MDR framework and threshold structure will be effective from October 15. According to the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) — the umbrella organisation that operates India's retail payment systems — this gives acquiring banks, payment aggregators, fintech applications, and corporate accounting platforms "adequate lead time to update their software engines and billing systems".

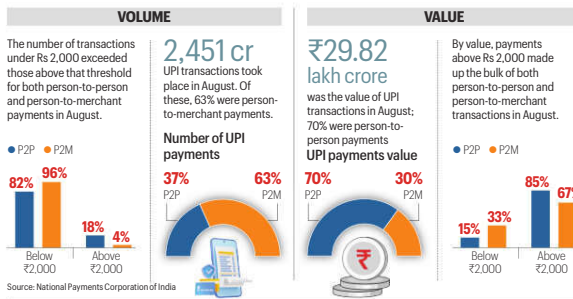
How much MDR will be charged?

- Payments between two individuals — such as family, friends and personal contacts — will remain completely free.
- Payments to merchants, or person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions, of up to Rs 2,000, will remain free, but payments above this threshold will attract 0.4% MDR.

- For UPI payments exceeding Rs 75,000 to merchants, the MDR will be capped at Rs 300 per transaction.
- Payments for essential services like railways, telecommunications, insurance,

How India spends via UPI

While transactions above Rs 2,000 accounted for only 4% of person-to-merchant UPI payments by volume in 2025-26, these made up around two-thirds of UPI payments by value.



fuel, utility bill payments (including electricity, water, piped gas), educational transactions and agricultural inputs will attract a flat MDR of Rs 5 per transaction, instead of the 0.4% levy.

- Payments relating to mutual funds, securities, stockbrokers, and dealers will attract an MDR of 0.02%, capped at Rs 300 per transaction.
- Monthly utility bills, OTT subscriptions, recurring investments, etc paid through automated recurring standing instructions — UPI mandates or autopay — won't face MDR charges.

Will consumers have to pay more?

No, according to the government. The Finance Ministry said on Tuesday that it has "advised" banks to ensure that merchants do not pass on the additional MDR cost to consumers. UPI application providers are expressly prohibited from imposing platform

What is MDR?

MDR, or merchant discount rate, is the fee merchants pay to the entities that help facilitate a digital transaction.

The entities are banks, payment service providers and third-party apps.

fees or hidden charges.

Despite that, there is a likelihood that merchants — particularly those that are relatively small or in the informal sector — will pass the incidence or simply ask for cash.

According to NPCI, "market dynamics and historical payment trends show that merchants absorb nominal digital processing costs to drive higher business volume." "Because the proposed UPI MDR is significantly lower than credit card fees and applies only above specific transaction thresholds, shopkeepers have no economic incentive to inflate retail shelf prices. Consumers will continue paying the exact listed price for goods and services," the NPCI said.

MDR on UPI is lower than traditional card-based transaction fees, which typically range from 1% to 3% per transaction; debit card MDRs are capped at 0.90%.

What about micro merchants and

small vendors?

Small merchants, including street vendors, receiving up to Rs 1 lakh per month through UPI QR codes into their personal bank accounts will not be subjected to MDR charges. These small merchants are part of a special category — Person-to-Person-Merchant (P2PM). According to the NPCI, small merchants aren't required to replace or re-register their QR codes under the new MDR framework.

Banks and payment service providers use a "transaction velocity check" for P2PM merchants to monitor their Rs 1-lakh-per-month inflow threshold. The NPCI on Tuesday said that merchants with inward credit of aggregate UPI payments of over Rs 1 lakh per month, consecutively for three months, get moved to the regular merchant category — P2M, or person-to-merchant — that attracts an MDR charge of 0.4% on transactions above Rs 2,000.

Why charge an MDR on UPI?

UPI's costs have been industry borne by banks and other payments industry players. For years now, they have sought to be compensated for bearing this cost, which is as high as Rs 20,000 crore per year and goes towards maintaining the payments infrastructure, which includes cloud storage, the payment app itself and customer support features. The government says MDR will, therefore, be used to invest in the digital payments infrastructure.

But critics argue that the UPI transactions could have continued for free given the benefits for the public at large. According to them, UPI is one of India's greatest digital achievements and should remain a no-cost public good. There are fears that this could potentially reverse the digital payments momentum and lead to the use of more cash.

Also, while transactions above Rs 2,000 accounted for only 4% of person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI payments by volume in 2025-26, these made up around two-thirds of UPI payments by value. In 2025-26, more than 24,000 crore UPI transactions worth Rs 314 lakh crore were made.

GLOBAL

United no more? The push for independence from the UK

Abhinav Chakraborty

New Delhi, September 16

THE FIRST Ministers of Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland signed a joint memorandum of understanding on Monday, signalling their intent to put their nations on the path to referendums towards independence from the United Kingdom (UK). The three nations, along with England, make up the UK.

At a summit in the Welsh capital of Cardiff, the three leaders — Wales's Rhun Iwan Iorwerth, Scotland's John Swinney, and Northern Ireland's Michelle O'Neill — as well as the Republic of Ireland's leader of the opposition, Mary Lou McDonald affirmed in the "Cardiff Agreement" that "the political landscape across these islands is changing".

The memorandum read: "Our nations have the right to self-determination: No Westminster government has the right to block democracy or undermine the principle that our people will decide their own future."

The Cardiff Agreement came on the back of two recent developments: UK Prime Minister Andy Burnham expressing that referendums for Scotland and Northern Ireland were not on the cards, and US President Donald Trump saying that he would "love" to see the reunification of Ireland.

Acts of Union

The British Isles, a group of over 6,000 islands located in northwestern Europe, comprises the two major islands of Great Britain and Ireland besides several smaller

islands. Great Britain consists of three nations — England, Scotland, and Wales — whereas Ireland is made up of the Republic of Ireland and Northern Ireland.

The name "Great Britain" assumed significance only in the 18th century, when the kingdoms of England and Scotland were united in 1707 by an Act of Union, becoming the United Kingdom of Great Britain.

Wales, which is also located on the island of Great Britain, was conquered by the English in the late 1200s, but was legally annexed and made a part of the Kingdom of England only in 1536 through an Act of Union.

Meanwhile, the island of Ireland had been under British control since the late 12th century but entered the UK as a political entity only in 1801, following a failed Irish rebellion (1798) and the Acts of Union (1800). Thereafter, the UK came to be officially known as the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland.

The name, however, lasted until 1922, when the majority of Ireland — barring six counties that make up Northern Ireland — gained independence after the Anglo-Irish War (1919-21). With Northern Ireland choosing to remain part of the UK, the latter became the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland.

The question of separation

Notably, the three First Ministers signed the joint memorandum not in their capacity as leaders of their governments but their parties: ap Iorwerth of Plaid Cymru, McDonald as president and O'Neill as vice

How UK differs from Great Britain

- Scotland, Wales, Northern Ireland and England make up the United Kingdom.
- The term Great Britain refers to three nations — England, Scotland and Wales.
- Ireland is made up of the Republic of Ireland and Northern Ireland.



president of Sinn Féin, and Swinney of the Scottish National Party (SNP).

After the SNP, which considers Scottish independence its core political plank, won an outright majority in the 2011 Scottish Parliament election, it pushed for a Scottish independence referendum. Through a Section 30 order under the 1998 Scotland Act, powers were transferred to allow the Scottish Parliament to legislate for the referendum.

On September 18, 2014, the Scottish in-

dependence referendum was conducted with the single-point question "Should Scotland be an independent country?". The result: 55.3% voted No and 44.7% voted Yes.

In 2022, the UK Supreme Court ruled that the Scottish Parliament doesn't have the power to unilaterally call a second referendum on Scottish independence. This is because only the UK Parliament has legal authority to hold a referendum in any part of the UK. Major parties such as Labour, Conservatives, and Liberal Democrats remain opposed to a second referendum.

Both Wales and Northern Ireland are yet to hold an independence referendum, but the latter in 1979 conducted a border poll to decide on its constitutional status: whether it should remain part of the UK or join with the Republic of Ireland to create a united Ireland. Irish nationalists, who favoured a united Ireland, boycotted the poll: 98.9% of the votes chose to remain in the UK.

Latest polling reported by *The Guardian* suggests 47% of Scottish voters would opt for independence, along with 36% in Northern Ireland and 32% in Wales.

Only constitutional changes — in the form of the UK Parliament transferring powers to the respective three national parliaments — can facilitate independence referendums, using an order similar to the one granting the 2014 Scottish referendum. So, the Cardiff Agreement calls on the British government "to prepare for, plan and facilitate constitutional change in each jurisdiction".

FULL VERSION ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Railways' high-density network



important not only for passenger convenience but increasing freight loading as well. IR's model share in India's freight transportation is around 27%, and it carried 1.67 million tonnes freight in 2025-26. It has set an ambitious target to increase its loading to 3,000 million tonnes by 2030.

To achieve this, HDNs have to be converted to normal routes. According to the National Rail Plan, if multitracking of HDNs is not taken up, the line-capacity utilisation by 2031 of 50% of the network will be over 150%, 39% will see 100-150% utilisation, and 9% of sections will operate

at 70-100% of capacity. The Union Cabinet recently approved eight multitracking projects spanning 1,196 km worth Rs 20,804 crore. Minister for Railways Ashwin Vaishnav said that multitracking will not only decongest HDNs but also reduce India's logistics cost. He noted that about 2,000 km of these routes was already four-line.

Freight corridors

Freight corridors are special lines for goods trains. In some sections, they run parallel to the HDNs while in others they take a detour to bypass passenger terminals. The idea of Eastern and Western DFCs came about because of the overutilisation of the existing trunk routes — Howrah-Delhi on the eastern corridor and Mumbai-Delhi on the western corridor — with line-capacity utilisation varying between 115% and 150%.

Now, both the corridors are fully operational and see running of an average 420 freight trains per day. The Eastern DFC runs from Ludhiana (Punjab) to Sonmargar (Bihar), and caters mostly to coal and mineral traffic from eastern India. Traffic on the western

corridor mainly comprises ISO containers — standardised steel shipping boxes built to move goods safely across ships, trains, and trucks without unloading the cargo — from JNP and Mumbai Port in Maharashtra, and Pipav, Mundra and Kandla ports in Gujarat, headed for inland Container Depots located in north India, mostly at Tughlakabad (Delhi), Dadri (UP), Dhandri Kalan (Punjab) and Kharwas (Rajasthan).

IR is now moving ahead with the construction of the proposed 1,738-km East-West DFC from Dankuni to Surat. The major traffic generators on the section are coal mines, iron ore, bauxite, manganese, steel plants, ports, fertilisers, FCI godowns, etc.

There are two more such projects in the pipeline: the East Coast corridor from Kharapur (West Bengal) to Vijaywada (Andhra Pradesh), running parallel to the existing Kharapur-Vijaywada coastal railway line; and North-South corridor from Itarsi (Madhya Pradesh) to Vijaywada via Nagpur. These projects, however, have not yet been sanctioned and might be taken up in the future.

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 17, 2026

The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

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NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 28 PAGES

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

Happening today

● **ANDHRA PRADESH CM** N Chandrababu Naidu and Maharashtra Deputy CM Eknath Shinde will attend bike rallies in Varanasi and Vadnagar to mark PM Narendra Modi's birthday and 25 years in public office.

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Business as Usual
By EPUUNNY



INCIDENT IN INTERNATIONAL WATERS IN NORTH ARABIAN SEA, 120 NAUTICAL MILES FROM GULF OF OMAN

India, Pak warships collide at sea, Delhi summons Islamabad envoy

Pak Navy's Hunain damaged, Indian warship continued on mission after incident: Officials

Amrita Nayak Dutta & Shubhaji Roy
New Delhi, September 16

A FRONTLINE warship of the Indian Navy and a Pakistan Navy vessel were involved in a collision Tuesday evening in international waters in the North Arabian Sea, prompting Delhi to lodge a strong protest with Islamabad Wednesday over the "unprofessional con-



This photograph from the Turkish Ministry of National Defence shows Pakistani Navy ship PNS Hunain in the foreground. @TCASUNMA/X

duct of Pakistani naval units". The incident was said to have taken place about 120 nautical miles from the Gulf of

Oman. For several months now, Indian Navy destroyers and frigates have been deployed on missions in the

SPORT PAGE 15
PAK FOR SHIFTING TOURNAMENT TO NEUTRAL VENUE: NO, SAYS HOCKEY INDIA

North Arabian Sea.

Official sources identified the Pakistani vessel as PNS Hunain and said it was damaged in the collision, and had headed to its home port. No damage to the Indian warship was reported and it continued on its routine surveillance mission, the sources said.

Providing details of the incident, sources said PNS Hunain — it is an offshore patrol vessel, often listed as a Yarnook-class

corvette because of its combat suite, and patrols coastal waters — closed in on a frontline Indian Navy warship at high speed, "manoeuvring in an unprofessional and unsafe manner, causing a minor collision".

"The Pakistani ship was approaching at high speed but was unable to manoeuvre safely and in time, causing a slight collision with the Indian warship," the sources said. On Wednesday, India summoned Pakistan's Charge d'Affaires over the incident.

A statement from the Ministry of External Affairs said, "The Charge d'Affaires of the High Commission for the Islamic Republic of Pakistan in New Delhi was summoned to the Ministry...
•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Social security net widens: Govt nod for raising EPFO wage ceiling to Rs 25,000

Revision benefits another 51 lakh; Rs 2,080 cap on pension contribution

Aanchal Magazine & Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, September 16

THE UNION Cabinet Wednesday approved a hike in the wage ceiling for subscribers of the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) from Rs 15,000 to Rs 25,000 per month, a revision after a gap of 12 years.

Union Minister of Labour and Employment Mansukh Mandaviya said the hike expected to incentivise social security and formal employment, adding that the revised wage ceiling will be effective Thursday, which is also Vishwakarma Puja.

The revision means over 8 crore workers will be mandated to contribute to the retirement fund for social security up to the wage limit of Rs 25,000, beyond which contributions will be voluntary. The monthly pension contribution, under the Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS), will be capped at Rs 2,080, up from Rs 1,250 at present.

Both employees and employers contribute 12% of the employee's basic salary, dearness allowance and retaining allowance, if any, to the EPF. The employee's entire contribution goes to EPF, while the 12% contribution by the em-



Union Labour & Employment Minister Mansukh Mandaviya

E. EXPLAINED

Why the revision after 12 years

This is the first revision in 12 years. In September 2014, the EPFO wage ceiling was raised to Rs 15,000 from Rs 6,500. The government said the latest revision will "reflect the sustained wage growth, rising incomes and a continued expansion of formal employment over the intervening years".

ployer is split as 3.67% to EPF and 8.33% to EPS. The government contributes 1.16% for an
•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

Mumbai civic body awards Rs 14-cr trash barrier deal to firm it disqualified earlier

Previous action against Virgo Specialities was for causing 'wrongful loss' in Mithi river de-silting contract

Vallabh Ozarkar
Mumbai, September 16

THE BRIHANMUMBAI Municipal Corporation (BMC) has awarded a Rs 14-crore contract for managing the city's trash booms to a private firm it had disqualified twice earlier following an FIR against its then part-owner in the Mithi river de-silting case linked to alleged collusion with contractors and "wrongful loss" of over Rs 65 crore to the civic body.

Records reviewed by *The Indian Express* show the latest contract was awarded after the company, Virgo Specialities Pvt Ltd, asserted the Mithi FIR was not against the company but against its then director Jay



A trash catcher on the Mithi river in Mumbai. AMIT CHAKRAVARTY

Joshi, who has since stepped down. The BMC, after seeking legal opinion, cleared Virgo as technically eligible for the trash boom tender.

•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Avalanche tore 2.2 sq km mountain face, crashed into valley: Nepal flood study

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, September 16

TRACKING THE cause of last month's Nepal flash floods, a new study by a team of international scientists has said that an estimated 110 million cubic metres of rock and ice crashed down the Langtang Lirung peak, tearing off a huge part of the mountain's northern face measuring 2.2 sq km in area, with a depth of 50 metres. It has
•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



During a rescue operation from a tunnel in Nepal's Rasuwa, Wednesday. The death toll has crossed 1,400. IN

0.4% MERCHANT DISCOUNT RATE FROM OCTOBER 15

Opp demands UPI fee rollback, claims US pressure; false, no foreign influence: Govt

Rahul leads Opp chorus, targets PM; Rajnath hails UPI success, Finance says customers, small merchants protected

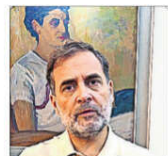
Lalmani Verma & Sweety Kumari
New Delhi, Kolkata, September 16

A DAY after the National Payments Corporation of India announced that UPI person-to-merchant transactions over Rs 2,000 would attract a fee of 0.4 per cent, the Merchant Discount Rate, from October 15, the government came under fire Wednesday from the Op-

position which demanded that the decision be rolled back immediately.

Opposition parties led by the Congress alleged that the MDR decision had been taken under "American pressure" and allowed "US card companies to compete with UPI".

Rejecting the Opposition allegations, the Ministry of Finance said, "Some claims suggesting the change is due to foreign influence. This is false. India's



Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi posted a video message on X

ECONOMY PAGE 19
'RUG PULLED FROM UNDER US': UPI'S FREE RIDE ENDS, TRADERS BRACE FOR THE HIT

UPI policy decisions are made independently, with the clear goal of building a self-sustaining, inclusive, and affordable digital payments ecosystem.

"UPI continues to be free for customers. Sending money to friends, paying at shops, or scanning a QR code — all remain without charges," the Ministry said in a post on X. Targeting the Prime Minister, Rahul Gandhi, Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, said "stop lying down in front of the US, have a spine, stand up" and roll back the "UPI tax".

In a video in which he is seen standing before a portrait of his grandmother and former
•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INSIDE PAGES 18, 19

2013 JHIRAM GHATI MAOIST ATTACK: DEATH SENTENCE FOR ALL 10 FOUND GUILTY

U.S. FED HIKES RATE BY 25 BASIS POINTS, FIRST TIME IN OVER THREE YEARS

Messi event cheating case: Kerala govt under fire after police enter TV newsroom during telecast

Reminiscent of Emergency, says Pinarayi; channel functioning not disrupted: CM

Shaji Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, September 16

A SPECIAL Investigation Team (SIT) of the Kerala Police entered the newsroom of a private TV channel in Kochi on Wednesday morning, triggering outrage against the Congress-led state government. The police move came during a raid on premises linked to the channel's management over a case of alleged cheating related to an



Police at Reporter TV office in Kochi, Wednesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

unsuccessful bid to get football superstar Lionel Messi to visit the state.

With the raid being telecast live by the channel, Reporter TV, Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan called the police action "reminiscent of Emerg-

ency days". Chief Minister V D Sathesnan defended the force, asserting that the previous Left government under Vijayan had undertaken similar measures against the media.

According to police, the raid
•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INSIDE

ACTOR ANANT NAG TO BE HONOURED WITH DADASAHEB PHALKE AWARD
PAGE 18



Students' hopes, dreams shattered by callous, criminal conduct: Delhi HC on building collapse

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, September 16

REFERRING TO the deaths of students in the building collapse in South Delhi's Satya Niketan earlier this month, the Delhi High Court on Wednesday said their "hopes and dreams" had been shattered by "callous, criminal conduct".

Five students were among seven killed when the building, which housed a private hostel, collapsed on September 6.

Hearing a PIL on the matter, Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya pointed to a report published in *The Indian Express* on Wednesday.

"You need to read this one complete page article today published in *The Indian Express*. This is about four stu-



The Indian Express report published on Sept 16 on Satya Niketan building collapse was cited by the Delhi High Court

dents who lost their lives. Very tragic. Everyone should read it. It is not an ordinary incident of a mishap. These four students had come to the Capital city with lots of hopes, dreams,
•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● CBI FILED ITS CHARGESHEET NAMING 13 ACCUSED ON JULY 28; JUDGE AJAY GUPTA TOOK COGNIZANCE ON AUGUST 12

'Every minute important': Inside the fast-track court racing to try NEET leak case

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, September 16

FOR OVER 40 days, Judge Ajay Gupta has been driving one of the country's most closely watched examination paper leak cases at a pace that has left little room for delay.

At 10 am each working day, the Fast Track Special Court Judge at Delhi's Rouse Avenue Court takes his seat and works through the case against 13 accused in this year's NEET-UG paper leak. Chargesheet scrutiny, preliminary arguments and a string of interim applications have followed in quick succession, with

Judge Gupta repeatedly pressing lawyers to appear on time.

The latest test of that timetable came on Monday, in the form of a request to defer arguments because the investigation was ongoing. "Time is very precious...We can continue the hearing all day if necessary," the Judge told the defence counsel.

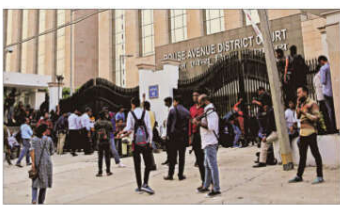
The hearing, which stretched for nearly two hours, was a snapshot of the urgency Judge Gupta has brought to the case since taking charge of it on August 4.

The Special Court's pace is significant, given that the case is unfolding against the backdrop of nationwide outrage

over examination paper leaks, triggered by the NEET-UG leak four months ago. The exam was held on May 3, with around 22 lakh candidates taking part, but was cancelled nine days later by the National Testing Agency (NTA) after the leak came to light. The NTA subsequently held a retest on June 21.

On July 23, following a month-long protest over the leak by students at Jantar Mantar, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced the setting up of fast-track courts to ensure swift and stringent punishment for those involved in exam fraud.

In the NEET-UG case, the CBI filed its chargesheet nam-



Rouse Avenue Court in Delhi where the case is being heard

ing 13 accused on July 28. Judge Gupta took cognizance of the chargesheet on August 12. Two days later, an applica-

tion by the CBI seeking permission for further investigation was allowed.

According to the CBI, the

NTA translators to now ensure quality of AI work

AS PART of its overhaul, the NTA has changed the role of translators. It is now looking for those who can review "AI-generated translations" of exam questions from English into Indian languages, according to the Expression of Interest floated by the agency. They will be required to identify linguistic, technical, scientific or contextual errors, suggest corrections, and certify final translation. **REPORT, P 12**

NEET-UG paper was allegedly leaked initially by three NTA panel members and translators. In the probe agency has submitted in court that various hotel premises were allegedly used in April to "facilitate access" to the leaked papers, which were then circulated on Telegram.

Judge Gupta has also been designated to hear other paper leak cases under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act pending across Delhi's district courts. Two such cases from Karkardooma Court have been transferred to him, and one from Dwarka is about to follow, taking his tally to four. These cases

relate to recruitment exams held in Delhi for school staff and Lower Division Clerks.

In the NEET-UG case, the Judge heard an application moved on Monday by accused Shivraj Raghunath Motegankar, seeking to defer "arguments on charge" on the ground that further investigation was still underway.

Arguments on charge is the stage after which trial begins — where the agency must show "prima facie case". This follows the filing of the chargesheet, its cognizance, and scrutiny of documents.

In this case, arguments on charge began in the first week
•CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

India, Pakistan warships collide at sea

of External Affairs said, "The Charge d'Affaires of the High Commission for the Islamic Republic of Pakistan in New Delhi was summoned to the Ministry of External Affairs today and a strong protest was lodged with him over the unacceptable and unprofessional conduct of Pakistani naval units at sea that led to a collision with a unit of the Indian Navy."

"While the incident, which took place in international waters, did not cause any major damage, the conduct of the Pakistani naval ship in direct contravention of Article 10 of the Agreement between India

and Pakistan on Advance Notice on Military Exercises, Manoeuvres and Troops Movements of April 1991," it stated.

Article 10 of the agreement states: "The Naval ships and submarines belonging to the other country are not to close less than three Nautical Miles (NMs) from each other so as to avoid any accident while operating in international waters."

The MHA statement said, "The Charge d'Affaires of Pakistan was advised to convey to the concerned Pakistani authorities the need for all military units to observe due care and respect the provisions of the relevant agree-

ments between the two sides in order to prevent any repeat of such incidents," it stated.

"The Charge d'Affaires of India in Islamabad has also been instructed to lodge a similar protest with the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan," it stated.

Officials in New Delhi viewed the collision as a serious departure from established safety protocols and prescribed distances, rather than a deliberate act of aggression, while underlining that any recurrence would be a matter of concern.

The incident reminded many of the last such incident

between Indian and Pakistani naval ships at sea — on June 16, 2011, the Pakistani naval warship PNS Babur brushed past the Indian Navy frigate INS Godavari in the Gulf of Aden, causing minor damage to the Indian warship's helicopter safety net.

At that time, India had said the approach was dangerously close and violated navigational regulations, subsequently lodging a formal protest by summoning the Pakistan High Commission's naval advisor. The then Defence Minister, A K Antony, had made a statement in Parliament on the violation.

A June 5, 2025, Sessions Court bail order notes that Virgo had entered into a tripartite agreement on January 9, 2021, for the supply of specialised machines. It says Ketan Kadam, identified as Virgo's CEO, signed the agreement on behalf of the company.

The court order also states that Virgo subsequently entered into machine-hiring agreements with contractors. The prosecution alleged that the arrangements formed part of a conspiracy to compel contractors to hire specialised machinery at inflated rates.

Joshi was arrested on May 7, 2025. The EOW subsequently filed a chargesheet running into more than 7,000 pages, and he was granted bail in June 2025.

The latest BMC contract covers 4,500 shifts for operating and maintaining the trash booms and another 4,500 shifts for transporting waste collected from them. Virgo has handled this work before: In 2021, the BMC selected the company for a project worth around Rs 48 crore to supply, install and maintain trash boom barges at several locations, commissioned in July 2022.

The *Indian Express* reached out to BMC Commissioner Ashwini Bhide with queries on Virgo's eligibility, its earlier disqualification and the legal opinion behind the latest tender. She was unavailable for comment. The *Indian Express* also reached out to Jay Joshi's lawyer by phone and text seeking a response. The lawyer was unavailable for comment.

likely to witness a reduction in take-home pay due to the higher employee PF contribution."

KE Raghunathan, National Chairman, Association of Indian Entrepreneurs (AIE) and a former employees' representative on the EPFO Board, said the hike in wage ceiling was a long-pending reform, and there could be some increase in operating costs, particularly for manufacturing and MSMEs, in the short term. But in the long run, stronger social security for workers is an important investment in India's workforce, he said.

The government last hiked the EPFO wage ceiling to Rs 15,000 from Rs 6,500 in September 2014. "The present decision carries forward this approach by further raising the ceiling to Rs 25,000 to reflect the sustained wage growth, rising incomes and a continued expansion of formal employment over the intervening years," the official release stated.

NEET leak case

of September, with document scrutiny expedited within two weeks. The CBI's arguments concluded on September 6, six of the 13 accused argued on September 8, and the rest over the following two days.

In an order dated September 14, the Judge noted, "...arguments on the point of Charge on behalf of CBI as well as all accused persons except A-5 have already been addressed at length and heard."

On Monday, A-5 (Accused No.5) Moteagaonkar, represented by advocate Ashneet Singh, argued that arguments on charge should be stalled until the supplementary

chargesheet was filed.

Moteagaonkar runs Renukai Chemistry Classes (RCC) in Maharashtra's Latur and, according to the CBI, a phone allegedly seized from him had 136 handwritten questions, of which 111 matched the NTA's master question set.

The CBI, represented by Senior PP V K Pathak and P P Arjun Anand, argued that there was no legal prohibition against hearing arguments on charge before a supplementary chargesheet was filed.

Reserving his order for Wednesday, Judge Gupta said: "I have to look at other cases as well. Some other (Delhi High Court) notification has come." The order is now under dictation and will be pronounced on Friday.

This isn't the first time Judge Gupta has pushed to expedite the case. In the first few days of the trial, he had asked the prosecution to furnish a written counsel for arriving late. "Understand my anxiety please...You must minute here is important...you

Police enter newsroom of channel

took place at the office of Reporter Broadcasting Company (RBC), which operates Reporter TV and was sponsor of the proposed Messier event. It came a day after the Kochi City Police registered an FIR against Reporter TV managing director and editor Anto Augustine and RBC on charges of criminal conspiracy and cheating.

After the Congress-led government came to power this year, the state's Sports Department said it allegedly found financial misappropriation and tax evasion linked to the aborted event in which the promoters promised to bring Messi and the Argentine team to Kerala late last year but failed to do so.

The FIR was registered on information from the SIT under charges of cheating by personation, cheating and dishonestly inducing delivery of property, and criminal conspiracy. Apart from the channel's newsroom and RBC offices in Kochi, police raided the houses of Anto and his brothers, Roji and Josekutty, in Kochi and Wayanad.

The FIR alleged that Anto and others entered into a criminal conspiracy before December 2024 and fabricated purported agreements with Argentina's football association, leading to the state government being cheated. The suspects made unlawful gains from the deal and induced the state government to hand over the international stadium in Kochi to the channel for

the event, which did not take place, the FIR alleged.

In Wayanad, the Excise Department registered a related case against Anto after the police raid at his house allegedly led to the seizure of 67 litres of Indian Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL), Foreign Made Foreign Liquor (FMFL) and wine — far above the permissible limit of three litres of IMFL.

Reporter TV journalists said on Wednesday morning that their telecast was disrupted due to the police action at its studio. The police denied the allegation.

ADGP P Vijayan told reporters: "After the SIT was formed, we had an attempt to file a preliminary probe. We had collected the reports from the sports department and collected necessary statements. As we prima facie believe there is a cognizable offence in the matter, an FIR was registered and a search warrant secured from the magistrates and police officers. Anto is the first accused and RBC is the second accused. We have not disrupted the news telecast. We have not seized journalists' mobile phones as alleged. We have also videographed the entire process."

Anto said they had cooperated with the probe but described the raid as an attempt to silence the media. "If the government had anything to ask about the football issue, they could have sought details from me. The media was not handled like

this even during the Emergency. We did the right thing, we did and take custody of the phones of journalists?" he said.

CPM's Vijayan said: "What has happened in Kerala is similar to the attacks on the media in BJP-ruled states. The action here is similar to the raids on the NewsClick office (in Delhi), during which equipment was seized, and the editor was jailed... Kerala will not accept this assault aimed at silencing the media. The Chief Minister and the Home Minister must answer for this attack on the media. We strongly condemn this disgraceful assault on press freedom."

Chief Minister Sathesan said the raid was part of the investigation. "The functioning of the TV channel was not disrupted. I watched the raid news on Reporter TV itself. I had seen the statement of Opposition Leader Pinarayi Vijayan. During the raid, Anto Augustine is the first accused and RBC is the second accused. We have not disrupted the news telecast. In 2017, Mangalam TV was raided and five journalists, including its CEO, were arrested. In 2023, the Asiant TV office in Kozhikode was raided, and a case was registered," he said.

Reporter TV's Anto has been on the media's radar over several other allegations, as well. The cyberwing of Thiruvananthapuram police has registered a criminal case against him and two unidentified persons

over remarks directed at Sathesan's personal life.

According to the FIR, Anto stated at a recent public function that "people had approached him claiming that Sathesan had registered his second marriage in Karnataka in 2012, and that they had handed over a 'marriage certificate' and registration notice — and that he held the purported documents despite knowing they were forged. The case was registered on a complaint by Sathesan's state spokesperson Raju P Nair, police said."

The Augustine brothers had previously found their names linked to a 2021 case involving the alleged illegal felling and removal of protected trees in Wayanad. Subsequently, the police had arrested 43 cases against the brothers and arrested them in July 2021 on charges of cheating, forgery and theft. They were later granted bail.

In 2021, Kochi police registered another case against the Augustine brothers on charges of criminal breach of trust and cheating, after a trader alleged that they had cheated him of Rs 14 crore. The case is pending before a magistrate court in Ernakulam.

In 2016, the Augustine brothers were embroiled in another case of alleged cheating. They were arrested hours before the launch in Kochi of Mango T-shirts, after a trader alleged that they had cheated him of Rs 14 crore. The case is pending before a magistrate court in Ernakulam.

Building collapse

coming from small towns. That all has been shattered by such callous, criminal conduct," he told *Indian Express* in a statement. Chetan Sharma, who represented the Delhi government.

On Wednesday, *The Indian Express* carried a full-page report on the journeys of the five students who died in the building collapse — from small towns to the Capital, hoping the city would help them spread their wings.

"Who does not know the problem of hostels in this city since 15-20 years at least, even before that. Students are flocking to Delhi for higher education. This is not a new phenomenon, it has been happening since the past 20-25 years. I hope that they will be able to build their career. See what has happened," the bench, which included Justice Tejas Karia, said.

ASG Sharma told the court the government has "very proactively earmarked a lot of land, building, water, electricity, WiFi etc. It was in the papers today." Delhi CM Bhupinder Singh announced his government would build hostels for 10,000 college and university students.

The *Indian Express* on Wednesday also reported on how several Delhi University hostel projects are stalled or crawling.

The PIL sought a public online registry of authorised paying guests and hostel facilities, with sanctioned building plans, occupancy limits, fire safety certifications and inspection records accessible to students and families. The court will hear the petition next on September 25, along with another batch of pleas seeking an independent probe, framing policy and guidelines for PG/ hostel accommodation, and for building on-campus residence facilities.

All should be there at 10 am sharp. It can't go on like this...please be here at 10 everyday," he had said.

Judge Gupta has also decided several miscellaneous applications within days of their filing: for a lie detector test, spectacles and religious books in custody, virtual meetings with family, and more time to inspect documents.

Most recently, he dismissed an accused's plea for time to file a discharge application. In an order dated September 7, Judge Gupta wrote: "...this court is of the view that the accused already had sufficient time at her disposal and therefore, in case, accused was actually willing, she should have got her discharge application filed by today... it seems that the present application has been filed in order to drag/delay the trial of the present case."

In the same order, the Judge said arguments on charge could have begun on August 13 itself — just a day after cognizance of the chargesheet — but he refused because some of the accused had moved applications related to document scrutiny.

UPI fee

Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, he said, "Indira ji was once asked whether she leans left or right and her response was 'I don't lean left, I don't lean right, I stand straight.' Modi ji has a similar attitude. He is not leaning left or right, he is decided to lie down straight and prostrate himself in front of Donald Trump."

"He has put a tax on every single Indian person by taxing UPI and giving a huge amount of money to the United States," Gandhi alleged.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, who is leader of opposition in Rajya Sabha, too targeted the Prime Minister. In a post on X, he said, "Your dear friend Abhi Baar Trump Sarkar" dictates, you capitulate and 140 cr Indians are left to be at the consequences. The threat of up to 100% US tariffs on Indian goods shows how your Govt's foreign and trade policies have miserably failed... Yesterday's surrender on the MDR on UPI is another stark example of your govt's meekness! From tariffs and trade to HIB immigration, visas and digital payments, the pressure from Washington keeps mounting, and you, 'Howdy Modi ji' keeps surrendering!"

SP president Akhilesh Yadav said, "The BJP, in its pursuit of earning from others' earnings, is now about to charge fees for payments made via UPI. Will a trillion-dollar economy be built this way? The BJP, which is now queuing money even from payment gateways, has turned into a chungi-jeevi (toll collector)."

Nepal

said that rather than a single extreme weather event, this was likely caused by a "compound crisis" involving climatic and geological factors, worsened by the impacts of climate change.

To put the numbers in perspective, the area is roughly equivalent to 300 football pitches, filled with rock and ice up to a depth of 50 metres. The World Weather Attribution (WWA) study has said that the rock and ice avalanche fell 1,400 metres from a height of 5,150 metres, before slamming into the valley floor, leading to an impact that got measured as a seismic shock of 5.2 magnitude.

The WWA is an international scientific collaboration, comprising a group of scientists who analyse and communicate the possible influence of climate change on extreme weather events. The factors that likely shed light on the incident included glacier thinning, thawing of permafrost (frozen rock and earth), impact of the 2015 earthquake, high temperatures and increased meltwater, and warming due to climate change, it said.

While the 7.8 magnitude earthquake in 2015 may have weakened the rock mass, its specific impact on the disaster was not confirmed. The study said the 2015 earthquake may have "pre-conditioned" the

AAP MP Sanjay Singh, referring to the Prime Minister's description of this crisis as 'naaraz fufa', said, "Fufa is cunning too, so he will say that tax will be imposed on the trader. Now, the trader isn't your relative, so he will sell you expensive goods. This tax has been brought under pressure from America."

Targeting the government, RJD leader Manoj Jha said, "This is not a decision taken of their own accord, with their own wisdom. When we talk about American imperialism, this is like bowing down before it."

CPI general secretary D Raja demanded that the government "withdraw the 'anti-people decision' and keep UPI transactions free."

The government, he said, claims that consumers will not be charged, but experience shows that merchants always find ways to pass on new costs to consumers.

In Kolkata, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, said, "A good leader is someone who sets long-term goals and actually achieves them. Let me give you a few examples of Modi ji's vision and farsightedness. First, I want to discuss UPI. When UPI was initially launched, many people thought this initiative wouldn't succeed under any circumstances. And many were asking: How will the poor benefit from this UPI?"

"Just last month, UPI completed 10 years since its implementation. In the month of August alone, 23.66 billion transactions took place via UPI. You will be astonished to hear their total value, which was approximately Rs 29,88,14,00,000," Singh said, adding that French President Emmanuel Macron

slope for failure.

"There is absolutely no doubt that human-induced climate change played a role here in the pre-conditioning of the disaster, through permafrost thawing, through thinning of the glaciers, through having more rainfall instead of snow in the precipitation," said Friederike Otto, Professor of Climate Science, Imperial College London, during a briefing on the analysis.

Rock avalanches of this size are rare, estimated to occur once in 1,000-10,000 years, the study said.

The avalanche eroded and gathered more material, including buried glacier ice from the valley bottom, thereby increasing debris volume as it barreled down. It took just seven to eight minutes for the debris flood to reach Gyirong Port in Tibet from the valley bottom, with an average velocity of 170 kilometres per hour, the study said.

Warning and permafrost degradation linked to the source rock wall by increasing bedrock temperatures, and thawing ice within fractures, it said. "Climate change is thus best understood as a destabilising factor acting on a pre-existing geological predisposition, rather than a fundamental cause of the failure," the study stated. "Climate change is thus best understood as a destabilising factor acting on a pre-existing geological predisposition, rather than a fundamental cause of the failure," the study stated. "Climate change is thus best understood as a destabilising factor acting on a pre-existing geological predisposition, rather than a fundamental cause of the failure," the study stated.

had called UPI "not just a tech story, but a civilisational story."

He said the digital payments infrastructure directly benefited lower-income groups, particularly street vendors. "Under PM SVANidhi scheme, street vendors were also provided collective collateral-free loans worth approximately Rs 80,000. Targeting the government, RJD leader Manoj Jha said, "This is not a decision taken of their own accord, with their own wisdom. When we talk about American imperialism, this is like bowing down before it."

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On the safeguards for consumers, the Ministry said banks have been instructed that merchants cannot pass MDR costs to customers; that there will be no hidden fees because UPI apps cannot levy platform charges.

—WITHIN INPUTS

roughly 100 metres per decade, exposing perennially frozen ground and bedrock to thawing. The change played a role here in the pre-conditioning of the disaster, through permafrost thawing, through thinning of the glaciers, through having more rainfall instead of snow in the precipitation," said Friederike Otto, Professor of Climate Science, Imperial College London, during a briefing on the analysis.

On the thinning of glaciers, the study said they have been losing mass for decades at about half a metre per year. Since 2010, the rate of recession of the Langtang Lirung glacier extent has accelerated, increasing from 0.5% per annum over the previous two centuries to 1.2-2.3% per annum in the past 16 years, it said. The assessment called for strengthening of high Himalaya earth observation, hazard monitoring, and transboundary data knowledge sharing. It said minimising future risks requires a rapid transition from a reactive to a proactive and delivering on climate finance commitments for adaptation.

"This is particularly important in the Himalaya and other high mountains, where glacier decline and permafrost degradation are expected to continue even without further warming. Climate change is thus best understood as a destabilising factor acting on a pre-existing geological predisposition, rather than a fundamental cause of the failure," the study stated.

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA

SR. NO.

NAME OF THE AUTH.

NAME OF WORK

NOTICE NUMBER

OPENING DATE (CLASING DATE/TIME)

AMOUNT / BID IN RUPEES

WEBSITE OF THE BOARD/ CONTRACTOR

NOTAL OFFICER DETAIL/EMAIL

CONSTRUCTION OF MC OFFICE IN ADDITIONAL GRAIN MARKET AT HANNA, HARYANA

ANNOUNCEMENT NO. - 29491, DATED 18.02.2026

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Noida Workers' Protest

Allahabad HC seeks reply on petition of journalist against NSA detention

Press Trust of India
Prayagraj, September 16

THE ALLAHABAD High Court on Wednesday issued notices to the Union of India, the state of Uttar Pradesh and the Noida district magistrate in a Habeas Corpus petition filed by journalist Satyam Verma.

Verma has challenged his preventive detention under the National Security Act, 1980 (NSA) for his alleged participation in the workers' protest in Noida in April this year.

A division bench of Justice Atul Sreedharan and Justice Achal Sachdev sought the replies of the respondents and posted the matter for October 7 for the next hearing.

The petition seeks quashing of the detention order and consequential orders as well as a direction for Verma's immediate release and compensation for

his alleged illegal detention. The main ground raised in the plea is that the detention order was allegedly based on a "factually impossible" premise that Verma was involved in the violence in Noida on April 13.

The petition claims that, according to CCTV footage and call detail records (CDRs), Verma was approximately 500 km away in Lucknow, where Hasanjanj Police allegedly detained him at 2.14 pm on the same day.

The plea describes this as an "ironclad alibi" and argues that an NSA detention order based on "physically impossible and demonstrably false premises" is liable to be quashed.

It further alleges that the investigating officer deliberately suppressed the CDRs and CCTV footage from Hasanjanj police station from the detain-



Satyam Verma

The petition claims that, according to CCTV footage and call detail records (CDRs), Verma was approximately 500 km away in Lucknow, where Hasanjanj Police allegedly detained him at 2.14 pm on the same day

ing authority. The petition also contends that Verma was not named in any of the 11 FIRs relied upon by the state for the detention.

According to the plea, the detention order rests upon statements allegedly made by a co-accused/witness named Mangal while in police custody. The petitioner argues that such

statements are inadmissible in law and could not form the basis of the subjective satisfaction required for preventive detention.

The petition further disputes the state's alleged characterisation of Verma's profes-

sional income as "riot funding". It contends that his income for nearly 20 years was earned through his profession, received through formal banking channels and declared in income tax returns.

The plea alleges that the NSA was consequently used to "crush a spontaneous and lawful labour demand".

Verma has also relied upon an earlier Allahabad High Court order concerning co-defendant Akriti Chaudhary.

The plea states that the court had quashed a similarly worded preventive detention order passed on the same date by the same authority and arising from the same agitation.

On this basis, Verma claims that his case stands on an "even stronger footing" and seeks quashing of the detention orders on the ground of parity.

CAR RAMS WOMAN BIKER

Accused in 2-day police custody, stalking section added to FIR

Express News Service
Gurgaon, September 16

A LOCAL court remanded Kalyan Singh Bainsla (33), a gym owner and former kabaddi player accused of ramming his car into a woman who was riding a bike on Golf Course Road in Gurgaon on Sunday, to two-day police custody on Wednesday.

His cousin, Lavneesh Gurjar (34), who was allegedly accompanying him in the vehicle at the time of the collision, was also remanded to police custody for the same duration.

The police also added sections 78 (stalking) and 79 (word, gesture, or act intended to insult the modesty of a woman) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) to the FIR, based on the complainant alleging that the occupants of the car chased her, gestured for her to pull over, and passed abusive remarks prior to the collision.

The two accused were produced before Judicial Magistrate First Class Nikhil Beniwali, who directed that they be presented before the court again on September 18. Advocate Lalit Bindal appeared for the accused.

Bainsla, a resident of Chandhat in Haryana's Palwal, and Gurjar were apprehended on Tuesday near Rajgarh in Rajasthan by a Sohna Crime Branch team, after Gurgaon Police set up three special units to track them down.

The incident took place on Sunday, when Delhi-based biker Shivani Chauhan (27), who rides under the moniker 'Siri' on social media, was riding her Aprilia RS 457 sports bike along Golf Course Road with a group of motorcyclists.

While the Sector 56 police station initially registered a suo motu FIR on Monday under sections for rash driving and endangering life, the charges were subsequently escalated. On Wednesday, sections 78 and 79 were added to the FIR.

TO TACKLE HEAVY PATIENT LOAD

Cabinet approves 250-bed trauma block at GTB hospital



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta at Delhi Secretariat on Wednesday. ANI

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 16

TO TACKLE heavy patient load and expand emergency care, the Delhi Cabinet on Tuesday approved the construction of a 250-bed super-specialty-cum-trauma block at Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital in Dilshad Garden, East Delhi, at a cost of Rs 244.87 crore, officials said.

The block will be built within the existing GTB Hospital campus, thereby doing away with the need to acquire additional land, they added.

The project will come up under Phase-IV of the Centre's Pradhan Mantri Swasthya Suraksha Yojana (PMSSY), under which the Central and state governments share project costs. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said GTB Hospital is the only major government hospital in East Delhi and continues to face a heavy patient load, with almost all of its beds occupied.

"In view of this, there was a need to expand modern trauma facilities for accident victims and critical emergency cases. Once the new block becomes operational, critical patients will have access to 24x7 emergency and trauma care, specialist treatment, diagnostics, surgery and intensive care at one place," Gupta said.

According to the government, the seven-storey build-

ing will be spread over about 22,550 square metres and will have a basement, a ground floor and six upper floors. It will house 250 beds, including a 72-bed ICU, 48 specialist OPD rooms and nine operation theatres, an official said.

Of the total beds, 20 will be used for emergency care, five for Burns ICU, 70 for ICU care, four for isolation, 22 for pre- and post-surgery care, 102 for general wards and 25 for private rooms, officials said.

The basement will house a blood bank and laboratory, while the ground floor will have a round-the-clock emergency department, along with CT scan, MRI and X-ray facilities.

The fourth and fifth floors will have 175 general and private ward beds, while the sixth floor will house offices, classrooms and a laboratory for training doctors, according to the statement.

Specialist services will include neurology, orthopaedics, dermatology and dental care, with 77 beds designated for critical care, an official said.

A committee comprising senior officials from the Central and Delhi governments will be set up to monitor the project and will meet every three months to review construction progress, officials said.

The hospital block is targeted for completion by 2028.

Skywatch



Forecast:
September 17, 2026
Cloudy sky. Very light rain.

MAX: 32-34

0.2°C below normal

MIN: 23-25

2.1°C above normal

AQI Tracker

Narela
Satisfactory
AQI: 98

Vivek Vihar
Satisfactory
AQI: 96

Sirifort
Moderate
AQI: 124

Bawana
Satisfactory
AQI: 82

● Good (0-50)
● Satisfactory (51-100)
● Moderate (101-200)
● Poor (201-300)
● Very Poor (301-400)
● Severe (401-500)

Bus services disrupted as strike by DTC drivers enters Day 2, protest to continue

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 16

BUS SERVICES across the Capital were disrupted on Wednesday as drivers and conductors operating Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) buses went on a strike for the second consecutive day demanding higher wages. The strike is expected to continue on Thursday as the demands of the protesting drivers were not met.

As per the DTC Karamchari Ekta Union, drivers and conductors operating these buses are currently being paid Rs 862 as daily wage — the minimum wage fixed by the Delhi government — which, the union said, is typically meant for daily-wage labourers, factory workers or employees of small companies.

The union, in a statement, questioned whether paying



Parked DTC buses amid the protest on Wednesday. TASHI TOBYAL

qualified drivers and conductors Rs 862 to operate large buses in a crowded city like Delhi amounted to "bonded labour."

"The dearness allowance, revised every six months under revised, had not been increased in the last one-and-a-half years,

and the basic increment, due every five years, was last implemented in 2019, and has been due since 2024," said Lalit Chaudhary, president of the union. The union's main demands include a minimum daily wage of Rs 2,000 for equal

work, payment for all government holidays, an annual bonus, and social security including a medical scheme.

Transport Minister Pankaj Singh said, "We have directed the private concessioners managing the DTC electric buses to sort the issues with drivers immediately," Singh also appealed to the drivers to call off the strike.

Chaudhary said, "Currently no government representatives have reached out to us. Our strike is peaceful and we have decided not to drive buses."

In light of the strike, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said it had made arrangements on Wednesday to manage additional passenger footfall.

DMRC increased 20 train trips across its network on Wednesday. Further, DMRC said that the enhanced arrangements will continue on Thursday.

IHC Theatre Festival

September 18-27, 2026

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The Stein Auditorium, India Habitat Centre, Lodhi Road, New Delhi.

Fri, Sept 18, 7:00pm



DANCING WITH DAD

(English/90 mins)
Wri. & Dir. Maneesh Verma

A story of a loving father who prepares his neurodivergent son for a life of his own. Through theatre, movement, live music and projection, it unfolds the beautiful and tender journey of a father and son bound by love, learning to part.

Sat, Sept 19, 7:00pm



Sun, Sept 20, 7:00pm



Tue, Sept 22, 7:00pm



Wed, Sept 23, 7:00pm



Thu, Sept 24, 7:00pm



Fri, Sept 25, 7:00pm



Sat, Sept 26, 7:00pm



Sun, Sept 27, 7:00pm



BHASBHARATAM

(Hindi/110 mins)

Dir. Piyaal Bhattacharya
Prod. National School of Drama,
Sikkim Repertory Company

Based on Bhasa's plays- Pancharatnam, Dootvakyam, Karnabharam, Dutaghatotkacha, and Urubhangam - the production journeys through the defining moments of the Mahabharata: exile, peace, war, and redemption

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GROUND report

Pamphlets on the ground, reels on screen: DUSU poll campaign ends



Campaign underway ahead of the elections, on Wednesday. AMIT MEHRA

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, September 16

PARCHAS (PAMPHLETS) scattered the ground, slogans rang out and SUVs squeezed through the crowd outside DU's Faculty of Law as the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) poll campaign entered its final hours on Wednesday.

The campaign also played out somewhere else — on students' phone screens, where viral reels, follower counts and emotional narratives were fighting for the Gen Z vote.

Rattled by protests over paper leaks and the outrage after the Satya Niketan PG building collapse killed five DU students among seven, student groups had to rethink their campaigns this year. Yet the final day showed that while much of the campaign had moved online, how little the old ways had changed.

The ABVP released a video set to the fast-paced track 'DU Bole Dil Se, ABVP Fir Se (DU Speaks from the Heart, ABVP Once Again)'. With flash mobs, drone shots and rap beats in the background, it featured its panel: presidential candidate Yash Dabas, vice-presidential nominee Ishu Maurya, secretary nominee Riya Chawdhuri and joint secretary candidate Lakshay Raj Singh.

The NSUI took a very different approach. In a video shot on a phone, the parents of its Adivasi presidential candidate Vijay Shankar Meena appealed to students from outside their home at Laksh in Rajasthan's Dausa.

His father, leaning on a walking stick, sat beside his mother. "Up to now he was my son, but the moment he stepped into this election, he became the son of the sarv samaj (entire society)," he said.

Maheshmurti Leni S. Jadhav, Joint Secretary of the AICC research department and the DUSU NSUI panel in-charge, pointed to Meena's social media reach. "Look at Vijay Meena's Instagram... he has crossed over 80,000 followers, stretching far beyond DU, to across the country and even overseas," she said.

"Social media is playing a decisive role in how this generation decides to vote... The Gen Z voter is far more vocal and discerning. They question incumbents directly..."

The Left alliance of AISA and SFI also acknowledged the shift, though it said its main focus remained firmly rooted in traditional on-ground efforts. "There is definitely a shift in the air," said Sharanya Verma, the campaign in-charge for the alliance.

She said students were more willing this year to discuss issues such as rent and university-run hostels after the Satya Niketan building collapse.

"Earlier, students were largely cynical, assuming no wonder would ever change. This time, when we go class-to-class,



Security personnel deployed at DU North Campus on Wednesday. ANI

students don't just silently listen, they also ask questions... They ask why more hostels had not been built despite the same union being in power for years, and why they were paying Rs 20,000 for rooms sized like a matchbox," she added.

Verma, however, said the online conversation often looked different from what happened in a classroom, alleging that money, muscle and caste-based campaigning continued to shape the election.

Students will tell us, 'we saw your reel, we agree with your fight. But on the ground, money and muscle remain brazen. They walk into colleges and chant their caste names instead of discussing policy. We faced targeted intimidation every single day of this campaign... including a violent attack on our activist Saman at Sri Aurobindo College on September 3."

The Left questioned the exclusion of students from the 22 women's colleges from central DUSU voting, including students at Lady Shri Ram College, Gargi College and Jesus and Mary College. "Who is afraid of



Membership of student wing not association with political party: HC

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, September 16

THE DELHI High Court Wednesday held that mere membership of a student union, backed by a political party, would not be considered as an association with the party for contesting in the upcoming Delhi University Students Union (DUSU) elections.

A PIL moved before a division bench of Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia flagged violations of the Lingdoh Committee's recommendation and the DUSU Constitution, which recommended disassociation of student elections and representation from political parties. The Committee had made recommendations for free and fair campus elections following directions issued by the Supreme Court in 2006. The recommendations were implemented as guidelines for campus elections.

In the PIL, Vijeeta, a DU student, argued that the short-listed candidates are to be considered as members of political parties and directly governed by the ideology of those parties since "student wings are wings of political parties". The PIL sought that the upcoming DUSU elections be cancelled — which the court refused.

The PIL also referred to official announcements made by student outfits, including the SFI, ABVP and AISA, for the candidates being fielded by them. ASAP, the student wing of AAP, in its announcement, also branded the party name. "We find that a particular candidate is proclaiming his candidature to the post of president but also indicates his association with a political party. It also bears the election symbol given. Such activity needs to be checked by the university authorities and the Chief Election Officer," the court recorded.

The court asked the university authorities and the Chief Election Officer of DU to ensure that the polls are "free of interference and participation, even remotely, of persons associated with political parties".

On Wednesday, DU Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh directed colleges to keep security tight for the next three to four days, with night patrols until September 18 — when voting will take place — and a teacher appointed to coordinate with police.

women's votes?" Verma asked. Verma maintained that tokenism — like parties promoting symbolic representation such as NSUI's Adivasi presidential candidate — does little to change daily campus power dynamics if caste patronage networks are not dismantled. Student housing and safety remained common themes across manifestos this year. ABVP promised new hostels, separate girls' hostels and fire-safety audits. NSUI demanded strict implementation of rent-control measures, regular landlord inspections and a DU portal listing affordable PGs and rentals. AISA-SFI sought the Rent Control Act, college subsidies and at least two hostels per college, while ASAP called for "Hostels for All" and cheaper public transport.

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Kailash Hills murder: From across rooftop, couple saw neighbour kill domestic help

Their statement is part of a 340-page chargesheet filed in the murder case

Pragnesh
New Delhi, September 16

IT WAS July 18, around 10.45 am.

Like every morning, Vinay and Kamini, a couple in their 60s, were sitting across from each other in their ninth floor flat in a DDA society at Kailash Hills in South Delhi. They were looking out through the full glass wall of their room at their lush green neighbourhood.

They saw a man appearing on the terrace of a three-storey DDA building opposite. He had a knife in his hand. Soon, a woman arrived. The couple watched as the man suddenly went after the woman and stabbed her in the neck. Once, twice, three times — at least six times, they would later tell the police.

They knew the man. "He was Dr Manish Gupta, who was murdering his domestic help," said a police officer.

340-page chargesheet

What Vinay and Kamini saw that morning is now part of the 340-page chargesheet in the murder of Meena Halder (45), a domestic help who had worked for Manish's family for 16 years, police said. Their statement is among those of 42 witnesses cited by police in the case. So are bloodstained house slippers allegedly belonging to Manish.

Kailash Hills is an idyllic neighbourhood by all means — a slope from the main road leads into narrow lanes, mostly lined with grey residential buildings. Some have three-storey white DDA houses surrounded by greenery.

Block A is one such lane. Manish had been living on the top floor of one of these DDA buildings for 16 years. His family had earlier lived in Karol Bagh. His father, a government employee with the electricity department, died when Manish was about six. An only child, he was brought up by his mother, with the family relying on his father's pension.

"Manish's father had booked a DDA flat in Kailash Hills before his death. After Manish completed his MBBS, he opened a small clinic at his Karol Bagh house. But after getting married and having a child, the family finally moved to Kailash Hills," said an officer.

Family's first house help

Meena, then 29, was the first help the family hired. Manish's wife, Tina, an Ayurvedic doctor, would leave for her clinic in Lajpat Nagar at say, a 20% margin, this is a very minimal cost and they won't be much impacted," he said, adding that credit cards, which carry higher charges, are already used by traders.

The conversation allegedly started with Manish. Three-four months before the murder, police said, Manish began feeling that Meena did not respect him the way she respected his wife. In his statement to police, he allegedly said Meena would not listen



Outside the house of the accused doctor (left) Manish Gupta in Kailash Hills. FILE

when he asked her to do something. She would agree when Tina asked her.

"Tina said Manish had asked her to fire the house help about two months ago. She rejected it, but Manish never made a fuss about it. He never said anything to Meena either. Manish felt she was not cleaning the house properly," a senior officer said.

Morning of murder

On July 18, Manish returned from his daily walk at Lodhi Gardens, where he went by car at around 9 am, police said. Around 10.30 am, he was preparing his clinic, attached to the third floor house. Patients were expected to start arriving within about 30 minutes.

His son was inside his room, playing an online game with the door locked. "Manish asked Meena if she could just quickly clean the clinic, and she said she would do it in some time," an officer said.

This angered Manish, who saw it as another sign that he was not taken seriously by his help, police said.

A few minutes later, he allegedly found the clinic was still not clean. He then asked Meena to clean the storeroom on the terrace, where he waited for her, said police.

"As soon as she came up, she found Manish there. He took a bat and hit her on the head. A scuffle broke out, and Meena bit his middle finger," the officer said.

Meena ran and Manish followed. It was then that Vinay and Kamini, having their morning tea, saw the two figures running on the terrace.

"Kamini called Manish's neighbour — whom she was also friends with — and asked her to help Meena. Her friend ran to Manish's house with her two sons. Manish opened the door and told them that he had murdered Meena. He then himself took them to the rooftop," the officer said.

By then, Vimal had made the PCR call. When police arrived, they found Meena's body on the terrace, her head battered and blood running across the floor. The knife allegedly used in the killing had blades on both sides and an ornate handle. "Manish got it from a guard who about 14-15 years ago as a showpiece. It looked like a warrior knife," the officer said.

Police said Manish's initial claims about his "mental health" problems were not supported by the investigation. His medical examination, they said, found him to be of sound mind.

Non-banking financial firm duped of Rs 12.84 crore, 5 held

Alok Singh
New Delhi, September 16

THE DELHI Police's Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations (IFSO) unit on Wednesday said an interstate cybercrime syndicate, accused of siphoning off Rs 12.84 crore from the corporate bank account of Hero FinCorp Ltd, which offers loans facility, has been busted.

Officers said it is suspected that the company's internal server was hacked, following which around 317 unauthorised transactions were made. Five people, including a relationship manager of a private bank, have been arrested, they said.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (IFSO) Gaurav Tyagi said the accused allegedly carried

out 317 unauthorised digital transactions from the company's account and routed the money to 34 primary-layer bank accounts. The transactions allegedly took place without the knowledge or consent of the company's management.

"A case was registered on August 21 based on a complaint by Hero FinCorp Ltd, a non-banking financial company. An FIR was registered under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita sections 308 (for extortion), 318(4) (for cheating), 319 (for cheating by personation) and 340 (for forgery) at the Special Cell police station," the officer said.

Officers said that during the probe, the IFSO unit analysed bank account details, mobile phone records and the flow of

funds and managed to place a lien or hold on approximately Rs 17 crore, in various accounts, thereby preventing the further diversion of the money.

Raid was conducted at multiple locations across the country and subsequently arrested Abhay Kumar Solanki of Bulandshahr, Lovely of Kurukshetra, Naman Kumar of Jaipur, Harman of Bikaner and Vikas of Jaipur.

Police said Rs 60,000 was credited to Solanki's bank account and later withdrawn through an ATM. Lovely allegedly operated an account in the name of Property Gallery at the Central Bank of India's Thane branch, in which Rs 80 lakh was received. He had opened the account at the behest of one

Satyam of Haryana's Cheeka.

Naman allegedly operated accounts in the name of Infimetry Services at Yes Bank, Jaipur, and another IndusInd Bank account. Police said around Rs 40 lakh was credited to the Yes Bank account and around Rs 70 lakh to the IndusInd account. The second account, police said, was linked to 43 complaints registered on the National Cyber-crime Reporting Portal.

Chinese Telegram groups under scanner

Investigators alleged that Naman's IndusInd Bank account was operated by Harman who used an APK file. "Harman was allegedly in contact with several Chinese groups on Telegram and one Devender Singh

Chauhan of Udaipur. Chauhan converted the proceeds of the crime into Tether, a cryptocurrency linked to US dollars, and transferred it to fraudsters based abroad," the officer said.

Harman allegedly operated Naman account for a commission of around Rs 1.5 lakh from Chauhan, the officer added.

Vikas, a relationship manager with RBL Bank in Jaipur, allegedly assisted Naman in opening the bank accounts. He also reportedly introduced Naman to Harman. Police said suspects based in India and Dubai have also been identified and efforts to arrest them are on.

When The Indian Express reached out to Hero FinCorp Ltd, the firm declined to comment on the matter.

● MOVE LEVYING 0.4% FEE ON TRANSACTIONS OVER Rs 2,000 HAS LEFT TRADERS DIVIDED

UPI fee: Small hit for some, but bigger worry for traders on thin margins

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, September 16

AT A shop in Sadar Bazaar, the next time a customer flashes a phone to pay a bill of more than Rs 2,000, the trader may have to do a quick calculation: absorb the newly-imposed UPI fee or try to recover the cost from the customer.

The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) on Tuesday announced that UPI transactions over Rs 2,000 will attract a fee of 0.4% from October 15. Under the new system, it is the merchant who pays the

0.4% fee, not the customer directly. On a Rs 10,000 payment, the merchant would pay Rs 40.

This has left Delhi's traders divided. While some said the charge is too small to make much difference to their business, those operating on thin margins worry that even a small deduction could add up.

An e-commerce website, grocery shop or a shopkeeper, receiving more than Rs 1 lakh per month from customers paying through UPI are categorised as merchants.

Mukesh Jain, general secretary of the Main Sadar Bazaar

Traders Association, said the impact could be felt by both customers and shopkeepers. "Shopkeepers are already operating on such tight margins nowadays, this will eat into that also. As a result, they might increase prices and pass it on to the customer," said Jain, who owns a shop selling festive goods.

"When making a UPI payment above Rs 2,000, the shopkeeper will either automatically increase the price by 0.4% or even more or tell the customer to pay the amount above the bill," Jain added.



E-commerce sites or shopkeepers receiving over Rs 1 lakh a month from customers through UPI are categorised as merchants. FILE

The Finance Ministry, however, has said banks have been "advised" to ensure that merchants do not pass on the cost to customers.

Further, he pointed out that due to UPI, more transactions were being recorded and kept on the books. "This might change that," he said.

But not every trader expects the fee to make much difference.

New Delhi Trader's Association president Atul Bhargava said that while smaller shopkeepers operating on thin margins could be affected, the im-

pact would be limited for bigger traders.

"For bigger traders and shopkeepers who are operating at say, a 20% margin, this is a very minimal cost and they won't be much impacted," he said, adding that credit cards, which carry higher charges, are already used by traders.

But not every trader expects the fee to make much difference. New Delhi Trader's Association president Atul Bhargava said that while smaller shopkeepers operating on thin margins could be affected, the im-

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INDIA'S developmental journey is entering a new phase, one that goes beyond expanding access and building infrastructure towards strengthening economic capabilities, technological capacity and India's position in the world. At the core of this next chapter is the vision of Viksit Bharat @2047, the ambition to transform India into a developed nation by the centenary of Independence.

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi turns 76 today, the focus goes beyond the reforms and initiatives of the past decade to the larger national ambition they seek to advance. From digital payments, modern infrastructure, manufacturing, entrepreneurship, social welfare, and India's growing global influence, the last decade has sought to build the foundations for this larger ambition. The task ahead is to accelerate this progress, create wider opportunities, take technology to the last mile and ensure that every section of society contributes to and benefits from India's growth towards 2047.

From modest beginning to a national vision

Born in Vadnagar, Gujarat, Narendra Modi's early years were shaped by a modest upbringing and an early exposure to the aspirations and everyday challenges of ordinary citizens. His years in public life, including his tenure as Gujarat's Chief Minister, brought a growing focus on governance, infrastructure, investment and development. In 2014, he assumed office as the Prime Minister, beginning a new phase of policy and governance centred on economic growth, social inclusion and institutional reform. Over the following years, this agenda expanded from individual programmes and reforms to a broader national ambition — building a more self-reliant, capable and confident India with its sights set on Viksit Bharat @2047.

The journey from policy to purpose

With Narendra Modi assuming office in 2014, the focus shifted towards accelerating growth, improving governance and expanding opportunities for ordinary citizens. Over the years, that agenda has rightfully expanded in scale and ambition.

Certain reforms like the Goods and Services Tax sought to create a more integrated national market, while initiatives such as Make in India, Startup India, Skill India and the Production Linked Incentive schemes sought to strengthen manufacturing, entrepreneurship and employment. The objective was not simply to increase economic activity, but to create the foundations for a nation that could compete with the world.

The next phase is centred on Viksit Bharat @2047, a broader national ambition that brings together economic strength, technological capability, social inclusion, human capital and strategic resilience. The Union Budget 2026-27 has further reinforced this direction, positioning economic growth, structural reforms, infrastructure, manufacturing, MSMEs, innovation and youth-led capacity building as important pillars of the journey towards Viksit Bharat.



Decades of Governance and the path to 2047

Technology powered self-reliance

India's digital transformation has emerged as a powerful enabler of economic participation and inclusive growth. Digital India, Aadhaar-enabled services, UPI, DigitalLocker and other components of the Digital Public Infrastructure have reshaped how citizens interact with government services and the wider economy.

What began as an effort to expand digital access has evolved into a platform connecting small businesses, street vendors, entrepreneurs and consumers to formal financial and digital systems. The next phase is reflected in NITI Aayog's DPI@2047 roadmap, which envisages taking digital public infrastructure beyond identity, payments and welfare delivery towards productivity, livelihoods, market access

and inclusive prosperity.

This digital transformation is complemented by a strong push towards economic and strategic self-reliance. Initiatives such as Make in India and the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes have placed manufacturing at the centre of the national economic strategy, with sectors such as electronics, semiconductors, defence, pharmaceuticals and renewable energy gaining strategic importance.

The focus on critical technologies and resilient supply chains is aimed at strengthening domestic capabilities while creating opportunities for investment, innovation and employment. Self-reliance, in this context, is not isolation, but the ability to participate in the global economy from a position of greater strength and confidence.

Empowering citizens to drive India's progress

In tandem with his focus on economic growth, Modi launched extensive social programs and major welfare initiatives designed to lift millions out of poverty. Over the years, initiatives such as Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, Ujjwala Yojana, Har Ghar Jal, Ayushman Bharat and Swachh Bharat Abhiyan have sought to strengthen access to housing, clean cooking fuel, drinking water, healthcare and sanitation. The rural development framework has also evolved and entered a new phase with the Viksit Bharat -

From inclusive growth to technological advancement and a stronger global voice, the nation's development journey enters a new phase under Prime Minister Modi's vision for 2047.



Warmest Birthday Wishes from TDI Group

TDI Group extends its heartfelt wishes to Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji on his 76th birthday, along with sincere appreciation for a journey that has strengthened India's confidence in its own potential. His contribution to infrastructure, connectivity and economic development has created foundations that will continue to influence the country's growth for years to come. TDI Group is privileged to witness how these changes are shaping cities, communities and new opportunities. We remain committed to contributing to this larger journey by building spaces and communities that complement India's progress. May he be blessed with good health, happiness, and renewed energy, and may his vision continue to inspire India towards a stronger, more prosperous, and developed future.

RAVINDER TANEJA
Chairman, TDI Group



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ADVERTORIAL



Birthday Greetings

TO THE HON'BLE PRIME MINISTER SHRI NARENDRA MODI Ji

On the occasion of the birthday of the Hon'ble Prime Minister **Shri Narendra Modi Ji**, the leadership, doctors, and staff of Kalra Hospital extend their warmest wishes and deepest respects. His vision for an accessible, self-reliant, and technologically advanced Bharat continues to inspire institutions like ours to serve the nation with integrity and compassion.

— Dr. R.N. Kalra, Dr. Ankit Kalra & Dr. Ankur Kalra, Kalra Hospital

Viksit Bharat & Healthcare : Building the Architecture of a Healthy Nation

Kalra Hospital — Over 50 years of pioneering cardiovascular excellence, accessible medicine, and nation-building from the heart of Delhi.

IN 1990, when specialized cardiovascular care in India was an exclusive privilege reserved for the elite or reachable only by travelling abroad, a young and resolute clinician named Dr. R.N. Kalra opened a modest 25-bed clinical setup in Kirti Nagar, West Delhi. Having trained and practiced at R.M.L. Hospital's Faculty of Medicine and Cardiology before starting independent consulting practice in the early 1980s, he had already seen, at close quarters, families turned away or forced into ruinous private care simply because specialised cardiac treatment was scarce. He resolved to build something different: an institution where clinical expertise and personal integrity would never be

traded off against each other.

That resolve has held for over five decades. What began as a single clinic has grown into Kalra Hospital SRNC Pvt. Ltd. — a multi-specialty tertiary care referral centre with a bed strength that has grown from 25 to roughly 250 across its flagship campus in Kirti Nagar and satellite branches in Dwarka Mor and Najafgarh. The hospital was among the first in the city to import modular operation theatres and emergency support systems from Germany, and today runs dedicated adult and paediatric intensive care units under a central monitoring system, a technically advanced cardiac operating room, advanced labour and delivery

suites, and a drive-in casualty unit built for split-second emergency response. It is empanelled with schemes such as ECHS, reflecting a deliberate choice to stay accessible to service families, pensioners, and middle-income households rather than positioning itself purely as a premium destination. As the nation marks the birthday of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji on 17th September, Kalra Hospital re-dedicates its service to the health, longevity, and vitality of every Indian citizen it serves.

Three generations, one mission. The hospital's leadership today reflects a rare continuity of purpose across generations. Dr. R.N. Kalra, Founder, Medical Director and CEO,



has spent over 50 years at the bedside — often working 16-hour days — and carries a long list of recognitions for his contribution to medicine and community service, including a Fellowship of the Royal College of Physicians, Glasgow (2006), the Meritorious Services Award from the Chief Minister of Delhi (2003), and honours from the Ministry of Health, the Indian Medical Association, and several international bodies. He also serves as CEO of the Indian Heart Foundation, the hos-

pital's corporate social responsibility arm running free heart check-up and blood donation camps across Delhi. Dr. Ankit Kalra, Consultant in Cardiology and Director, has led the build-out of the hospital's preventive cardiology and non-invasive diagnostic wings, with a particular focus on young-adult cardiac wellness and faster emergency protocols. Dr. Ankur Kalra carries the family's clinical tradition onto the international stage — an interventional cardiologist trained through fellowships at Beth Israel Deaconess Medical Center, Harvard Medical School, and Methodist Hospital, Houston, he currently serves as Division Chief of Cardiology at SUNY Upstate Medical University in

New York, following earlier academic appointments at the Cleveland Clinic and Indiana University. In 2026, he was named a recipient of the SCAI-Edwards Lifesciences Early Career Research Grant for his research on long-term survival after transcatheter aortic valve replacement, and he continues to serve as director of the Barry J. Maron Hypertrophic Cardiomyopathy Center in New Delhi, host of the widely followed cardiology podcast Parallax, and founder of the non-profit makeadent.org, which works to advance cardiovascular health globally. It is this combination — deep local roots and genuine global academic standing — that the family believes sets Kalra Hospital apart.

INTERVIEW

Dr. Kalra, five decades ago, specialized cardiology in Delhi was virtually non-existent for the common man. What inspired you to establish Kalra Hospital in 1990?

Dr. R.N. Kalra: When I entered practice in the 1980s and early 1981, I witnessed a heart-wrenching reality — ordinary families were suffering or losing loved ones simply because specialised cardiac care was scarce and prohibitively expensive. If a patient needed serious cardiac evaluation, they either had to wait indefinitely in crowded public wards or spend a fortune travelling overseas. I believed then, as I do now, that every second counts in a heart emergency, and every citizen deserves access to top-tier care right in their neighbourhood. We started small in Kirti Nagar with just 25 beds. The initial years demanded immense sacrifice and long hours, but the demand for honest, empathetic care was overwhelming. That humble facility grew organically into a multi-specialty institution because patients trusted that we put their well-being above everything else.

Healthcare has transitioned into a highly commercialized, tech-driven industry. How has Kalra Hospital preserved its soul and human touch despite these industry shifts?

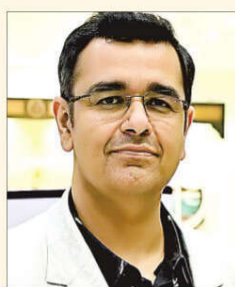
Dr. R.N. Kalra: Technology is a wonderful servant, but a terrible master. At Kalra Hospital, over 80% of our staff have been with us for five, ten, fifteen, or even twenty-five years. That longevity creates a family environment, not a corporate factory. When a patient walks through our doors, they aren't processed as a file number; they are received with warmth and empathy. We have always maintained a strict policy of ethical medicine. During the second wave of COVID-19, when hospital beds were scarce across the country, we expanded our capacity, procured independent oxygen lines, and treated thousands of patients. Most importantly, we enforced a zero-tolerance policy against price-gouging. We did not raise our rates or exploit vulnerable families. Honesty is the true backbone of

Dr. Ankit, with your extensive background across world-renowned medical centres, how do you see the intersection of global academic standards and local clinical care unfolding at Kalra Hospital?

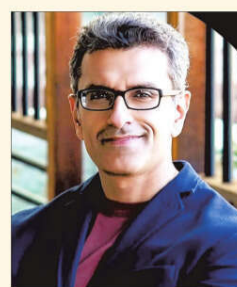
Dr. Ankit Kalra: The trend of young adults — in their late twenties, thirties, and forties — presenting



Dr. R.N. Kalra
Founder, Medical Director and CEO



Dr. Ankit Kalra
Consultant - Cardiology, MBBS, MD, DNB,
Director - Kalra Hospital



Dr. Ankur Kalra (MD)
Cardiologist at the Cleveland Clinic & University
professor at the Cleveland Clinic

with acute coronary syndromes is one of the most pressing health challenges in urban India today. The causes are multi-faceted: high mental stress, sedentary work culture, poor dietary choices, lack of physical movement, smoking, disrupted sleep cycles, and a genetic predisposition to metabolic syndromes that many Indian families carry without realising it. To counter this, we have shifted heavy emphasis toward structured preventive cardiology. Catching hypertension, dyslipidaemia, or early arterial changes before they result in a catastrophic cardiac event is vital. We encourage young professionals to undergo annual cardiac screenings, monitor their blood pressure, and make lifestyle adjustments early. Primary prevention is always more effective, and far less traumatic for a family, than emergency intervention.

Dr. Ankur, with your extensive background across world-renowned medical centres, how do you see the intersection of global academic standards and local clinical care unfolding at Kalra Hospital?

Dr. Ankur Kalra: The gap between global healthcare standards and top-tier Indian clinical care has

closed rapidly over the last decade. What we practice in leading institutions internationally — whether transcatheter structural heart interventions, evidence-based quality protocols, or patient safety frameworks — can absolutely be implemented right here in Delhi. My own work, including our current research into long-term outcomes after transcatheter aortic valve replacement, is really about the same question applied at scale: how do we make sure a patient's outcome depends on the quality of evidence behind their treatment, not their postal code. When high-level academic rigour meets the deep empathy my father established, the patient receives world-class outcomes right in their local community, whether that's through the hypertrophic cardiomyopathy programme we run in Delhi or the broader cardiology work I lead in the United States.

Today marks the birthday of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji. How do you view his administration's national health initiatives, and how do private institutions fit into this vision?

Dr. R.N. Kalra: Prime Minister Narendra Modi Ji

has brought structural healthcare reform to the centre of national governance. Programmes like Ayushman Bharat, the expansion of digital health ecosystems, and the establishment of new medical infrastructure across the country demonstrate a deep commitment to national well-being. For a health ecosystem to function effectively, public infrastructure and ethical private institutions must work in tandem. While primary health centres manage early detection, tertiary units like ours stand ready to handle complex surgical interventions, emergency cardiac catheterisation, and critical care. By aligning ethical private practice with national health goals, we can ensure that high-quality medical care reaches every stratum of society, not just those who can travel or pay for it abroad.

What is the roadmap for Kalra Hospital as you look toward the coming decade?

Dr. Ankit Kalra: We are expanding our technological capabilities while deepening our community footprint. We are actively integrating advanced non-invasive imaging, modular surgical infrastructure, and digital patient monitoring tools that enable continuous, real-time oversight

of critical patients — the kind of infrastructure that used to be available only in a handful of large corporate hospitals.

Dr. Ankur Kalra: At the same time, we are exploring futuristic avenues like robotic-assisted cardiovascular procedures and specialised heart failure clinics, informed by the research and clinical protocols we're developing internationally. However, our expansion will always be measured and patient-centric. We are not building an impersonal corporate chain; we are scaling a trusted institution where clinical excellence, academic precision, and genuine compassion remain paramount.

Beyond the wards, the hospital's community work has quietly continued in the background for decades through the Indian Heart Foundation, its CSR arm, which runs free cardiac screening and blood donation camps across Delhi's neighbourhoods — the kind of preventive outreach that rarely makes headlines but catches problems long before they become emergencies. It's a fitting complement to the family's belief that a hospital's real impact is measured as much by the crises it helps a community avoid as by the ones it treats.

Conclusion

From a 25-bed clinic in 1990 to a multi-specialty cardiac destination spanning Kirti Nagar, Dwarka Mor, and Najafgarh, Kalra Hospital's journey traces the arc of Indian private healthcare itself — from scarcity to self-reliance, and from imported technology to home-grown research that now feeds back into the global conversation on cardiovascular care. What has held constant through that arc is a founding conviction that never wavered even during the darkest days of the pandemic: that medicine, first and foremost, is a trust between doctor and patient, not a transaction. With Dr. R.N. Kalra's decades of bedside experience, Dr. Ankit Kalra's focus on prevention and emergency readiness, and Dr. Ankur Kalra's international research bringing fresh evidence back home, the hospital enters its next chapter with the same intent it started with in 1972 — accessible, ethical, and genuinely world-class care for every Indian who walks through its doors. As the country moves toward a stronger, healthier future under national programmes aimed at exactly this goal, institutions like Kalra Hospital remain quiet but essential pillars of that progress.

BIRTHDAY WISHES

ON behalf of Delhi Book Store and the entire DBS Group family, I extend my heartfelt wishes to our Hon'ble **Prime Minister, Shri Narendra Modi Ji**, on his birthday. Your leadership, vision and determination have strengthened India's global standing and accelerated its journey towards a self-reliant and progressive Bharat. The spirit of Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas continues to shape an inclusive growth story, with transformative initiatives across education, healthcare, technology, infrastructure and entrepreneurship.

Many congratulations to Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji on the success of Brics Summit 2026.

At DBS Group, we particularly appreciate your emphasis on knowledge, innovation and youth empowerment. Initiatives such as Digital India, Skill India and the vision of Viksit Bharat resonate with our commitment to making knowledge and learning accessible to all. We believe an educated, informed, and skilled society is the foundation of a strong nation. On this special occasion, we wish you continued good health, happiness, and a long life. May your leadership continue to guide India towards greater prosperity, unity and global prominence.

Vijay Ahuja, Managing Director, DBS Group

Delhi Book Store:

Building a knowledge-driven India, one book at a time

From a humble beginning to a trusted knowledge destination, DBS continues to bring authentic books closer to readers across disciplines.

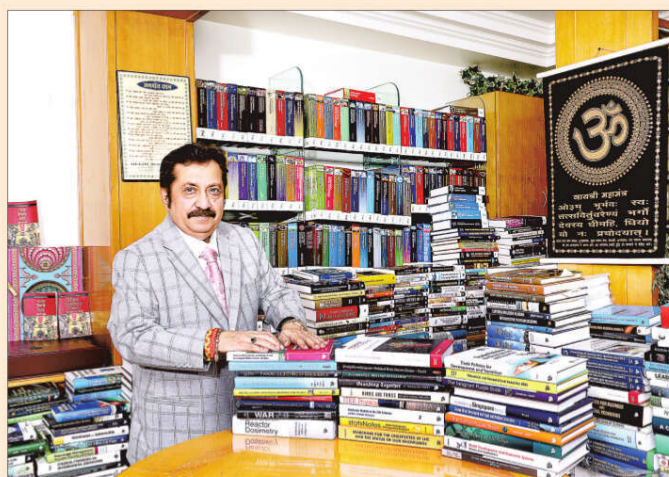
In 1947, when India gained its independence, a young man named Jeevan Kumar began a modest journey in Delhi with little more than medical books, determination and a bicycle. Traveling on foot and by bicycle, he supplied books to students and doctors, laying the foundation for what would eventually become Delhi Book Store (DBS). Presently, DBS is Asia's largest showroom of medical books and one of India's most trusted destinations for medical and non-medical titles. As it continues to evolve with the changing world of education and knowledge, we spoke with Vijay Ahuja, Managing Director, DBS Group, about the institution's journey, its enduring values and its vision for the future.

DBS has evolved considerably since its modest beginnings in 1947. Could you take us back to the early years?

The modest journey began in 1947 when my father, Jeevan Kumar Ahuja, moved his family from Dera Ghazi Khan to Delhi. He started by personally taking medical books to young medical students and doctors, travelling on foot and by bicycle. The response was overwhelming, which encouraged him to establish a small shop at Nai Sarak in Old Delhi. This little shop became an important resource for medical students, doctors, teachers and libraries not just in Delhi but across India and neighbouring countries. Over time, the store flourished and grew as a trusted name in the world of books.

Medical books remain at the heart of DBS. What sets your collection apart today?

Our strength has always lain in the breadth and authenticity of our collection. Today,



Vijay Ahuja, Managing Director, DBS Group

the Daryaganj showroom spans around 20,000 square feet across five floors and houses approximately 200,000 titles. The collection covers virtually every major specialisation, including Anaesthesia, Cardiology, Ultrasound, Surgery, Obstetrics & Gynaecology, Radiology, Orthopaedics, Oncology, Haematology, Ophthalmology, ENT, Laboratory Sciences, Nursing, Dentistry, Veterinary Science and Pharmacy, among others. Whether it's for students, doctors, or institutions, DBS is a one-stop destination for all.

DBS has built a strong presence beyond medicine. How important is this wider portfolio to the group?

Our vision has always been larger than one discipline. We have substantial collec-

tions across Science & Technology, Humanities, Social Sciences and General books. The objective is to be the bookstore of choice for doctors, engineers, technocrats, corporates, scientists, academics, students, and scholars.

After nearly seven decades, how has DBS kept pace with changing consumer and industry needs?

For us, quality and service are our core values. While we honour our heritage, we have also embraced modern distribution methods. Presently, DBS operates two modern high-rise facilities with over 20,000 square feet of working area. Our experienced personnel assist customers, and our customer service team looks after numerous calls and emails daily to ensure a



Prateek Ahuja, CEO

seamless supply chain. We supply books not only across India but to institutions and individuals worldwide.

DBS remains a family-led institution. How has the next generation contributed to its evolution?

Family continuity plays an important role in DBS's journey. After my father, I took the initiative to expand and modernise the business. Currently, my son Prateek Ahuja, our CEO, brings a global perspective derived from his studies pursued in the U.K. Together, we combine tradition with innovation to keep DBS at the forefront of the book industry.

Your philosophy is summed up in the belief that "Books inspire, books motivate, books build nations." Why does this continue to be relevant?

We believe books are more than mere products; they are instruments of learning and transformation. They enhance reality, shape minds, and safeguard democracy. Every child of Bharat has the desire to transform India into a vishvaguru, and books are central to that journey. Therefore, we have devoted our lives to making knowledge accessible.

ABOUT DELHI BOOK STORE (DBS)



Founded in 1947 by Jeevan Kumar Ahuja, Delhi Book Store began as a humble initiative to make medical books accessible to students and doctors. Under the leadership of Vijay Ahuja, Managing Director of DBS Group, and Prateek Ahuja, CEO, DBS has grown into Asia's largest showroom of medical books with a strong presence in non-medical disciplines as well. The five-floor Daryaganj showroom in Delhi offers an extensive selection spanning Medicine, Science & Technology, Humanities, Social Sciences and General subjects. Backed by modern infrastructure and distribution capabilities, DBS serves individual readers, professionals and institutions across India and worldwide.

ON TRADITION MEETS INNOVATION:

"We started on a bicycle in 1947 carrying books on foot. Today, we manage over 200,000 active titles with digital distribution, matching India's digital revolution step-for-step."

— Vijay Ahuja

ON YOUTH & GLOBAL STANDARDS:

"Indian minds are competing on the global stage. Our commitment at DBS is to bring global knowledge home while exporting Indian intellectual genius to the rest of the world."

— Prateek Ahuja

ON LIFELONG INVESTMENT:

"Spend time on books; they pay lifelong dividends to individuals and compound value for the entire nation."

— Vijay Ahuja

ON THE VISION OF BHARAT:

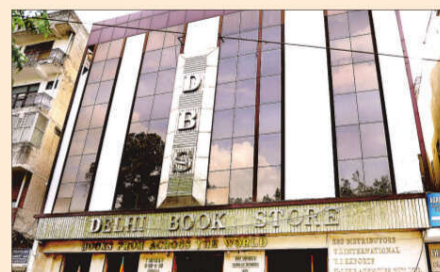
"When a nation invests in knowledge infrastructure, it transforms its youth into global leaders. Books are not mere printed paper; they are the bedrock of Viksit Bharat."

— Vijay Ahuja

ON ARCHITECTING KNOWLEDGE:

"Prime Minister Modi's vision of 'Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas' is fueled by educational empowerment. We see our duty as providing every researcher, doctor, and technocrat the intellectual tools to innovate."

— Prateek Ahuja



As education, healthcare and technology continue to evolve, what does the next chapter look like for DBS?

We see DBS continuing to strengthen its position as one of India's and Asia's most trusted destinations for authentic books across disciplines. As education, healthcare and technology evolve, the demand for credible, current and specialised knowledge will only grow. With our infrastructure, expertise, and longstanding values, DBS is well placed to serve this evolving need and embark on the next chapter of its journey.

LEGENDS IN

ADVERTORIAL

Healthcare

Aatmanirbharta in Healthcare: The Key to Viksit Bharat 2047

From one patient's struggle to a new generation of Indian healthcare technology

There are moments in a surgeon's life that never leave you.

For me, one of those moments came in 2012, when a 22-year-old woman with a congenital hole between the chambers of her heart came to me. She was an ideal candidate for robotic surgery. Her brother told me that she was worried a large scar from conventional surgery might affect her chances of getting married.

I offered to perform the surgery without charging my own fee. But the hospital costs were still around 74 lakh, and the family could not afford them.

Her brother tried to raise the money. A month later, he called to say he was still struggling. I never heard from him again.

I often think about that young woman. Because that was the moment when robotic surgery changed from a technology into a responsibility towards my motherland, India.

I had spent decades building my career as a cardiac surgeon in the United States. When I returned to India in 2011, I bought a Da Vinci surgical system myself because I believed Indian patients deserved access to the same advances I had seen transform surgery abroad.

But I quickly discovered that the technology was simply too expensive to scale in a country like India.

I began asking myself a question that has guided much of my life since: **If technology can transform a patient's life, why should access to it depend on where that patient lives or what that patient can afford?**

That question took me from being a surgeon to becoming an entrepreneur and, by necessity, a student of engineering and innovation.

Building what India did not have
When we began, there was no established surgical robotics ecosystem in India.

I started SS Innovations, now SS Innovations International, Inc. (SSI), with a small group of engineers. At one point, around ten of them were working from my home. I invested my own savings, borrowed money and sold my car and furniture. During Covid, when funding disappeared, we continued anyway. There were times when even giving salaries became difficult, and members of our team were willing to make sacrifices because they believed in what we were trying to build, a vision for a greater India.

We were not trying to make a cheaper robot. We wanted to create something genuinely Indian, designed around the needs of our surgeons, our hospitals and our patients, while being capable of competing with the best systems in the world.

That journey resulted in the SSI Mantra. Made in India, for the World.

Today, the system has moved far beyond its beginnings. As of September 2026, the SSI Mantra had reached 238 installations globally, with more than 15,000 procedures performed and approximately 1,500 physicians trained. The platform is now being used across 12 countries. For me, however, the most important number is not the number of robots. It is where those robots are going and whom they are reaching.

A large part of our Indian footprint is outside the traditional metropolitan centres, including Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities where advanced robotic surgery was once impossible to access. We are also working with government and medical institutions, because I believe that if indigenous technology is truly going to democratise healthcare, it cannot remain confined to premium private hospitals. After all, healthcare is not a privilege but a right of all.

This belief led us to develop SSI MantraM, our mobile telesurgery unit, a bus designed to take advanced robotic surgery and surgical expertise beyond the walls of major urban hospitals. It can travel to remote locations across the country, connecting surgeons and specialists through a high-speed fibre-optic network and enabling telesurgery, training and clinical collaboration. We have taken MantraM to medical colleges and hospitals across India, including government institutions, allowing surgeons and students to experience, train on and engage with the technology.

This is what I mean when I talk about democratising robotic surgery. We are not trying to build technology for a few centres of excellence. We are trying to create a network in which ad-



There are innovation stories that begin with a business plan and a venture capital cheque, and there are innovation stories that begin with a young woman's brother walking away because he couldn't afford 4 lakh rupees for her heart surgery. **Dr. Sudhir Srivastava's** story belongs to the second kind.

A cardiac surgeon who built one of the most decorated robotic heart surgery careers in the United States, **Dr. Srivastava** returned to India in 2011 carrying a conviction that advanced surgical technology should reach far more patients than could ever afford it. What followed was not a smooth commercial rollout but a fourteen-year act of personal conviction: a mortgaged car, sold furniture, a decade of self-funding running past Rs. 500 crore, a global pandemic that wiped out early fundraising, and eventually SSI Mantra, a Made-in-India surgical robotic system, and its dramatically upgraded successor, SSI Mantra 3, engineered in an almost unbelievable five months. Today, that journey has grown into SS Innovations International, a Nasdaq-listed company working to make advanced robotic surgery affordable and accessible for all.



vanced surgical capability can progressively reach more cities, more hospitals, more surgeons and, ultimately, more patients. That is what Aatmanirbhara Bharat should mean in healthcare.

Self-reliance means creating, not merely consuming

India has achieved extraordinary success in pharmaceuticals, vaccines, space technology and digital infrastructure. Yet medical devices remain an area where we continue to depend significantly on imports.

The issue is larger than the trade balance. In advanced medical technology, dependence can affect cost, maintenance, upgrades, spare parts, software, training and the long-term ability to support technology across thousands of hospitals.

The Covid years reminded us that strategic supply chains cannot always be taken for granted.

If we want a resilient healthcare system, we must build strategic capabilities here.

I do not believe Aatmanirbhara means shutting ourselves off from the world. It means having the confidence and capability to stand on our own.

This is also why I deeply appreciate the clarity with which Prime Minister Narendra Modi has articulated the idea of Aatmanirbhara Bharat and connected it to the larger ambition of Viksit Bharat 2047. His call for India to move from being a market for the world to becoming a hub of innovation has particular meaning for those of us building complex technologies here.

For innovators, this vision is both an opportunity and a responsibility. The Prime Minister has consistently encouraged Indian scientists, engineers and entrepreneurs to take on challenges that were once considered beyond our capabilities. That encouragement matters. It creates the confidence to attempt what has not been attempted before and to believe that technologies conceived in India can stand alongside the best in the world.

I believe healthcare must be an important part of that journey.

For years, India has been seen primarily as a large market for technologies developed elsewhere or a dumping ground of obsolete technologies in the name of refurbished machinery. I want to see that perception change.

India should not be known only as the purchaser of advanced technology. It should increasingly be known as the inventor, engineer and exporter of it. Our journey is one example of what that can look like.

In April 2025, SS Innovations International Inc. began trading on Nasdaq under the symbol SSI. For me, that moment carried significance beyond a financial milestone. A technology platform conceived and engineered in India was now standing on one of the world's most prominent global capital markets.

The ambition must now be to take more Indian technologies into the world.

We should not become a dumping ground for yesterday's technology

There is another conversation we need to have honestly if India is serious about building indigenous medical technology: the growing market for refurbished high-end medical equipment.

Let me be clear. I am not against refurbished equipment. Properly refurbished technology can have a legitimate role in healthcare, particularly when it is safe, appropriately certified, transparently priced and supported through its original intended lifecycle. Further, there may be an occasional situation when such technology is not available or manufactured in India.

Sophisticated medical technology cannot be treated like second-hand consumer electronics.

A surgical robot is not simply a machine that is purchased, installed and used. It is a clinical ecosystem. Its safety depends on the condition of its hardware, the reliability of its software, the availability of instruments and spare parts, cybersecurity, maintenance, upgrades, technical support and, ultimately, the ability to stand behind the technology when a patient's life depends on it.

This becomes even more important when we consider what India is trying to build. Also a patient should be given a right to know what technology he or she is getting operated on with and whether it is obsolete in the country of origin!

An Indian company developing a complex medical device invests significant financial resources, years in engineering, clinical validation, regulatory compliance, manufacturing capability and human capital. If, at the same time, India creates a market where older imported systems can enter primarily because their initial acquisition price is lower, we risk creating the wrong economic incentives.

The issue is not old versus new.

It is short-term acquisition cost versus long-term national capability.

If India wants indigenous medical technology to become more affordable, we need to allow Indian manufacturers to achieve scale. If we want scale, we need demand. If we create demand, component manufacturers, engineers, service networks, training institutions and research capabilities grow around that demand.

This is how an ecosystem becomes self-reliant.

The Government has recognised that refurbished medical devices require careful consideration and, in 2026, constituted a committee to examine their regulation, including safety, performance and remaining useful life.

I welcome that conversation because the answer should not be to shut the door on refurbished technology. It should be to establish a framework that gives hospitals and patients confidence about what they are buying and getting operated on, how long it can safely be used, who is responsible for maintaining it and whether the technology remains clinically supported.

Most importantly, India should ensure that the economics of healthcare do not uninten-

tionally make it easier to import yesterday's technology than to build tomorrow's technology here.

We have spent decades being one of the world's largest markets for medical technology. The next chapter should be different.

We should become one of the world's important creators of it.

Making distance irrelevant
One of India's greatest healthcare challenges is the uneven distribution of expertise.

We have exceptional surgeons and hospitals, but they are not distributed evenly across the country. A patient in a smaller city may have a hospital nearby but not the specialist required for a complex procedure.

For decades, our answer has been to move the patient.

Telesurgery gives us the possibility of moving the expertise instead.

We first demonstrated this in India through robotic cardiac telesurgery between Gurugram and Jaipur. Since then, the distances have significantly disappeared. On December 23, 2025, a group of 9 renowned experts within India performed 24 Multi-specialty Telesurgeries including Cardiac Surgeries on patients scattered across India. They got the best care in their hometowns without travelling to large metropolitan cities.

In May 2026, we collaborated with Guyana as it launched its National Robotic Surgery Programme. Using the SSI Mantra and the compact SSI MantraAsana tele-surgeon console, I performed a cardiac procedure remotely between Guyana and a patient in India across approximately 20,000 kilometres of fibre-network distance. At the time, it was the world's longest-distance robotic telesurgery.

The significance of Guyana went beyond a world record.

It demonstrated how an Indian-developed platform can become part of another country's healthcare infrastructure. Guyana is not simply buying a machine. It is building capability, training clinicians and creating a new model of access to advanced surgery.

Then, in July, we pushed the boundary further. A robotic telesurgery between Colombia and India crossed more than 22,000 kilometres of network distance, eclipsing our previous record.

The record matters because it proves what is technically possible.

But the real objective is much simpler.

A patient should not have to travel thousands of kilometres merely because the expertise they need is somewhere else.

Taking the operating room to the patient
Telesurgery is only one part of this vision.

If expertise can travel digitally, why should the physical infrastructure of surgery always re-

main fixed?

That question led us to MantraM, our mobile telesurgery unit. The idea is straightforward: take advanced robotic surgical capability closer to underserved communities while also creating a platform for training, demonstrations and remote surgical collaboration.

In 2025, MantraM completed its first robotic telesurgery, with a hysterectomy guided remotely from the mobile unit to an operating room in Bhopal. The unit has since travelled to medical colleges, hospitals and underserved communities across India.

It represents an idea I feel strongly about.

The future of surgery should not always require the patient to travel to the technology. Sometimes the technology should travel to the patient.

The same principle is now being taken into more specialised areas.

Our SSI Mantra platform uses 5 mm instruments that enable delicate procedures in smaller patients. In August this year, an SSI Mantra system was used to perform robotic pyeloplasty on a 45-day-old baby in Coimbatore. The infant recovered rapidly after the complex minimally-invasive kidney procedure. By the end of August, 258 paediatric robotic procedures had been completed using the platform.

For me, that is more meaningful than any record.

When a 45-day-old child can benefit from technology engineered in India, the argument for indigenous innovation becomes deeply human.

From healthcare technology to national capability

The philosophy behind this work also extends beyond conventional hospitals.

Project Operation explores how mobile surgical infrastructure can bring advanced operating capability into remote and difficult environments. Project Vimana takes the idea further, exploring a drone-enabled trauma surgery system designed to reach casualties where conventional access may be difficult.

The applications could extend from disaster response to remote healthcare and defence.

I am particularly interested in what this could eventually mean for battlefield medicine.

A wounded soldier may not always be able to reach a major hospital quickly enough. If technology can take surgical capability to the casualty and connect that capability to an expert surgeon elsewhere, we can begin to rethink what the golden hour means.

These are technologies under development, not substitutes for today's established systems. But they represent an important direction for Indian innovation.

We should be building technologies not only for the problems we have today, but for the problems India and the world will face tomorrow.

We need an ecosystem, not just a robot
One of the greatest lessons of the last fourteen

years is that building the machine is only the beginning.

We need surgeons who can use it, engineers who understand clinical requirements, biomedical technicians who can maintain it, hospitals willing to adopt it, reliable connectivity for telesurgery, training institutions, clinical research, component manufacturers and regulatory frameworks that protect patients while enabling innovation.

This is where I believe India's next phase of development will be decided.

We have exceptional doctors. We have world-class engineers. We have a young population, a large domestic healthcare market and an increasingly sophisticated manufacturing base.

What we need is to connect these strengths. We need to create an environment in which an Indian company can take a difficult idea from a laboratory, through clinical validation, into manufacturing and eventually into hospitals around the world.

We need to make it possible for young Indian engineers to believe that they can work on technologies that are not merely assembled here but conceived here.

And we need to make sure that our best innovations have the opportunity to achieve the scale required to become affordable.

The India we must build
When I look back at the journey from that 22-year-old patient to the systems we are building today, I do not see it simply as the story of one company.

I see it as a small example of what India can accomplish when necessity, talent and conviction come together.

We began with ten engineers working from a home.

We now have an Indian-developed robotic platform being used across countries and continents.

We have performed over 700 cardiac surgeries. We have taken robotic technology into paediatric surgery. We have built a mobile surgical platform. We are exploring how robotic surgery can move into disaster response and defence. And an Indian healthcare technology company now trades on Nasdaq. We have done telesurgeries across the globe.

But I do not see these achievements as the destination.

I see them as evidence that India can create. That matters because Viksit Bharat 2047 cannot be defined only by the size of our economy, the scale of our infrastructure or the sophistication of our cities.

It must also be defined by the confidence we give every citizen.

The confidence that where you live will not determine the quality of treatment you receive.

The confidence that advanced technology can be affordable.

The State and Central Government should provide insurance coverage through various State or National Ayushman Scheme for Robotic Surgeries to avoid two or three tier healthcare system. It should become mandatory for private insurances to provide coverage for Robotic surgeries.

The confidence that an Indian surgeon can work with technology designed and built in India. And the confidence that when the world confronts a difficult problem, when the world always ask, **"Who can we import the solution from?"**

We will increasingly ask: **"Can we build the solution here?"**

"I believe we can."

This is the spirit behind the Prime Minister's vision of Viksit Bharat and Aatmanirbhara Bharat - an India confident in its own capabilities, willing to innovate, build and contribute to the world. I feel privileged to play my small part in that larger national journey.

And I believe the India we build over the next two decades should not merely be a consumer of the world's best technology.

It should be one of the countries creating that technology, exporting it, improving it and making it accessible to millions who were once excluded from it.

That is the India I came home to build. An India where innovation crosses borders. An India where expertise reaches the patient. And an India confident enough to tell the world, not only that we can use the future, but that we can invent it.

That is when India will truly attain Aatmanirbharta in healthcare. That is when we'll truly be on the way to Viksit Bharat 2047 and become Vishwaguru!



The Editorial Page

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 17, 2026

The Indian EXPRESS
- FOUNDED BY -
RAMNATH GOENKA
IN 1932
BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Students need a safe home. That's DU's duty

THE SATYA NIKETAN tragedy has brought much-needed attention to accommodation for Delhi University (DU) students. The figures underline the scale of the problem: Around 70,000 students are enrolled in DU's undergraduate programmes every year, and its PG courses have more than 10,000 seats. While the university's hostels have 3,422 seats, the colleges affiliated to it have 3,788 seats. Many of these students come from outside the city, and it's clear that DU's hostel network cannot accommodate them. The result is a vast dependence on private paying-guest facilities and rented accommodation, often in densely packed neighbourhoods with unsafe conditions close to university campuses. For outstation students, the soaring accommodation costs offset DU's affordable tuition fees. Seven months after assuming office, the university's vice chancellor announced plans to build two 1,000-bed hostels near North Campus. But as an investigation in this paper shows, the VC begins a second term next month, the projects remain held up by funding constraints, space crunch, land-use restrictions and administrative hurdles.

The immediate priority must be to expand safe and affordable hostel accommodation, while also recognising that the gap is too large to be bridged by construction projects initiated by the university alone. In the Delhi government, DU and its colleges have rarely come together to devise solutions that treat student housing as part of the university's essential infrastructure. Delhi's master plans have allowed property owners to adapt their houses to provide student accommodation, provided they adhere to safety norms. In practice, these caveats were flouted. At the same time, DU hasn't shown much initiative to engage with the private accommodation market around its campuses. Options such as a university-maintained database of accommodation, with information on location, occupancy, and compliance with basic safety standards, were never explored.

After the Satya Niketan tragedy, Delhi's Chief Minister has called for a survey to identify colleges with sufficient space for hostel construction. These units will be built via public-private partnership, and the Delhi CM has promised that the government will ensure students' safety. These are steps in the right direction, but the government needs to do more. For starters, it needs to nudge the colleges to look at out-of-the-box solutions drawing in entrepreneurs by pooling the colleges' unused parcels of land into hostel sites. A student life in Delhi helps many youngsters spend their savings. As the brother of one of the victims of the Satya Niketan incident told this paper, "he loved the city". The best tribute to those who lost their lives last week would be to end the lack of imagination and political will that denies people like them a safe home in the city.

A small fee, a stronger UPI

THE NATIONAL Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has announced that UPI transactions over Rs 2,000 will attract a fee of 0.4 per cent from October 15. Called the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), the fee, capped at Rs 300 per transaction, applies only to person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions. The Union Ministry of Finance has stated that banks have been "advised" to ensure merchants — e-commerce websites, grocery shops or shopkeepers, receiving more than Rs 1 lakh per month from customers paying through UPI — do not pass on the cost to customers. It has also been clarified that for certain categories of transactions — such as UPI payments received for rail tickets, fuel and agricultural inputs, credit card dues, telecom or utility bills, insurance premiums, and tax payments — a flat merchant fee of Rs 5 will be charged from merchants. There are several reasons why this decision should be welcomed.

These changes follow the passage of the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Act, 2026 last month, which built on the recommendations of the 32nd report of the Standing Committee on Finance. The report had noted that "the absence of MDR makes the UPI ecosystem financially unsustainable". The MDR is the fee paid to the bank or payment service provider for processing digital transactions, and crores of transactions take place each year. In 2025-26, for instance, there were more than 24,000 crore UPI transactions, and their total value was Rs 314 lakh crore. UPI was introduced in 2016 with an MDR. The zero-MDR policy was adopted in 2020 to expand the adoption of digital transactions. The balanced approach in the latest shift will ensure a sustainable revenue flow to invest, while also enabling seamless digital payments for a large section of people — this could lead to greater reach.

The decision has attracted some criticism. The main Opposition party, for instance, has claimed the move will hurt consumers, especially the poor ones. Such criticism is unfounded. More than 95 per cent of UPI transactions are below the Rs 2,000 threshold. The changes do not apply to person-to-person transactions, and critical public services will have a flat fee. There is an MDR on credit card as well. Allowing these changes will ensure more competition in the marketplace and better service delivery.

A gambit for Gukesh, and for India

ADAY before India began its Chess Olympiad campaign in Samarkand, captain Srinath Narayanan played his biggest gambit: Gukesh D would play on board 4, the final board. It's unprecedented for a reigning world champion to play on board 4. At the previous two Olympiads, Gukesh was on board 1, where he had delivered individual goals. The board order is more than a matter of prestige at the Olympiad: Board 1 is usually reserved for a country's top players, which ensures they play the cream of other nations. Does Narayanan's choice indicate that the team management lacks faith in the 20-year-old after his slump since becoming the world champion? He has gone from being the World No. 5 in December 2024 with a rating of 2783 to currently being the World No. 31, rated 2703. In his last tournament, the Chennai Grandmasters, he did not win a single match. By his own admission, his Achilles' heel is going for risky moves which, when a player is low on confidence, can backfire.

India not playing Gukesh on the top boards might actually work in the reigning world champion's favour. Getting to face weaker players over 11 rounds at the Olympiad could be the best way for him to gain back confidence in time for the world crown defence. He can take risks, like his style demands, and not be made to pay by opponents — the equivalent of an Indian cricketer going back to play the Ranji Trophy to get some runs under his belt. It just might be a gambit that helps India retain the gold.



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

THE PARADOX of Indian civilisation has always been the contradiction between our intellectual radicalism and our social orthodoxy. For millennia, the Subcontinent was a laboratory of boundless metaphysical inquiry, where the foundational texts of the Indic tradition openly questioned the origins of the universe, and where heterodox sceptics, materialists, and spiritual iconoclasts debated without fear of a Spanish-style Inquisition. Hindus have no concept of heresy because we did not fear the destabilising power of an idea. Yet, in modern India, this heritage of intellectual fearlessness is being systematically stifled by the misuse of a legal relic that elevates the fragile feelings of the mob over the fundamental rights of the individual. This is Section 295A of the Indian Penal Code, now re-codified as Section 299 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

Introduced by the British in 1927 in the turbulence of the "Rangela Rasooli" controversy (a provocative Urdu pamphlet satirising the Prophet Muhammad's personal life had sparked widespread communal riots), Section 295A was ostensibly designed to preserve public order by penalising deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings. It was born out of a colonial urge to police Indian subjects deemed too volatile to handle the friction of free and provocative speech. The British

have abolished their own blasphemy law, but we not only retain this colonial instrument under Article 19(2) of our Constitution, which permits speech restrictions in the interests of public order, but have allowed it to metastasise into the single most potent weapon against creative and intellectual freedom in our democracy.

By translating the deeply subjective and volatile concept of "emotional hurt" into a cognisable, non-bailable criminal offence, Section 299 of the BNS effectively grants a permanent "heckler's veto" to the most intolerant, reactionary segments of our society. It creates a perverse incentive for outrage by elevating "the right to be offended" above the right to free speech. Political entrepreneurs, religious zealots, and competitive vigilante groups quickly realise that the easiest path to public relevance is to claim that their sentiments have been wounded. All it takes is one aggrieved individual to file a First Information Report (FIR) in a remote corner of the country, and the machinery of the state is instantly triggered against a writer, a filmmaker, a stand-up comedian, or a publisher — for speech that a court will often find, years later, was never malicious at all.

The alarming phenomenon of cultural self-censorship in India is starkly illustrated by the corporate capitulation of major publishers, fearful of falling afoul of BNS 299. This trend was dramatically underscored when Penguin Books India chose to withdraw distribution of Joe Sacco's graphic novel on the Muzaffargarh riots, echoing its earlier decision to pulp copies of Wendy Doniger's *The Hindus*, and then anxiously asked for cuts to Sonia Gandhi's memoirs. Its signal was not considered necessary in the international edition. Because none of these texts was legally proscribed, these were pre-emptive surrenders,

normalising a cowardly calculus where commercial risk-aversion replaces constitutional principle, leaving the Indian reader culturally deprived.

The tragedy of BNS 299 lies in the grueling, punitive nature of the legal process itself. The law allows arrest before a trial can even establish whether malice existed. For an artist or an author, being dragged through a labyrinth of multi-city court appearances, facing jail time and enduring financial ruin, is a punishment designed to break the spirit. The inevitable consequence is a pervasive, suffocating culture of fear. When the cost of creative expression is the potential loss of personal liberty, the vast majority of creators naturally choose to pull their punches. Publishers refuse or trim sensitive manuscripts, galleries pull provocative paintings, studios quietly cancel scripts, and academics choose safer, sterile research topics. We are left with a public square sanitised of radical honesty, reduced to a bland conformity that is entirely unworthy of India's intellectual lineage.

In his landmark 2008 Delhi High Court judgment quashing criminal proceedings against the self-exiled maestro MF Husain, Justice Sanjay Kishan Kaul delivered a magnificent, definitive defence of artistic liberty against the creeping tides of intolerance. Opening the ruling with a quote from Pablo Picasso ("Art is never chaste... Where it is chaste, it is not art"), Justice Kaul meticulously dismantled the obscenity and blasphemy charges by contextualising Husain's abstract, nude depiction of Bharat Mata within India's rich, four-millennia-old heritage of sacred, pluralistic, and erotic iconography. From Khajuraho to Konark, sternly critiquing the "new puritanism" being waged by self-appointed guardians of cultural purity, the judgment warned that

allowing a closed mind to restrict our open society would push India backward. By affirming that one disapproving viewer cannot hold the rights to restrict free expression, Justice Kaul established a vital constitutional shield for creative dissent and intellectual fearlessness.

This constitutional scrutiny should move to the front of the process. Prior government sanction should be required before an FIR under BNS 299 is even registered, not after the accused has already endured an investigation and a chargesheet. Equally, multiple FIRs on the same subject, lodged in different states, should immediately be consolidated into a single proceeding. BNS 299 cases should be fast-tracked to quash frivolous proceedings. And vexatious complainants should face costs or other punitive consequences, so that the incentive structure of BNS 299 is reversed, rather than reinforced.

Those who weaponise BNS 299 to defend faith are, in reality, insulting the very traditions they claim to protect. The great Indic philosophies were forged through intense, unsparring contestation. Our texts are filled with purvapaksha, the meticulous formulation of an opponent's viewpoint, followed by rigorous logical refutation. The gods and sages of Indian antiquity were argued and bargained with, and frequently satisfied. To suggest that an ancient, resilient civilisation is damaged by an artist painting a provocative image, or a novelist writing a satirical line, is an act of shameful civilisational self-doubt.

If we seek a Viskit Bharat confident in reason and genuinely open to the future, our proud civilisation does not require the protective custody of a police inspector. It is time to curb the misuse of BNS 299.

The writer is a fourth-term Congress MP from Thiruvananthapuram

Those who weaponise BNS 299 to defend faith are, in reality, insulting the very traditions they claim to protect. The great Indic philosophies were forged through intense, unsparring contestation

Thorny inter-state disputes are giving way to dialogue, progress



HIMANTA BISWA SARMA

AS NARENDRA MODI completes 25 years as the head of a government — first as Chief Minister of Gujarat and for over a decade as Prime Minister of India — one conviction has remained constant. "India cannot advance without all its states advancing in tandem. States and the Centre must work together to forge a model of cooperative federalism, resolve differences, and chart a common course to progress and prosperity." PM Modi said this at the first meeting of the NTI Aayog Governing Council in February 2015. It is a vision he has carried since his days as Gujarat CM, and one he has entrusted, as PM, to Union Home Minister Amit Shah to translate into reality. Over the last few months, the Union Home Ministry has formalised memoranda of understanding that resolve some of India's oldest inter-state disputes.

The first was the tripartite MoU between the Centre, my state of Assam, and Nagaland, signed on June 11. The second, among Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Haryana, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Delhi, revived the long-stalled Kishau Multipurpose Dam Project after an eight-year deadlock. The third, between Rajasthan and Haryana, ended a 32-year wait to operationalise the 1994 Upper Yamuna Basin agreement. The fourth, among Maharashtra, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan, was a one-time settlement of decades-pending dues under the Narmada Award. Most recently, Bihar and Jharkhand signed a pact ending a 25-year dispute over the Sone River. Within the same framework, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana have agreed to finally resolve their pending division of assets and liabilities.

As Gujarat's longest-serving chief minister, most of it under a Congress-led Centre, he saw firsthand how inter-state and Centre-state disagreements can stall welfare works

and Union government tripartite MoU. This agreement had eluded three governments for three decades. At stake was a belt of more than 1,000 square km straddling the Assam-Nagaland border, where domestic oil exploration had been effectively frozen because of a poorly demarcated, ambiguous boundary finalised in 1963. Committed to the PM's agenda of an *atmanirbhar* Bharat, Amit Shah j reframed the issue. Under his guidance, Assam and Nagaland agreed on a 50:50 split of hydrocarbon revenue, irrespective of how the ongoing boundary resolution efforts conclude.

This is not an isolated agreement: The Bodo Peace Accord, the Karbi Anglong settlement, the Assam-Meghalaya boundary agreement, the Assam-Arunachal Pradesh border resolution, and the Frontier Nagaland arrangement addressing the decades-old Eastern Nagas demand for separate administrative recognition. This rapid succession of peace accords and MoUs in the Northeast is finally yielding dividends in building a secure *Ashtakshmi* — a region once familiar with insurgency is now 80 per cent free of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act.

These agreements are a reminder of what steady, patient leadership can achieve. Disputes that outlasted governments of every hue, that were allowed to fester because resolving them seemed politically inconvenient, are today being settled not through grand gestures but through the unglamorous, persistent work of dialogue.

This is the hallmark of PM Modi's leadership. A refusal to accept that any problem is too old or too complicated to be solved, and an unwavering belief that a strong, united India is built by strengthening its states, not by centralising at their expense. As the nation looks ahead to the goal of a Viskit Bharat by 2047, it does so with the confidence that comes from 25 years of proof that when the Centre and the states work as one, even the most stubborn of disputes give way to progress. That is the true and lasting message of the Modi story.

A case in point is the Assam, Nagaland

The writer is Chief Minister of Assam



AFTAB ALAM

TWO RECENT editorials — "At BRICS, the value of keeping difficult conversations alive" (*IE*, September 12) and "At BRICS, more than a triumph of diplomacy" (*IE*, September 14) — make a persuasive case for BRICS as a useful forum for dialogue and diplomacy. But they set too low a bar for judging the grouping at a time when the international order is undergoing profound change.

At the heart of their argument is the idea that, despite its internal differences and competing interests, BRICS remains a useful instrument of diplomacy in a fragmented world. Its expanded membership strengthens the Global South's voice and creates greater scope for economic cooperation. It also brings together countries with competing interests, making BRICS a useful forum for keeping diplomatic channels open on difficult geopolitical questions while making conscious efforts to avoid being seen as an explicitly anti-Western or anti-American alignment.

But this optimism should not obscure the harder realities of international politics. States use multilateral forums to advance their interests, manage vulnerabilities and respond to shifts in power. What matters is whether dialogue can help resolve disputes, moderate conflicts, produce meaningful cooperation and contribute to a more stable, rules-based international order. John Mearsheimer argues that international institutions do not transcend power politics; they largely reflect the distribution of power and the interests of the states that use them. BRICS may be less an independent force shaping international politics than a forum through which states respond to changing configurations of power and pursue converging interests.

The bonhomie between Narendra Modi and Xi Jinping, following years of border tensions and Xi's first visit to India since 2019, should not be seen simply as a triumph of BRICS diplomacy. India and China have strategic reasons to reduce tensions amid Donald Trump's attempt to weaponise tariffs. The rapprochement may give both greater room for manoeuvre in dealing with the US, without requiring either to appear confrontational.

The larger question is what BRICS seeks to achieve beyond providing its members with a forum for dialogue and diplomatic options. The New Delhi Declaration is clear about the shortcomings of the existing order — unilateral sanctions, coercive measures, protectionism, tariffs and the unequal representation of developing countries in global institutions — but offers little indication of how these can be addressed. Even its call for reform of global institutions leaves unanswered the question of how such reform can be achieved. As G. John Ikenberry suggests, the present moment may be less about the collapse of the US-led liberal international order than a struggle over its future shape, authority and leadership. BRICS has yet to articulate what that future might look like politically, economically and institutionally.

The writer is dean, Faculty of International Studies, AMU

40 YEARS AGO September 17, 1986



BSF to continue combing

THE CENTRE has directed the BSF to continue its operations against intruders from Pakistan and to shoot them if they do not respond when challenged. The fresh directions were issued to remove doubts about the role of the BSF guarding the India-Pakistan border in Punjab following the killing of 10 Sikh youths who intruded in the Dera Baba Nanak sector of Gurdaspur district on August 30. The youths "alleged" to make the intruders clear when a BSF patrol challenged them.

Shiv Sena leader, Nihang shot

TERRORISTS in Punjab, after lying low for

a brief period, struck again, killing two persons, including a Hindu Shiv Sena leader, and injuring at least five others in separate incidents. Vijay Mahan, vice chairman of the Phillaur unit of the Shiv Sena, was fatally wounded by scooter-borne terrorists in the morning. A call for a bandh in Phillaur has been given by the Punjab Shiv Sena president, Rama Kant Jalota, to protest against the killing.

Horror in Bombay's KEM

HIGHLY DECOMPOSED flesh and bones were fished out of a potable water tank of the King Edward Memorial (KEM) Hospital in Bombay. Hospital employees said that it was difficult to say whether the flesh was

of an animal or a human baby. The police said that a *prima facie* it looked like animal flesh, but added that expert opinion was awaited. The flesh and bones have been sent to the police surgeon for analysis.

Army to help control floods

TROOPS WERE called out in Pharenda and Maharajganj tehsils of Gorakhpur district in Uttar Pradesh and east and west Champaran districts of Bihar, to help the civil authorities control the worsening flood situation. According to reports received in New Delhi, scores of villages were submerged by floodwaters even as the flood situation in other parts of Uttar Pradesh showed considerable improvement.



The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, SEPTEMBER 17, 2020

11

Along the coasts and in the sea, the dawn of a sunrise sector



C P RADHAKRISHNAN

WHAT THE OTHERS SAY
Israel's answer to 'NAZA' should be an investigation, not intimidation.
—Haaretz, Israel

THE LEADERSHIP of Prime Minister Narendra Modi has ensured that Bharat's growth story is always *sabka saath, sabka vikas, sabka vishwas, sabka prayas*. In the past 25 years, he has touched the lives of crores of people, especially those belonging to the weaker and disadvantaged sections.

Referring to backward districts as "Aspirational Districts", border villages as "Vibrant and First Villages" and the Northeast as *Ash-takshmi* reflects a transformative approach that has transformed geographical marginalisation into empowerment.

Another major step towards ensuring inclusive growth has been our focus on the Blue Economy. In the 1960s, with the Green Revolution, we tackled the problem of acute hunger. Bharat today ranks among the top global producers of rice, wheat, pulses, and millets, reinforcing its role in global food security. The White Revolution ended India's chronic milk shortage and dependence on imported dairy products. Bharat is now the world's No. 1 milk-producing country and, as a result, protein deficiency has drastically reduced, especially among children.

The Blue Revolution is set to be another success story. Nature has blessed our country with more than 11,000 km of coastline. We have a rich maritime tradition. We have an Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) extending over nearly 24 lakh square km. Bharat has a large amount of marine wealth. Yet much of this potential remained untapped for decades. Most of our fishing activity remained close to the shore. Today, we are ready to look beyond the horizon. The deep waters of our EEZ and the high seas present immense opportunities for sustainable harvesting of high-value fish such as tuna.

In 2019, with the creation of the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, the fisheries sector got a ministry of its



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

own for the first time. PM Modi had said that the blue *chakra* in our national flag represents the potential of the Blue Revolution and the ocean economy.

In the past decade, India's fisheries and aquaculture sector has emerged as a sunrise sector. Bharat is now the second largest fish-producing country, contributing around 8 per cent to global fish production. The sector supports the livelihoods of nearly 3 crore fishermen and fish farmers and contributes significantly to food security and nutrition. India's fish production reached more than 195 lakh tonnes in 2024-25.

Recently attended two events organised by the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying. One was the national launch programme for promoting sustainable harvesting of fisheries in the high seas and providing letters of authorisation to Indian-flagged vessels in Odisha. The second was the fisheries outreach programme in Lakshadweep. In Odisha, I was pleased to inaugurate the initiative taken by the ministry. It reflected the collective resolve of the Union government, the state government, our institutions, and our fishing communities to move towards a new era of growth, sustainability and prosperity in marine fisheries. When I

Deep-sea and high-seas fisheries can create employment not only in harvesting, but also in processing, cold chain, transportation, packaging, logistics and export services

visited Lakshadweep last month on my first official visit as Vice President, I was extremely pleased to note that many fisheries development projects have been approved for Lakshadweep under the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana.

The Union Budget 2025-26 recognised the untapped potential of the deep waters of our EEZ and announced an enabling framework for sustainable harnessing of fisheries from the EEZ and the high seas. This progressive framework enables our fishermen to venture confidently into these new frontiers. I am particularly happy that the new framework places our fishermen at its centre. The Fisheries Rules for the EEZ and the Guidelines for Fisheries in the High Seas in 2025 mark a new beginning for Mother Bharat. It gives priority to issuing letters of authorisation to fisheries co-operatives, Fish Farmer Producer Organisations and Indian fishermen. Lakshadweep, with a land area of about 32 square km, has nearly 145 km of coastline, a lagoon area of about 4,200 square km, territorial waters extending over 20,000 square km and an Exclusive Economic Zone of about 4 lakh square km. It alone accounts for nearly one-sixth of India's EEZ. This is our true maritime strength, which sends out a

powerful message. When individuals work alone, they do make progress, but when they work together as a team, they create a transformation.

India's seafood today reaches more than 120 countries. During the last financial year alone, our exports touched an impressive figure of more than Rs 73,000 crore, an increase of over 140 per cent since 2013-2014. The world has developed confidence and belief in the quality of Indian seafood. Digital authorisation systems, vessel tracking, international certification, and other steps will help Indian seafood command even greater respect in premium global markets. However, as we pursue growth, we must never forget our responsibility towards nature. The sea has nourished humanity for thousands of years. It is our sacred duty to preserve it for thousands of years to come. Sustainable fishing is a moral responsibility. The new guidelines are a positive step in this direction. They rightly emphasise compliance with conservation measures and a firm stand against illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing.

Deep-sea and high-seas fisheries can create employment not only in harvesting, but also in processing, cold chain, transportation, packaging, logistics and export services. It can create opportunities for our youth. It can provide greater participation for women in processing and value addition of coastal India.

As we move towards Viksit Bharat @ 2047, we are committed to making the Blue Economy inclusive and sustainable. In this journey of the Blue Revolution, each sector has a job to do. Our fishing communities will power India's Blue Economy. I am glad that the Fisheries Ministry, under the leadership of PM Modi, is making significant strides towards a new era of growth, sustainability and prosperity.

I urge the youth to view fishing not as an inherited occupation alone but as a modern profession driven by science, technology, innovation and global opportunity. I urge our institutions to continue supporting our fishing community with knowledge, technology and finance. So let us move forward with confidence, and together build a stronger coastal Mother Bharat.

The writer is Vice President of India

The 80-20 game is making us all losers



MEHBOOBA MUFTI

THE ORDINARY Indian is increasingly becoming the casualty of collapsing governance. An ambulance cannot reach a hospital. A father cannot get his dying child to a dispensary. Students are crushed beneath the roofs of unsafe buildings. A minor is sexually assaulted inside a moving bus. A mosque is demolished. A girl's hijab is forcibly removed. The Satya Niketan tragedy in Delhi. The brutal rape and murder in 2012 shook the conscience of the entire nation. People poured out on the streets. The political establishment was brought to its knees. Today, when several rape cases are being reported every hour, the country barely stirs. That should frighten us.

The most dangerous consequence of the normalisation of violence is not merely that violence has become frequent. It seems that society somehow doesn't feel shocked by it. Deaths caused by collapsing buildings, broken roads, administrative negligence and violence against women become just another headline. Anyone who dares to speak out can be branded "anti-national" or "anti-Hindu". In some cases, dissent itself becomes a crime, and those who question authority are turned into social outcasts.

This speaks volumes about the plight of the so-called 80 per cent majority, which has been driven towards the politics of religion, identity and manufactured confrontation.

This brings us to the other 20 per cent and the recent demolition of a mosque in Saharanpur. It was not an isolated controversy. Under the Yogi Adityanath government, several mosques and Muslim religious structures have faced demolition, or official scrutiny over allegations of unauthorised construction or encroachment. What is striking this time, however, is the Muslim community's response. Instead of allowing anger to spill onto the streets, prominent organisations from the community have emphasised constitutional remedies, legal recourse and communal peace. The Jamiat's position is particularly significant. Its message has been to knock on every available door of the law rather than allow the issue to become a communal confrontation.

That is a significant political shift. Muslims are beginning to understand that even peaceful protests can be turned against them, providing an opportunity for arrests, police action and communal polarisation. The experience of recent years has taught them that being reactive can carry a heavy price. From arrests linked to public prayers to the prolonged incarceration of activists such as Umar Khalid and Sharief Imam, the lesson being absorbed is simple. Do not provide those seeking polarisation with the confrontation they need.

The same maturity was visible in West Bengal when Muslim clerics and community organisations appealed to Muslims to avoid cow sacrifice during Eid ul Adha and opt for other animals instead. Some even called for a boycott of cow slaughter and suggested that the cow be declared India's national animal. The irony was remarkable. The Hindu cattle traders reportedly began protesting because the reduced demand was affecting their livelihoods. The political script had been reversed. Muslims were exercising restraint while Hindu traders were demanding the restoration of an economic activity.

This is being proactive — avoid unnecessary confrontation and deny communal politics the oxygen of conflict.

Muslim clerics could similarly encourage Muslims to avoid offering *namaz* on public roads. Prayer deserves dignity and cleanliness while public roads should remain accessible to everyone. Such voluntary restraint would remove yet another pretext for harassment and communal mobilisation.

But if Muslims are learning to respond differently, the majority, 80 per cent, is becoming so numb that it has given up on demanding accountability for the failures of governance.

Is this the road map to Viksit Bharat 2047? A developed India cannot be built by dividing citizens, rendering them deaf to suffering, blind to injustice and silent in the face of governmental failures. Nor can dissent be buried while accountability disappears. The real danger is not simply that India will remain divided into 80 and 20. It is that while the 20 per cent learns to navigate the politics of polarisation, the 80 per cent remains silent as governance itself collapses around them. And when that happens, the victims will no longer be Hindu or Muslim. They will simply be the losers of the 80-20 game.

Ultimately, the politics that promises the 80 per cent protection from the 20 per cent is not protecting anyone. It is preaching to the majority to mistake communal dominance for security while leaving the minority to survive through caution, compromise and legal endurance. The result is a devastating blow to the progress and secular fabric of our country. The politicians may win the 80-20 game, but it is making losers of us all.

The writer is former chief minister of Jammu and Kashmir



LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Evacuation and rescue

HIMALAYAN DISASTERS do not respect political boundaries, so preparations to deal with them cannot be confined to individual states or countries ("Don't let borders blind us to Himalayan risks", *IE*, September 16). India, Nepal, Bhutan and regional partners should share rainfall, river-flow and landslide data in real time and establish common early-warning protocols. Infrastructure projects in fragile terrain also require cumulative impact assessments. Local communities must be trained for evacuation and rescue. A coordinated regional mechanism could save lives while balancing development with the Himalayas' ecological limits.

Abhinav Barathi, Chennai

Freedom to innovate

UNIVERSITIES CANNOT build lasting academic credibility through administrative control alone ("West Bengal's wrong path to academic excellence", *IE*, September 16). Filling faculty vacancies, ensuring predictable funding and protecting institutional autonomy matter more. Recruitment should be transparent, merit-based and insulated from short-term political considerations. Universities also need stronger research support, modern laboratories and partnerships with industry and international institutions.

Sakunthala, Coimbatore

Protect options

INDIA'S ENGAGEMENT with multiple groupings offers diplomatic room, but it also demands careful prioritisation ("After BRICS, it's time to navigate the realities of great power rivalries", *IE*, September 16). New Delhi should focus on arrangements that deliver gains in trade, technology, energy security and strategic autonomy. Dialogue with competing powers must continue, even during disagreements. A pragmatic foreign policy, based on interests rather than camps, can help India protect its options in an increasingly fragmented international order.

S.M. Jeeva, Chennai



KAUSHIK DAS GUPTA

AMONG BENGALIS, who can obsess endlessly about gastronomy, few subjects evoke as much passion as *hilsa*. The Padma loyalist swears that the fish from Bangladesh is fatter and more fragrant. The Ganga partisan will insist that the fish from the river has a sharper flavour, a more elusive aroma and a pedigree that an imported fish cannot quite match.

But an upstart seems to be complicating the argument. Over the past two months, around 500 tonnes of hilsa have crossed into Bangladesh, much of it from Gujarat. The Gujarati fish is reportedly especially attractive to Bangladeshi buyers because of its high roe content; some of the roe is being processed separately, while the remaining will be dried for domestic consumption.

The *hilsa* could perhaps be having the last laugh. It has crossed rivers, borders and culinary loyalties with much less fuss than the people who make it a cultural totem. Behind all the talk of the hilsa's pedigree, there is a rather more quotidian truth: People eat what is readily available. And trade is an enabler.

The hilsa is a fish of the wider Indian Ocean. Its range stretches from the Bay of Bengal to the coasts and estuaries of the Arabian Sea. Travel south and west from Bengal and the *hilsa* acquires other names and other cultural lives. On the Godavari it is the *pulasa*; on the Indus, the fish becomes *palla*. The fish moves between the sea and rivers, entering different river systems to spawn.

Today, the Sindhi claim on the silver-scaled fish is perhaps less written about. But the Indus hilsa too is a delicacy, a livelihood and a marker of regional identity

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a footnote, a specimen behind glass. It stands in both at once, a little strange in each, and makes the reader walk out to meet it.

That is not a translation strategy. It is a way of living, and she picked it early. We have a poor word for people who live this way. Between, we use it to mean not-quite-between. Between, between homes, between flights. It smells faintly of the departure lounge. For Kushi Dyson, between was not a waiting room. It was an address.

She was born in Kolkata on June 26, 1940, into a household where Rudin, Chekhov, Boshu Dey, Ajit Dutta and Sudhinidhar Dutta were Abani Mohan Kushi's friends and literature was what the adults were doing in the next room. She never had to be taught that books mattered. She saw what English was doing to the languages around it. She called it cultural politics, and she was

sharp about the Bengali version of the affliction: The accomplished English speaker proud of being bad at Bengali.

Her response was to learn Spanish. While writing *In My Blossoming Flower Garden* she taught herself Spanish, and found that Sanskrit was unexpectedly useful for it. "The more languages you know," she said, "the more enjoyable the game becomes." Game. Not battle, not defence, not heritage preservation. Game. When languages are handled mainly as flags, that noun is nearly seductive.

Cultural confidence, she demonstrated over six decades, does not require quarantine. You can know English to its bones and not lose Bengali

The writer is senior associate editor, The Indian Express. kaushik.dasgupta@expressindia.com

Ketaki Kushari Dyson and the art of living in between



BUJETRI PATHAK

IN 1958, a Presidency College student sat for an English literature paper at Calcutta University and did something slightly unusual. Writing about poetry, she reached for Jibanananda Das. *Amrita surya*, she rendered: Nectar sun. She took a record mark. The essay went into Sukumar Banerjee's undergraduate textbook. And Ketaki Kushari Dyson, 18 years old, had already assembled the method she would spend the next 67 years refining. Enter another language. Do not leave your own at the door. "Nectar sun" does not tame Jibanananda into something an English reader can swallow without noticing. Nor does it strand *amrita* in italics with

sharp about the Bengali version of the affliction: The accomplished English speaker proud of being bad at Bengali.

Her response was to learn Spanish. While writing *In My Blossoming Flower Garden* she taught herself Spanish, and found that Sanskrit was unexpectedly useful for it. "The more languages you know," she said, "the more enjoyable the game becomes." Game. Not battle, not defence, not heritage preservation. Game. When languages are handled mainly as flags, that noun is nearly seductive.

The same refusal runs through her fiction. *Noton Noton Paryayagati* takes up the inheritance of the 1970s women's movement through women by turns vulnerable, funny, independent, compromised and muttonous. Margaret Thatcher's Britain is in it, and students moving from the Middle East into Europe. The intimate and the international share a room. Her scholarship did the same by other means. *Rabindranath o Victoria Ocampo o Sandhu* is a long look at what two cultures can do when neither is required to kneel. With Sushobhan Adhikari, she went into Tagore's paintings and traced how his colour changed. She was always drawn to the seam where one form gives way to another.

Ten years ago, at the Kolkata Literary Meet, she said there was no reason not to accept Indian English as a distinct variety. We

are having that argument again. English is the language of the interview and the visa; the mother tongue is produced as evidence of authority. Cultural confidence, she demonstrated, does not require quarantine. You can know English to its bones and not lose Bengali. You can live in Britain without becoming stateless in the head. You can go a long way into another culture and come back with your own intact, possibly improved. She died on Saturday.

Somewhere there is an examination script with two English words on it, *noton*, by a teenager who had worked out that the alternative to being colonised by a language is not a barricade. It is curiosity. It is translation. It is conversation.

The writer is assistant professor, Sikkim Manipal University



Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, September 16

Hunt

THE NATIONAL Investigation Agency's chief, 1994-batch Himachal Pradesh cadre IPS officer Rakesh Agrawal, who took charge of the agency in January, is still in the hunt for an independent house that can meet his "specific requirements". Agrawal stays at a government accommodation in Lutyens' Delhi, and the proposal for an independent house has been pending for months with the ministry concerned. A senior NIA officer has been tasked with handling day-to-day coordination of the file, and agency officials hope for an early resolution.

Share, Care

ONE OF the AICC secretaries attached to poll-bound Uttar Pradesh, Sanjeev Arya, has taken strict note of some Congress leaders not sharing social media posts by the party's top leaders on issues related to "social justice". In a recent meeting with party leaders from the state, sources said, Arya bluntly asked how many of them share social media posts by Rahul Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge and Priyanka Gandhi. Many of the leaders present had no answer to the query and sat sheepishly.

Plant 7,000 trees in Bhopal for 700 cut down for cricket stadium road: NGT

Express News Service
Bhopal, September 16

THE NATIONAL Green Tribunal directed the Madhya Pradesh Forest Department to plant 7,000 trees by September 30 as compensation for the felling of around 700 trees for the road being constructed for the proposed cricket stadium in Bhopal. The direction came on Wednesday in proceedings concerning the felling of over 700 trees and construction activity in the catchment area of the Bhoj Wetland near Neelband Barkedha Nathu in Bhopal, where a cricket stadium and an associated road project have been under scrutiny.

The bench comprising Judicial Member Shoo Kumar Singh and Expert Member Sudhir Kumar Chaturvedi directed the Forest Department: "In light of the cutting of 700 trees, we expect that the Forest Department, Social Forestry, may plant the trees at a ratio of 10 times i.e., 7,000 trees, in the present session and the exercise should be completed by September 30, 2026."

Dalit labourer suicide: HC seeks status report on probe; Cheema says Opposition trying to frame him

Express News Service
Chandigarh, New Delhi, September 16

THE PUNJAB and Haryana High Court on Wednesday asked the Punjab government to file a status report regarding the probe into the death of Gulzar Singh, a Dalit labourer who allegedly died by suicide in Sangur after being harassed for questioning Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema on easy availability of drugs in his area.

With opposition demanding that Cheema be sacked and booked for abetment to suicide, the minister finally his silence and accused the Opposition parties of joining hands to "frame" him, even as BJP MP

THE NATIONAL Testing Agency (NTA) has invited Expressions of Interest (EOI) from academicians, scientists, researchers, professionals and educators to join a three-year panel of Subject Matter Experts (SMEs) for question paper setting, translation, vetting, moderation, answer key verification, curriculum mapping, research, psychometric validation and other confidential academic assignments.

The last date for applying is October 9.

According to the NTA, the empanelled experts may be called upon to undertake one or more of the following confidential academic activities, depending on their area of expertise and NTA's operational requirements.

The experts will be tasked with authoring questions of specified format, difficulty level, and curricular alignment for one or more NTA examinations, vetting, coaching organisation, test-preparation company, curricular alignment, language clarity, difficulty calibration, distractor quality, and fairness.

Another key responsibility listed by the NTA is answer-key verification and challenge resolution. Experts may be required to examine challenges raised by candidates against provisional answer keys and provide reasoned responses. The experts will also be required to maintain and update the secure item banks, including tagging and calibrating questions, retiring over-exposed items and



A protest against the NEET leak in Chandigarh in July. EXPRESS FILE

adding fresh questions.

The panel may further contribute to subject-level committees dealing with syllabus review, examination schemes and policy inputs, besides curricular mapping, development of test specifications and blueprints, pilot studies and research on examination quality.

According to the NTA, the applicant must not be associated, directly or indirectly, in any capacity, with any candidate-coaching organisation, test-preparation company, exam-coaching institute, online or offline tutoring platform, or any private entity engaged in the business of preparing candidates for NTA examinations or similar entrance examinations.

It also says that the applicant must not have authored, co-authored, contributed to, edited or endorsed any commercially published preparation material, mock test, question bank or sample paper for NTA examinations or similar entrance examinations, in the last five years.

"The applicant must not

have any active or recent commercial relationship with any candidate-facing test-preparation entity in the last three years, and no immediate family member of the applicant (spouse, children, parents, siblings) should be appearing for any NTA examination in the years for which the applicant is empanelled..." it said.

The applicant will also have to undergo a comprehensive background and integrity verification before empanelment, the NTA said. The agency has also specified restrictions on how confidential work is to be carried out. Empanelled experts will be required to sign a comprehensive Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA) at the time of empanelment, and re-affirm it at the start of every assignment.

It also asks those empanelled to refrain from any post-empanelment commercial association with candidate-coaching entities for a period of 2 years from the date of the last assignment, in line with NTA's cool-off norms.

NTA restructures role: Translators will now ensure quality of AI work

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, September 16

AS PART of its overhaul, the National Testing Agency (NTA) has changed the role of translators, looking now for those who can review "AI-generated translations" of examination questions from English into Indian languages, identify linguistic, technical, scientific or contextual errors, suggest corrections, and certify the final translation.

The NTA's Expression of Interest has mentioned that the role being offered is different from the conventional 'translator' role in earlier cycles. The NTA conducts a number of high-stakes competitive examinations, including NEET, JEE Mains, CUET, UGC-NET and others in 13 languages.

Under the restructuring process, the translation function will be performed in two parts—the bulk of the translation shall be performed by an air-gapped AI-based translation platform deployed on NTA's premises, and the verification, certification and quality-assurance of the AI-produced translations shall be performed by a panel of empanelled human professionals.

The panel of empanelled human professionals will be

Agency taking extra security steps after the NEET UG paper leak earlier this year, triggering outrage, protests & CBI probe

referred as the "translation reviewers" who will be operating under structured, monitored conditions in NTA's secure facility.

The selected reviewer will also see only "individual items, presented one at a time, in a randomised order that bears no relationship to the order in which items appear in the final paper". They (the reviewers) will also not be allowed to see the assembled paper, NTA said.

The agency is taking extra security measures after the NEET UG paper leak earlier this year, triggering outrage, protests and a CBI probe.

Translators and question paper setters came under scrutiny during the NEET UG paper leak investigation. The CBI investigation into the NEET UG paper leak found that one of the arrested subject experts, Manisha Mandhare, was not only involved in setting the question paper but also translating it.

Eggs thrown at her, Mahua message to SC: 'Faced them as freedom fighter faced bullets'

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, September 16

EGGS WERE thrown at TMC MP Mahua Moitra allegedly by BJP workers at Tahatta in Nadia district, where she had gone to attend a party meeting on Wednesday evening.

Going live on Facebook from Tahatta, the Krishnaganar MP was heard telling police officers to clear the protesters, or they would be in contempt of court. While she got in her car and was seated in the front, protesters carrying black flags pelted eggs at her and chanted "Go Back" slogans.

In a video posted on X, where she was seated in the car with eggshells on her face, Moitra said, "The Supreme Court of India told me to go and face some eggs. We were holding an internal meeting at our party office in Tahatta. BJP workers and leaders gathered outside with eggs. I had four policemen with me. The High Court has said this cannot be done. Police instead of moving them (protesters), told me to get into car. Why should I run away? I am not scared. In full view of the police, they came and threw eggs on me."

Later she posted on X, "Big shout out to Hon'ble Justice Dipankar Datta Milord - I came to my constituency for a meeting informing @WBPolice, and BJP workers, with their help, pelted eggs on me. True to your advice, I faced them as a freedom fighter faced bullets."

"Justice Dipankar Datta - Milord, I am officially both an



TMC MP Mahua Moitra in Krishnaganar, Wednesday, PM

MP in independent India & a freedom fighter today! BJP ofice bearers (NOT public) surrounded my meeting & pelted eggs as I left. Thank you Milord, for upholding our Constitutional protections," she added.

She was referring to the observation made by Justice Dipankar Datta of the Supreme Court in August, asking the TMC MP — who raised concerns of 'egg attacks' to seek a virtual appearance before the investigating officer in a criminal case — why a politician should fear eggs when freedom fighters braved bullets. "Having taken the plunge into politics, why do you fear eggs? Our freedom fighters took bullets on their chest," Justice Dipankar Datta had said.

The bench, also comprising Justice Sheel Nagu, had said the matter should not have come up before the Supreme Court at all. Following this, Moitra withdrew the plea, and the court subsequently dismissed it as withdrawn.

How Chhattisgarh is moving from Red to green

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, September 16

WHEN NTI Aayog came out with its rankings in the category of Regulatory Ease and Institutional Environment among 17 large states in July, it packed a surprise. Topping the list was an unusual name: Chhattisgarh.

As the BJP government at the Centre pushed ahead with its operations to end Maoist insurgency, the state worst affected by it rolled out measures to come out of its shadow, about a year after the BJP wrested power in Chhattisgarh. The Industrial Development Policy 2024-30 unveiled by the Vishnu Deo Saigovernment in November 2024 proposed measures such as fully digitised allotment of 1,548 acres of land for industrial purposes without human intervention, automatic mutation of 2.5 lakh land records, hassle-free registration, and provision of 39,000 services via a single click.

Nearly two years later, the impact is showing. Says Rajat Kumar, Minister, Commerce & Industries: "Reforms only count when it saves time, and time is what investors value most. That is why state known for coal and steel is building chips, AI data centres and garments... Twenty-six years (since the creation of Chhattisgarh), the next 26 will be decided by what we make possible for people to build here."

On the ground, the time



A OneClick single window system now integrates 186 services across 10 departments in the state. EXPRESS

taken for approvals, and receiving NOCs, construction permits and utility connections has been drastically shortened, while the cost of exiting has been cut. Where discretionary, file-based clearance was the norm, there is now time-bound service delivery, automatic escalation on delay and deemed approval where departments do not act.

Even small measures such as the Udyam Aakanksha registration form cutting down the number of fields to be filled on the portal from 126 to just 54 have helped. The portal has been created for registration of enterprises and issue of approval certificates to MSMEs for starting businesses and claiming state incentives. Officials talk of a surge in applications from previous Maoist heartlands such as Sukma, Dantewada and Kondagaon, by "102%".

Says Minister for Commerce and Industry Lakhman Lal Dewangan: "Chhattisgarh is no longer just a land of resources, but a state that turns possibilities into industry and employment."

Kumar cites five specific measures that have boosted Chhattisgarh to the top in the category of Regulatory Ease and Institutional Environment: ■ Chhattisgarh was the first state to enact a second "Jan Vishwas" legislative edition. Since January 2026, 279 minor provisions have been decentralised and compliance shifted from inspector-led enforcement.

■ This year the state also passed the Ease of Doing Business Act, under which Chhattisgarh's permission system is now based on risk-based classification, with the categories to be notified for 43 services soon. High-risk activities, such as those posing a

threat to the environment, will have a notified validity period, and low-risk units move to self-certification or certification by a licensed engineer, architect or chartered professional. If a department does not act within the notified timeline, the approval will be taken as granted.

■ Under "entry and compliance", home-based registration is permitted, which means small businesses with 20 or more employees can register through simple intimation, with no application scrutiny and no inspection. New power connections require on-site inspection and no contractor test report, only self-certification, and an instant online estimate. Homestay registration carries lifetime validity.

■ Certain businesses such as restaurants have been allowed to operate round the clock, with women permitted to work all shifts, subject to safety and hygiene.

■ A OneClick single window system now integrates 186 services across 10 departments, with the applicant receiving regular updates on the status of his or her application, along with geo-tagged inspections and real-time dashboards.

Kumar attributes the realisation of proposals on the mission system is now based on risk-based classification, with the categories to be notified for 43 services soon. High-risk activities, such as those posing a

land being acquired, or clearances under way, or the status of construction and operations.

Several industries entering the state for the first time include India's first AI Data Centre Park, being built with a Rs 1,000 crore investment by RackBank in Nava Raipur, with a capacity for 100,000 GPUs (graphics processing units), a semiconductor manufacturing unit; India's first purpose-built disaster recovery data centre campus (essentially a backup/fail-safe location for critical digital infrastructure of metros) by Hypermet, involving a Rs 4,200 crore investment; and units in garment manufacturing, consumer electronics, ocean-based food processing, in-trailers less manufacturing, and global BPO operations.

Ashwin Gang, Urli Industries Association, representing around 500 businesses, calls the steps taken by the government "positive and commendable". However, he urges there should be focus on existing MSMEs as well. "Land availability and affordability remain major concerns, particularly for MSMEs. Industrial areas are now crowded and land prices have risen. High power costs and shortage of skilled manpower in Chhattisgarh are other concerns. Value addition is needed and there is scope for it in food processing, herbal products, textiles, pharma, aluminium and automobile components."

'Swachhata Hi Seva 2026' campaign commences today

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 16

THE 2026 edition of Swachhata Hi Seva, an annual campaign which encourages citizens across the country to step out and take ownership of their surroundings, commenced on Thursday.

Union Jal Shakti Minister C R Patil, announcing the campaign on Wednesday, said, "This year, the theme of the campaign is 'Swachhata Mein Sahbhag, Swachh Bharat, Viksit Bharat'."

"Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, cleanliness is not just a government programme today. It has become a mass movement

through people's participation", Patil said.

Thursday also marks the birthday of Prime Minister Narendra Modi (September 17).

The 5.25 lakh villages of the country have been declared free of open defecation. Besides, 12.22 crore individual household toilets have been built in rural areas since 2014. This shows the big change in the sanitation sector in the country," the minister added.

Patil further said that over 18 crore citizens participated in the Swachhata Hi Seva campaign last year. Of them, 14 crore people were from rural areas, he said, adding that people's participation is rising over the years.

"This year too, we endeavour to ensure that every state, every village, every panchayat and every person becomes part of this movement", Patil said.

The Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, which falls under his ministry, has also launched Swachh Seva Aankal for Swachh Bharat Mission (Gramin) programmes.

"Under this, gram panchayats will undertake self-assessment of rural sanitation service delivery", Patil said, adding, "The move is not only aimed at achieving the cleanliness target but also to ensure continuous improvement of the sanitation system at the village level."

ADVERTORIAL

Dr Vikramjit Singh Sahney, Padma Shri
Member of Parliament, Rajya Sabha

AT THE Prime Minister's gala dinner on September 12, the spectacular cultural panorama, "Navarasa: The Universe of Shared Emotions", offered a fitting metaphor for BRICS itself: different civilisations, distinct experiences, yet a shared human aspiration for dignity, security and prosperity. The challenge of diplomacy is to give that shared aspiration practical form. In New Delhi, India did precisely that.

The 2026 BRICS Summit was historic, and a major diplomatic achievement for India under Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Its significance lies not simply in convening leaders, but in securing a consensus declaration despite sharp differences over West Asia. PM Modi's leadership deserves credit for keeping cooperation possible when division would have been easier. The New Delhi Declaration gives the strengthened Global South both a common voice and a practical development agenda.

I approach this moment with the perspective of having participated in the BRICS Business Council since its founding in Durban in 2013. This September, I chaired the India-South Africa Business Forum, participated in the Business Council meeting and INNO-PROM with Indian and Russian commerce ministers, chaired the Business Forum's Agriculture session and the India-UAE Roundtable.

BRICS now represents approximately 49.5 per cent of humanity and around 40 per cent of global GDP in purchasing-power-parity terms. Such scale creates resiliency, not merely negotiating weight. A grouping encompassing producers, consumers, capital, technology and natural resources can help make development less vulnerable to distant disruptions. New Delhi's achievement was to connect this economic weight with an agenda centred on people.

During the BRICS Business Forum, PM Modi, Cyril Ramaphosa, Vladimir Putin and Masoud Pezeshkian emphasised practical partnerships, resilient supply chains, technological capability and economic opportunity. Their common message was unmistakable: BRICS must move beyond describing its potential to organising its delivery. The South should not remain merely a supplier of raw materials or a consumer of technologies developed elsewhere. South-South cooperation should mean jointly designing solutions, sharing production capabilities and building markets, rather than reproducing relationships in which one partner supplies resources and another captures value.

The declaration's strength is that it links this ambition to institutions and mecha-



PM Modi Emerges As Beaconlight For BRICS

The 2026 BRICS Summit was historic, and a major diplomatic achievement for India under Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

nisms. Its calls for UN Security Council reform, more representative international financial institutions and fair, rules-based trade by who shapes rules, whose development needs receive financing, and whether smaller economies have a meaningful say. A stronger South should improve multilateralism, not replace one hierarchy with another. South voice to be heard in Multilateral agencies which are dominated by West.

The declaration's emphasis on dialogue, civilian protection and zero tolerance for terrorism also matters to development. No supply chain is secure when shipping routes become theatres of conflict. Peace is therefore not a separate diplomatic chapter; it is an economic necessity.

As Chair of the BRICS Agri Business Forum, agriculture for me is the clearest test. Food security cannot endure without farmer prosperity. The declaration recognises smallholders as essential stakeholders, agrees to establish the farmer-centric BRICS AGRIN network, and welcomes networks for digital agriculture and regenerative farming. These provide a foundation for sharing seeds, knowledge and technologies while respecting national systems and farmers' interests.

The Business Council's annual report complements this framework with recommendations on seed cooperation, food information, plant protection and quarantine, cold chains, farmgate processing and agri-



From left: Islem Salem (Egypt), Chen Gang (China), MP Dr Vikramjit Singh Sahney (India), Sagar Kaushik (India), Andrey Guryev (Russia), Busi Mabuza (South Africa) and Ahmad Al Hassan (UAE) at the Agri session of the BRICS Business Forum 11 September 2026, New Delhi. The session was chaired by MP Dr Vikramjit Singh Sahney

tech partnerships and mandates for BRICS Agri Portal. Better logistics, local processing and dependable buyers must accompany better cultivation. BRICS cooperation should help farmers retain more of the value they create.

Affordable agri-tech must therefore become a defining priority. AI-based advice should help farmers decide when to irrigate, detect crop stress and use fertilisers efficiently, in languages they understand. Shared machinery services and farmer organisations should make precision tools accessible to smallholders. The proposed agri-tech startup corridor offers a route for testing and adapting solutions across countries. Innovation must be judged by lower costs, reduced risk and higher incomes.

Crop-residue management offers another practical opportunity. BRICS should support affordable residue collection and machinery, and investments in bioenergy. The principle should be simple: make residue valuable rather than leave its disposal an unaffordable burden. Climate action becomes more durable when farmers can earn from it.

Similarly, crop diversification needs an economic proposition, not merely an advisory. We should connect climate-resilient seeds and water-saving practices with processing, dependable buyers and markets for pulses, oilseeds, millets and horticulture. Sustainability must strengthen the farmer's balance sheet, not become another obligation imposed upon it.

These priorities connect directly with the wider economy. The declaration's MSME credit-assessment principles and proposed study of invoice discounting address a familiar constraint: an enterprise may have orders but lack working capital. Its work on payment interoperability and local-currency settlements can support more dependable economic relationships. The objective should be practical financial choice, not currency confrontation.

The New Development Bank must be central to this effort. Its role must go beyond conventional lending it should promote well-designed public-private partnerships (PPPs), de-risk viable projects and mobilise private capital for cross-border infrastructure, clean energy, agricultural value

chains, MSME financing and digital connectivity. Its success should be measured not only by loans approved, but by jobs created, farmers empowered and communities transformed.

For the next generation, the BRICS Incubator Network, stronger Startup Knowledge Hub and proposed virtual platform for youth startups offer pathways from an idea to a market. We should connect incubation with mentoring, patient finance, cross-border trials and skills. Young innovators and women entrepreneurs must become participants in international commerce, rather than spectators to summit diplomacy.

The sectoral agenda is equally consequential. The declaration links health cooperation with digital access, medical production and preparedness; energy security with equitable transitions, smart grids and storage; and education with skills and qualification recognition.

The Business Council's priorities in manufacturing, aviation, transport and logistics should now become practical partnerships. AI-enabled production and shared technologies can strengthen industrial value chains, while direct air links, cargo corridors and paperless trade can connect businesses more efficiently.

Digital infrastructure and AI must be approached with the same purpose. BRICS should learn from each other's public platforms and widen access to secure digital payments, connectivity and computing. AI should serve earlier diagnosis, telemedicine, multilingual education and better public services, with safeguards for privacy and cybersecurity.

What especially distinguishes Prime Minister Modi's approach is his insistence on accountability. His call to identify ten major trade barriers, help 100 startups enter other BRICS markets annually and forge 1,000 business partnerships, with yearly review, gives business cooperation a measurable direction. As Council members, we should carry that discipline into agriculture and every other sector.

A declaration securing consensus and creating credible avenues for action are substantial achievements in themselves. Under PM Modi, India's chairship has helped position BRICS as a catalyst for a more capable, confident and cooperative Global South.

The new global order can emerge only with shared purpose. New Delhi supplied that purpose and a framework for pursuing it. The enduring measure of this historic summit will be a South that can innovate, finance, produce and prosper together the shared emotions of Navarasa finding their most meaningful expression: shared opportunity.



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Shri Narendra Modi Ji

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ASIAN GAMES | AICHI-NAGOYA | SEPTEMBER 19 TO OCTOBER 4

Protagonist, Paraphernalia & Podium: It takes three elements to complete sport. *The Indian Express* presents the stories about the personality, the equipment and the opponent who will bring the slash of strokes and dash of colour to the Asian Games

From Dhyan Chand to Jugraj: Evolution of the hockey stick

From a mythical magnet to the bow bent into a modern stick, and now a coat of paint, how India's best keep reinventing

Prithvi Raj

Jalandhar, September 16

A FEW weeks back, top Indian drag-flicker Jugraj Singh had a specific request for his hockey stick manufacturer. He wanted another layer of paint or primer on his stick, especially near the area from where he drags the ball during penalty corners.

This is one of the recent changes hockey sticks have seen in their constant evolution from wooden to carbon fibre.

"Jugraj had asked us to add a layer of paint to his stick. This is something new that drag-flickers across the world have been doing," said Jitin Mahajan, the second-generation hockey stick maker and the owner of the brand 'Alfa'.

Explaining the change, hockey broadcaster and coach Siddharth Pandey said, "When the stick comes out of a manufacturing unit, the surface is very smooth and there's no control on it. The white paint adds a layer of friction between the stick and the ball. That allows the stick to have more grip on the ball to execute the drag-flick."

From the days of wood to the carbon fibre, hockey sticks have often been used as magic wands by wizards of the game with the greats often having their tool made according to their own precise specifications. It's part of the hockey lore that Dhyan Chand's extraordinary dribbling skills gave rise to rumours that he had a magnet in his stick to help him in ball control. "The value of a good hockey stick is immense. You can ask a hockey player to change anything but they are very particular about their sticks," Mahajan said.

Different specifications

As the game has moved with the times, hockey sticks have evolved according to the requirements of their users.

"Almost everyone in the Indian national team plays with our sticks. But we can't manufacture the sticks for the whole team in one go. Each stick takes time as there are exact specifications from the players," Mahajan said. "For example, forward Abhishek asks for a low bow and more weight on the lower side of the stick as it helps in generating power while taking a shot."

Pandey explained the different bends in a hockey stick.

"The bow is basically the bend on the stick. A low bow means the stick has a bend at its lowest end, allowing the

1. Pink stick, it's the mid-bow used by midfielders

2. Orange stick, it's the low-bow, used by strikers



The grainy part of low-bow is where drag-flickers ask for primer to be applied to create friction, which helps during penalty corners. EXPRESS



(Inset): Jugraj Singh has a white primer painted on to his hockey stick. The paint allows a better grip on the ball when going for a drag-flick. HOCKEY INDIA

player to perform 3D skills, pickups, back-flicks, aerials, and have more power," he said. "For mid-fielders, there is a pro bow somewhere in the middle of the stick. It's not very pronounced but allows more control and accuracy while passing."

The hockey sticks are constantly modified for the specific requirements of their users. "Indian defenders usually receive aerial balls or have to scoop it up. So some extra bend helps them in controlling the ball better," said Mahajan. "As new skills have developed over the years, such changes have been made to hockey sticks."

Wooden to composite

Like other sports equipment, the hockey stick has also evolved in terms of the material used. "Our family started making

SPORT LAB

hockey sticks back in the 1960s. There has been a constant evolution of the stick through the eras," said Mahajan, whose brand is the domestic market leader in hockey sticks. "We used to make wooden sticks before but it would take a lot of time. When FIH introduced glass and carbon fibre in the early 2000s, the manufacturing of sticks started moving towards a more modern method."

While Alfa leads the market in India, Pakistan's Awan Sports dominates the global market with the likes of Adidas, Nike, Osaka, and Grays manufacturing hockey sticks there and exporting their product out of Pakistan. The introduction of carbon fibre has been a game-changer. "We were the first to make composite hockey sticks in India. In 2005-2006, we started making hockey sticks from carbon fibre and they were exported too but westopped due

to increasing competition in the international market," said Raghav Kohli, owner of Shrey Sports, primarily known for making cricket helmets.

However, Shrey has restarted making hockey sticks for the past four years and Indian women's team player Sakshi Rana and British star Jacob Draper are two of the players who use their products. "Hockey is a passion for me and despite stopping it back in 2006, I decided to revive the hockey stick business and we have been growing in the international market," Kohli said.

What changed when the sticks moved away from wood?

"The game becomes much faster. Wooden sticks wouldn't last long. Carbon fibre and the resin used to make modern-day sticks is like aviation-grade material. The transfer of ball between players, the execution of skills and the quality of goals have gone to a higher level with the improvement in the sticks," said Pandey.



Face/Off: In order to confound opponents, India's badminton doubles shuttlers must blend into each other's roles unpredictably. Satwik and Treena must run off set-ups from the net, and Chirag and Gayatri must attack from the back to disrupt opponents' plans that rely on pre-conceived notions. IAI

PERSONALITIES

The end of badminton's division of labour

Shivani Naik

Mumbai, September 16

WHERE BADMINTON forks away from volleyball and develops a personality of its own is when Treena Jolly starts dribbling at the net, and Satwik Saijal Rankireddy uses strategic high lifts, imparting visible deceleration on the shuttle with the slightest of backswings, unlike the expansive one behind his 500kph smash. Treena can poke and prod at the net with the tinnest tilts of the thumb metacarpal and first phalanx, a skill she learned beyond her core capability as a smash hitter herself.

With just two people on the court, badminton's ace doubles practitioners don't have the luxury of role-assigned blockers, setters, spikers or a super-specific libero. Chirag Shetty is expected to dive full-stretch in defence for a block, run the offence like a setter for Satwik, and soar high for a tracked-back smash two returns later, all in the same rally. Gayatri Gopichand was always underestimated for her smashing, until the Delhi World Championships, when her forehead cross-court smash left China's Yifan unable to guard her back court.

The Indian doubles style has evolved in 2026 with deceptive personalities at its core, and a healthy disregard for being hemmed in by restrictive definitions. The last two World Championship medals have come from doubles. Satwik-Chirag first. Treena-Gayatri most recently, and both pairs are re-drawing what an Indian doubles player plays like: everything, everywhere, all at once, coherent to each other even when the world watches, puzzled.

The unmaking of the label, "Satwik, Treena smash" or "Chirag, Gayatri set it up", was at the core of this evolution. Satwik's shoulder gave way. Treena was forced to sit out, nursing a foot injury, and used the time to train meditatively on the hundred ways to dribble. PV Sindhu had done something similar in late 2015 with a hurt foot of her own.

India's best doubles pairs are abandoning fixed roles for something harder to scout

FACTFILE

SATWIK-CHIRAG

Ranked World No 5. They had dipped to World No 25 in May 2025.

HIGHS OF 2026: Won Singapore Open, China Masters and Thomas Cup bronze.

LOWS: Of exit at World Championships, recurring shoulder concerns for Satwik.

COMPETITION LEVEL: 17 of the Top 20 MD pairs are from Asia making medalling at the Asian Games tougher than Olympics most times.

TREENA-GAYATRI

Ranked World No 26. Had dropped to World No 58 in mid-July of 2026.

HIGHS: Philippines IC title, World Championship bronze.

LOWS: Foot injury to Treena which meant they missed the early summer swing of tournaments.

COMPETITION LEVEL: 25 of the Top 30 WD pairings are from Asia, with several combines having spoken of peaking for the Asian

Treena, a sponge for new skills, decided to shape-shift her game entirely to master the net, before the pair won bronze in Delhi.

Chirag and Gayatri, meanwhile, remain quietly in awe of their respective partners' big smashes, and tend to hide their own sharp-sniping abilities, which aren't shabby at all. It helps that they're underestimated. Like Sindhu in singles, both Treena and Satwik were smash machines once. But that isn't sustainable on the back and shoulder. So both learned the meditative art of slowing their breathing, using the racket as a scalpel rather than a scythe, and discovering the "feel" on the shuttle in badminton's unspoken battle zone: the net.

Gayatri's smashes work on placement more than power, an important distinction, since Japanese and Chinese women's doubles pairs are trained specifically to pick apart the hardest hits. Her vision in finding gaps is an innate skill, and she plays close-range confrontations with a ticking brain and locked wrists. Satwik-Chirag won the "first three shots" battle at China Masters, where trick serves were on show. Gayatri is being tutored in spinny serves by the least-

known member of her family, her brother Vishnu, a former shuttler now graduating from Loughborough.

Leaping high and unleashing a gigantic smash had been second nature to Treena. But when your game is that aligned to one shot, you're one video-analysis session away from being countered. That's why Treena summoned something closer to sorcery at the net: canny strokes, serve variations, and the audacity to dribble.

These weren't make-do parries at the net. Proper keeps, precise taps, choosy pushes, subtly varying serves, none of the escape-lifts, Gayatri's interceptions look effortless; Treena's take real driving to catch fast drives at the net. While the world stayed stuck on Gayatri's surname and Treena's smash, the duo were quietly outrunning the predictability of how they were seen.

There's a Nicolas Cage-John Travolta film from before any of these four were born. But Satwik-Chirag and Treena-Gayatri are, right now, in the Face/Off stage of their rotational play. That vice-versa trick, the devilish duality, is what Indian doubles play can be defined as.

PATH TO GOLD

Compound interest: Can India upstage Korea and Taiwan for mixed team gold?

Nitin Sharma

Chandigarh, September 16

KOREAN MALE compound archer Kim Jong-ho was an absolute beast of the Mixed Team event at Archery World Championships - winning four back to back world titles with different partners till 2019. India's Jyothi Vennam and Sahil Jadhav don't have a gold at the World's, but two mixed team silvers at 2021 and most recently at the 2025 edition, make her one of Compound Archery's most dependable athletes at the all-important Asian Games.

For all her previous glory, the consistent medals that define her longevity and the individual genius, will pale in comparison to what's at stake at the Aichi Nagoya Asian Games. The mixed team gold offers a quota place for the LA Olympics. Vennam won the mixed gold along with Ojas Deotale in

a three gold haul at Hangzhou Asiad, and a repeat of the paired title will make XD gold more precious than others.

"There will be extra motivation to seal a quota place. While we train hard with same passion and intensity as always, people's perception changes with this," Vennam explained to *The Indian Express*. "There's also motivation that India mixed teams are strong and we have proved it since a long time. And that'll be the case in future too. Olympics event is new for us but it's same mentality as well as training. Rest of countries are also looking to better in both men and women sections to find balance in mixed events," she adds.

The catch with Mixed Team is that the gold will hinge only halfway on Vennam - the male archers, World No 15 Kushal Dalal, No 22 Sahil Jadhav or No 92 Ganesh Thirumani will have

to match Vennam's precision and steady nerves - and that's where we deal in unknowns.

Vennam has three World's medals from 8 editions - 2 silver, 1 bronze. Her partnership with Rishabh Yadav fetched her one of those silvers in 2025 where they had managed to beat Chinese Taipei pair of Chang Cheng-wei and Huang I-tou - one of the main gold contenders at Nagoya.

Korea threat

She has 11 World Cup stage medals, but she realises the different dynamic of mixed where the partner is equally crucial. Also, a giant part of Mixed Team is time management - with a combined shooting window allotted. "One member can take extra time sometime and then the other has to shoot within what's left. And the same can happen in scoring. One member can have a bad



Jyothi Vennam and Sahil Jadhav will be India's likely mixed team for the compound event. WORLD ARCHERY

shot and the other helps the team recover. But the focus is on believing your process and giving your best," Vennam says. India currently tops among

Asians in world rankings at 4th behind Netherlands, USA and Denmark. Only four Asians are in the world's top 20 mixed teams: Chinese Taipei at 8th,



Korea at 9th and Kazakhstan at 11th spot. But Korea, the most dominant Recurve nation, can hardly be dismissed given the high stakes of an Olympic spot.

India currently tops among Asians in world rankings at 4th behind Netherlands, USA and Denmark. Only four Asians are in the world's top 20 mixed teams.

Korea dropped So Chae-won, the successful partner of Kim Jong-ho after they lost the 2025 World championship quarters at home in Gwangju to the Taiwanese. They went by form including World University Games bronze medalist Park Yerin, besides two-time World Cup medalist Choi Sun Gyu and 2025 World Championships bronze medalist Choi Yoo-hee, even as Kim Jong-ho, looms large.

"India, Chinese Taipei and Korea are the countries which have strong male and female archers. In practice, we make all the three women archers train with all three men archers rotating the sequence and it helps in different pairings. Later, Kazakhstan and China too have been doing well apart from Malaysia in mixed team format," says coach Jijuanjot Singh Teja.

World Championships quarter-finalists Andrey Tyun Tyun and Roxanna Yunnusova of Kazakhstan (1398), World Cup mixed team bronze medalists and Fatin Nurfathe and Mohammad Juwaidi Maiki of Malaysia are also in the mix.

Vennam has been staggeringly consistent in individuals, but the mixed team gold when it truly matters, is what makes the Nagoya fortnight the biggest challenge of her career.

WEST INDIES ODI SERIES

A spot open behind the stumps but Rishabh is snubbed again

Three regulars are missing from India's squad but Pant is not the one filling the breach

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, September 16

FOR MORE than two years, India's ODI team has moved on without Rishabh Pant. Now, even with several regulars unavailable for the three-match series between West Indies, the wicketkeeper-batsman has been overlooked again.

Dhruv Jurel's selection ahead of Pant makes the omission harder to explain away. Shreyas Iyer, Ishan Kishan and Axar Patel are all unavailable for the ODIs, leaving India without several players who'd normally make their ODI XI. Their absence still hasn't opened a way back for Pant. Instead, he'll captain Rest of India in the Irani Cup against Jammu and Kashmir, one more sign of how differently his red-ball and 50-over careers are moving.

Which raises a simple question: where does his ODI career go from here?

Pant last played an ODI against Sri Lanka in August 2024, his only chance that series, with KL Rahul preferred as wicketkeeper. Since then, he's remained central to India's Test side, but has slipped down the 50-over pecking order.

This series looked like a route back. Kishan's absence opened up the wicketkeeping slot, Iyer's created a gap in the middle order; Axar's removed another left-handed batting option.

Instead, India turned to Jurel. With Rohit Sharma opening and Ravindra Jadeja likely batting at No. 7, India could field an entirely right-handed



Pant's last major ODI was in 2022 vs England where the wicketkeeper got his only ODI century. CREAMAS

middle order. Pant would have offered a left-handed option somewhere in the top six.

More than that, his style can change the pace of an ODI innings, particularly through the middle overs. He can attack spin, find boundaries when the field spreads, and force opposition captains to rethink their plans.

ODI cricket also gives Pant room to build an innings. He doesn't have to attack from the first ball, and at his best, can settle before turning the pressure back on the bowlers.

There are risks in that approach too. His attacking instinct has cost India wickets at times when he needed to stay in. But his capacity to change a game quickly has also been one of his biggest strengths.

His latest major ODI innings showed exactly what he can offer. Against England at Manchester in July 2022, Pant

walked in at No. 4 and made an unbeaten 125 off 113 balls, 16 fours and two sixes, helping India complete the chase and win the series. It remains his only ODI hundred.

Pant has played just one ODI since the end of 2022. Much of that absence was beyond his control; his car accident in December 2022 kept him out of the game for more than a year, before he returned during the 2024 IPL.

Since regaining full fitness, though, ODI opportunities have been hard to come by. He played once against Sri Lanka in August 2024, and hasn't featured in the format since. With India carrying several gaps to fill, the West Indies series looked like his chance to return and put himself in contention.

Jurel's selection adds another name to the competition too. Rahul has established himself as India's primary ODI

wicketkeeper, and Kishan remains part of the picture when available. If Jurel takes his opportunities, Pant's route back could narrow further.

The challenge only grows once the missing players return. Iyer is established in the middle order. Axar offers the balance of a left-handed batsman who can bowl. Kishan is another left-handed wicketkeeper-batsman.

That doesn't mean Pant's ODI career is over. At 28, he has time to force his way back, and injuries, form and workload can shift selection plans quickly. His experience and ability with the bat mean he can't simply be written out of the picture.

But chances have to come from somewhere.

This series looked like one: several players unavailable, space in the middle order, an opening behind the stumps. If that wasn't enough to bring

Since regaining full fitness, though, ODI opportunities have been hard to come by. He played once against Sri Lanka in August 2024, and hasn't featured in the format since

Pant back, the road ahead looks difficult.

For Pant, the issue is no longer really about what he can offer India in ODI cricket. It's about getting another chance to prove it. The door hasn't fully closed, but after this omission, finding the next one open may be harder than ever.

INDIA'S ODI SQUAD: Shubman Gill (C), Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, Ruturaj Gaikwad, KL Rahul (VC), Dhruv Jurel, Nitish Kumar Reddy, Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Mohammed Siraj, Aaquib Nabi, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Naman Dhir.

INDIA'S T20I SQUAD: Shreyas Iyer (C), Abhishek Sharma, Vaibhav Surooravanshi, Ishan Kishan (WK), Sanju Samson (WK), Tilak Varma (VC), Shivam Dube, Kuldeep Yadav, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Ravi Bishnoi, Nitish Kumar Reddy, Arshdeep Singh, Prince Yadav, Mayank Yadav.

REST OF INDIA SQUAD: Rishabh Pant (C, WK), Sanat Sangwan, Shikhar Mohan, Sudip Gharami, Sarfaraz Khan (VC), Smaran Ravichandran, Manav Suthar, Saransh Jain, Akash Deep*, Mukesh Kumar, Mukesh Choudhary, Aryan Juyal (WK), Arjun Pandey, Anukul Roy, Ayush Doseja.

Pakistan wants ACT shifted, Hockey India says no

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 16

THE PROBLEMS which used to crop up, almost inevitably, whenever India or Pakistan hosted a major multilateral cricket tournament seem to have become a regular feature in hockey as well. The Pakistan Hockey Federation (PHF) has asked the continental body to relocate the upcoming Asian Champions Trophy, scheduled to be held in Mohali and Jalandhar from October 27 to November 5, to another country, citing the "sensitive bilateral situation" between the two neighbours and the "prevailing security conditions".

Interim PHF president Mo-hyuddin Ahmed Wani said in a statement on Wednesday that at least Pakistan's matches should be held elsewhere to en-



The PHF has asked for the event to be shifted to another country. IAI

sure "a safe, dignified and conducive environment for the national players and officials".

India and Pakistan are scheduled to face each other in Jalandhar on November 1.

The development comes after Pakistan pulled out of the

FIH Junior World Cup in Tamil Nadu and the Asia Cup in Raigarh, Bihar, last year.

Hockey India secretary general Bhola Nath Singh, who is also a vice-president of the Asian Hockey Federation (AHF), however, ruled out any

change in venue. "No such request would be entertained. There will be no change in venue. If they (Pakistan) want to play in the Asian Champions Trophy, they will have to come to India," Bhola Nath was quoted as saying by PTI. He added that if Pakistan do not turn up, the organisers have the option of replacing them with either Bangladesh or Oman.

Similar issues have arisen in cricket, with the two national boards unwilling to send their teams across the border for multilateral tournaments. Bilateral cricket between India and Pakistan has also remained suspended for years.

An arrangement has now been reached under which, whenever either India or Pakistan hosts an ICC event over the next few years, matches involving the other side will be

played at a neutral venue.

Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann had earlier said that Pakistan would travel to the state for the Asian Champions Trophy as India's sports policy did not object to athletes from the neighbouring country coming over for multilateral events. The PHF subsequently said that Pakistan's trip across the border to play in the tournament was subject to its government's clearance.

The issue has surfaced just days after the Indian women's cricket team refused to take the trophy from Asian Cricket Council chief Mohsin Naqvi, who is also the Pakistan Cricket Board chairman and his country's interior minister, after winning the Asia Cup. India's men's team had done likewise after clinching the corresponding tournament last year.

Arjun slips on Board one, but India starts off with a win

Mayank Chaudhary
New Delhi, September 16

INDIA'S PATH to title defence at the 2026 Chess Olympiad across the men's and women's events in Samarkand was never going to be easy. But dropping a full point in the very first round still came as a big shocker when Arjun Erigaisi lost his game to Thailand's IM Prin Laohawirap on the top board.

Arjun played on Board 1 in the absence of R Praggnanandhaa, who sat out the opening round, and was handed a crushing loss by a player nearly 400 rating points below him in classical chess.

Playing with white in the Colle System, Arjun had huge winning chances against 2363-rated Laohawirap. But the exhaustion of continuous events, having featured in the Esports World Cup and the Global Chess League, appeared to catch up with India No.2. He messed up in the endgame and lost his positional advantage when he traded his light-squared bishop and a rook for Black's knight and rook pair by the 29th move.

Laohawirap's inaccurate play allowed Arjun to exchange his dark-squared bishop and activate his queen on the king-side to regain the advantage. However, Arjun looked far from his best and let his advantage slip once again, even though he had an edge on the clock.

With better drawing odds and a position to play for a win with an extra pawn, Arjun blundered badly, trapping his own queen. This time, Laohawirap was in no mood to let it slip as he forced a resignation from the Indian in a matter of two positions.

Thankfully for the Indian men's team, the upset happened only after the defending titleholders had already sealed the match. It was Nihal Sarin who struck the first blow with the black pieces in the Symmetrical version of the English Opening against PM Tannadon Kulpruethanon on Board 2. Nihal ended the game in just 28 moves. Vidit Gujrathi soon made it 20-0-0 in India's favour, taking down Tupfah Khumnor-kaew with the dark pieces.

Talking point

The biggest talking point before the 2026 Olympiad had nothing to do with who India would play, but where D Gukesh would play. The reigning World Champion, India's most potent weapon on the top board in 2022 and 2024, was suddenly placed on Board 4 by captain Srirath Narayanan, a decision that shocked many, as no other reigning World Champion had ever been fielded on a lower board since fixed board orders were introduced in 1931.

But Gukesh doesn't seem to mind where he plays. If anything, the reduced pressure of Board 4 might give him exactly what he needs ahead of the all-important World Championship title clash against Javokhir Sindarov.

For Gukesh — who played



Arjun Erigaisi lost to Prin Laohawirap. RAFALEKSIENWICZ/PIDE

on Board 3 after Prag sat out — beating an untitled player 800 rating points below him was never going to be a problem, and he made light work of Paris Rashid Aliriyami's defence. The youngest-ever World Chess Champion bulldozed his way with the white pieces in the Queen's Indian Defense and forced a resignation from the 1909-rated Aliriyami in a mate-in-five position.

For the top-seeded Indian women's team, the first round against the Dominican Republic turned out to be much smoother with a 4-0-0-0 clean sweep. A little less than 3 hours from the start, in a span of six minutes, R Vaishali, Koneru Humpy, and Savitha Sri B won their respective games to give India an unassailable lead.

Vaishali won her game in just 31 moves with the black pieces against 1792-rated Miguellina De La Rosa Martinez on Board 2. Humpy followed, beating 1832-rated Franchesca Ramirez in as many moves on the top board.

On Board 4, Savitha's game against Karla Mya Nunez Diaz lasted 38 moves before the Dominican player resigned. For Vantika Agrawal, who played as Divya Deshmukh skipped the round, it was a hard-fought win over Mary Gonzalez. Vantika struggled with time management for much of the game, with the position nearly equal. It wasn't until the 45th move that she found any big inroads, but eventually, inexperience told as Gonzalez blundered in an equal position, losing the game in the next five moves.

RESULTS: (Open) India bt Thailand 3-1 (Arjun Erigaisi lost to Prin Laohawirap; Nihal Sarin bt Tannadon Kulpruethanon; D Gukesh bt Paris Rashid Aliriyami; Vidit Gujrathi bt Tupfah Khumnor-kaew). (Women) India bt Dominican Republic 4-0 (Koneru Humpy bt Franchesca Ramirez; Luzon; R Vaishali bt Miguellina De La Rosa Martinez; Vantika Agrawal bt Mary Loly Gonzalez Peguero; B Savitha Sri bt Karla Mya Nunez Diaz).

Two Namibia chess players denied visas

TWO OF Namibia's players had their visas rejected upon arrival in Tashkent for the 2026 Chess Olympiad, putting their participation in the tournament in jeopardy. In a desperate bid, they had to register their women's team coach Leonhard Mueller and national chess federation president Charles Eichab in the men's team.

Namibia's problems began when two players, Goodwill Khoo and Otto Nakapunda, were denied visas at Uzbekistan's capital Tashkent. Khoo was sent back to Istanbul, where he was stranded without his passport.

Indian Grandmaster Priyadarshan Kannappan, who had been training the Namibian men's team virtually and serves as their coach and captain, travelled to Samarkand via Tashkent from New Delhi on an Indian passport and had no trouble clearing immigration. After landing in Tashkent at 9 am on Tuesday, he reached Samarkand by 4 pm.

By that time, the Namibian contingent had landed in Tashkent. But unlike Priyadarshan, who had applied for an e-visa months in advance, they had gone for visas on arrival.

"All the players except two from the open team got their visas, and they didn't give any proper reason for denying the other two. They just said their names were not on the list," Priyadarshan told The Indian Express.

While the rest of the Namibian team was figuring out what to do, Priyadarshan was scrambling to get his team registered in Samarkand. "It was only at 8:50 pm that I got an update that both applications were rejected," he said. With no other option, Priyadarshan registered Mueller and Eichab in the men's team.

MAYANK CHAUDHARY

● NEW ROLE, SAME GOAL

Raphinha at the centre of Barcelona's attempt to make a new look dynasty

Among Flick's forwards, the Brazilian was easiest to repurpose with his sturdier physical presence and assured finishing

Sandip G
New Delhi, September 16

SOME GOALS are made for reels. Like Raphinha's third-minute strike against Feyenoord in the Champions League. Inside the box, he dislocated a pair of defenders with a gorgeous feint, both sliding theatrically along the luscious Nou Camp grass, and insouciantly slugged the ball home. The goal embodied the triumphalism Barcelona had displayed this season, nascent still, but bouncing with hope.

So the goals were made to reassure the manager and boardroom. Like Raphinha's second, that arrived 54 minutes later. He whipped home a through ball from Pedri with a brilliantly timed run in from behind. It was a classical poacher's strike, which would please the manager Hansi

Flick, who was admittedly worried that Barcelona had not signed a replacement for Robert Lewandowski and Ferran Torres. Both were pushed to the departure lounge in the hope that an incoming flight would land Julian Alvarez. But he stayed firmly grounded in Atletico Madrid's hangar.

When uncertainty over Alvarez grew, Flick promptly drafted the contingency plan. In the preseason warm-up, he briefed Raphinha about the potentially new role: the Brazilian, put end to shifts on the training ground, adapting to the new role. Flick's choice made sense. Among his stack of forwards and wingers at his disposal, he was the easiest to repurpose. He has a sturdier physical presence than Lamine Yamal and Karim Ademyl upfront; he doesn't get bullied by defenders. He is a



Raphinha has 8 goals and 3 assists in 6 appearances in all competitions this season. AP

considerably better finisher than Gabriel Jesus, still teething into the side, as well as Dani Olmo and Fermin Lopez; Karim Ademyl is still raw.

The season before he had scored 34 goals and assisted 26, but as a left-sided winger.

Perhaps, had they acquired Alvarez, they would not have been this prolific, what with him taking time to blend into a club with a vastly different culture.

The striker's instincts of Raphinha are evident; his

knack of exploding into spaces, using his body and trickery to pinch the ball from defenders, and the expertise to score goals differently. He can scream it across the face of the goal, he could nudge and nod. He could blast long

rangers with as much dexterity as he could chip the ball over the keeper's head. The Ballon D'or snub was just another timely fuel.

The prelude to his first goal offered insights into his goal-sniffing impulses too. He was lurking near the centre line when Pedri flung an aerial pass to Yamal out far right. When the ball nestled into Yamal's feet, Raphinha was storming into the box, creeping into the frame. Still, it seemed a decision that shocked many, as no other reigning World Champion had ever been fielded on a lower board since fixed board orders were introduced in 1931.

But Gukesh doesn't seem to mind where he plays. If anything, the reduced pressure of Board 4 might give him exactly what he needs ahead of the all-important World Championship title clash against Javokhir Sindarov.

For me, one of the best players in the world."

It was a classic case of the emergency plan working more prolifically than the default plan. Structurally, it enables the rest to play in their best positions. Yamal can't be moved out of the right wing, Adeyemi's favourite role is on the left. Olmo is a comfortable putting shifts as No.10, play-making and disrupting the defensive lines with his unpredictable movements. Rodri's arrival has fully unlocked Pedri's attacking abilities.

The result has been devastating. Barcelona have sloshed in 26 goals in six games, that is one goal roughly every twentieth minute. Raphinha and Yamal have apportioned a chunk of the pie (eight), but others have chimed in. The vibrant star, twisted by his body in the direction of the ball and then conjured that heavenly feint. The brace took his tally to eight goals from five games. Flick gushed praises: "Rapha has played fantastic. He is on another level - he's unbelievable. When he's like this, he's,

lan giants look a genuinely supreme and exciting side capable of crushing the tightest defences in the world and triumphing in Europe for the first time since 2015.

The German manager, though, dwells on their defensive robustness. Six games into season, they have conceded only three. "When I see the xG [expected goals] we have in every game, it's good, but also the xG against us is much better than last season," he said.

The central piece has been Pau Cubarsi, only 19. "For me, he's playing on another level at the moment. I am really happy he has the confidence, but also he's very focused. With the body, he also improved physically. This is very important, especially for this position. Also with the ball, he's playing really well, which helps a lot, so amazing about that."

Rodri has seamlessly woven into the side that has all the markings of making this season epic. En route, there would be goals made for reels, and those that reassure the manager.

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SUNDAY
OPEN

Trump praises India's efforts to address illicit opium cultivation

Press Trust of India
Washington, September 16

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Wednesday identified India, China and Pakistan among 23 major drug transit and illicit drug producing countries and urged their respective leaders to address the issue.

In a Presidential Determination to the US Congress, Trump also made it clear that appearing on the list was not necessarily a reflection of the respective government's current counterdrug efforts, or coordination with the United States. It said countries are placed on the list due to geographic, commercial, and economic factors that allow drugs or precursor chemicals to transit or be produced.

"I welcome Prime Minister Modi and the Government of India's efforts to address illicit opium poppy cultivation and bolster supply chain integrity. I look forward to continued cooperation through the United States-India Drug Policy Framework," Trump said in the Presidential Determination.

2013 Jhiram Ghati attack: Death sentence to all 10 found guilty

Jayprakash S Naidu
Raipur, September 16

A SPECIAL NIA court in Jagdalpur city in Bastar district on Wednesday awarded death sentence to 10 Maoists who were convicted earlier this month of murder and criminal conspiracy in the 2013 Jhiram Ghati attack case.

At least 27 people were killed and 38 injured in the attack that almost wiped off the then Congress leadership in Chhattisgarh. These included state Congress chief Nand Kumar Patel and his son Dinsh; senior party leader and former MLA Uday Mudliyar; and Mahendra Karma, who was instrumental in founding the banned anti-Maoist militia Salwa Judum.

NIA Judge Ajay Singh Raiput convicted the accused under seven sections of the Indian Penal Code (IPC) and the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act, Arms Act and Explosives Substances Act. "The death sentence was awarded on seven



Outside the NIA special court in Jagdalpur in Chhattisgarh's Bastar district. FILE

counts including criminal conspiracy (120 B) and murder (section 302) of the IPC. A total of 101 prosecution witnesses were examined in the trial, NIA prosecutor Dinesh Panigrahi said.

The 10 who have been convicted are Pramila Modiyam, Chaitu Lekam alias Munna, Sumit alias Punem Modiyam, Mukka Mandvi, Kosa Kavasi alias Kosaram, Aayata Markam, Madkani Deva, Joga Madkani, Banjani Nanna alias Chammru and Mahadev Nag. An 11th accused died during trial

while another 28, named in the chargesheet as accused, have been listed as wanted.

Among the prominent Maoists chargesheeted in the case but shown as wanted accused are Thippiri Tirupathi alias Devu, a CPI(Maoist) politburo member who surrendered in Telangana in February this year; Barse Deva who surrendered in January this year; and Ganesh Uikey, a CPI (Maoist) central committee member who was killed in a December 2025 encounter in Odisha.

Arvind Choudhary, the lawyer of the accused, said, "We will appeal before the High Court within the 30-day stipulated time."

Guddu, brother of Kavasi, claimed he along with Mandavi had been falsely implicated in the case. "They were not there at the time of the attack. Those who were involved have surrendered and are living freely, while those who were not involved are paying the price. The families are shattered," he added.

On the other hand, Tulika, Karma's daughter, said she was unsatisfied with the judgment, alleging that the main accused were "sitting in the lap of the BJP government".

"We were not satisfied then and we are not satisfied now. We are not safe even now... Can anyone tell me on what basis those who have surrendered have been removed from the list (of convicts)? Barse Deva executed the attack... Why is the BJP government not questioning these top Naxals who

are sitting in its lap?" Tulika said. "We need a Narco test of then CM Raman Singh, his entire cabinet and of top officials from DG to SP who were in charge at the time of the incident," she added.

On whether Devuji and Deva will ever be tried in the case, Chhattisgarh Home Minister Vijay Sharma said, "The states have their surrender policy as part of which appropriate decisions were taken based on the situation at that time. Further decisions will also be taken as per the surrender policy."

A government official, requesting anonymity, said both Deva and Devuji can be prosecuted under the rehabilitation policy. The official said, "Surrender does not automatically result in the withdrawal or closure of a criminal case..."

The Jhiram Ghati attack took place on May 25, 2013, when over 150 Maoists ambushed a Congress Parivartan Rally convoy. The 27 people who were killed included 10 security personnel.



One person has been arrested in connection with the case and the car has been impounded by the police. ANI

Jumped on bonnet, held on to wipers, says Lucknow woman hit by car driven by friend

Express News Service
Lucknow, September 16

A 22-year-old woman said that she clung on to the bonnet of a car, allegedly driven by her male friend, after he hit her and dragged her a few metres outside Janshwar Mishra Park in Lucknow's Gomti Nagar area on Wednesday morning.

Police have arrested one person and impounded the car in connection with the incident.

Based on the complaint filed by the woman, police have registered an FIR against her male friend, who was allegedly behind the wheel at the time of the incident, and his friend. Both have been booked for attempt to murder.

According to police, after they received information of a car hitting a woman outside Janshwar Mishra Park on Wednesday morning, a police team reached the spot. "On reaching the spot, we came to know that the youth driving the car was a friend of the woman. There was an altercation between them at the spot, after which the youth and his friend got into the vehicle and hit the woman before fleeing," said a

police officer involved in the probe. In her complaint, the woman said that she had gone to Janshwar Mishra Park to have tea in the morning when her male friend, accompanied by his friend, reached the spot and started shouting at her for visiting the park.

The two men then got into the car and drove towards her in an attempt to run her over, the woman said, adding that she jumped onto the car's bonnet and held onto the windshield wipers to save herself before falling to the ground. She alleged that her friend, who was driving the car, tried to run her over before fleeing the spot. She also alleged that the other man in the car also abused her.

She alleged that her friend assaulted her on several previous occasions as well.

She said that she lost consciousness from the impact of the collision and was taken to hospital by family members, including her younger sister, her aunt, and other people present at the spot. Deputy Commissioner of Police, Lucknow, Deepika Sharma said the medical examination of the girl is being done.

Preity Zinta, Pankaj Tripathi among 18 members on revamped film certification board



Apart from Preity Zinta and Pankaj Tripathi, the new CBFC board will also include Priyadarshan and Prosenjit Chatterjee

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, September 16

THE INFORMATION and Broadcasting Ministry reconstituted the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) on Wednesday.

The new 18-member board includes well-known film personalities such as actors Preity Zinta, Suniel Shetty, Pankaj Tripathi, and Prosenjit Chatterjee. The list also includes actor Rounak Ganguly and actor-producer Pallavi Joshi. Joshi's husband Vinay Anand is a member of the previous CBFC Board.

The Board will also have writer-columnist Yatindra Mishra, filmmaker Nila Madhab Panda, film and art critic Vinod Anupam, Marathi actor and writer Nishigandha Wadi, writer and activist Ramesh Pantange, and Telugu film producer Supriya Yariagadda, singer and BJP politician Hans Raj Hans, filmmaker Priyadarshan, Indian music composer

Shankar, film writer and director Abhishek Jain, and actor Manoj Joshi.

Officials said the new board has strong regional diversity, with several young and progressive filmmakers being brought in.

The reconstitution of the CBFC Board was long pending. The previous CBFC Board was last reconstituted on August 1, 2017. The Cinematograph Rules state that the board should be reconstituted every three years, even as it allows members to continue until new appointments.

The 149th meeting of the CBFC, also colloquially known as the Censor Board, took place on August 29 after a gap of six years. This meeting was the first after Shashi Shekhar Yempati took over as CBFC Chairperson. Under the Cinematograph (Certification) Rules 2014, the CBFC board must meet once every quarter.

Rs 2.5 cr as carbon credits: In a first, farmers reap harvest of good practices

Anju Agnihotri Chaba
Ludhiana, September 16

FOR THE first time in India, farmers have earned carbon credits for improved agricultural practices. The first beneficiaries are around 2,500 farmers — 1,400-odd from Punjab and the rest from Haryana.

The payment is based on verified carbon credits attributed to a farmer, and not linked to acreage. The first set of payments covered thousands of acres, with over 50,000 carbon credits generated. Farmers received around Rs 3,000-Rs 15,000, with the total amounting to around Rs 2.50 crore.

A 45-year-old farmer from Kothe Lal Singh Wale village in Bathinda, Sahib Singh received Rs 5,700 for having stopped burning paddy residue on his fields for the past 7-8 years. Jagmail Singh and Nishan Singh, who belong to the same village, earned Rs 19,000 and Rs 14,000, respectively. Sahib, who owns around 13 acres, has been using direct seeded rice (cutting water use) and managing crop residue instead of burning it. "My way of farming has finally acquired an economic value," Sahib said.

The programme that seeks to put an economic value to farming practices that reduce emissions and conserve soil and water was initiated by agro-tech firm Grow Indigo in 2019, with technical guidance from the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR). There is also an MoU between the ICAR-Agricultural Technology Application Research Institute (ATARI), Ludhiana, and Grow Indigo.



Farmers in Punjab, Haryana who received financial aid for reducing emissions, are being felicitated in Ludhiana. EXPRESS

The recent BRICS Summit in New Delhi adopted a declaration on the establishment of a BRICS Network of Centres of Excellence on Agroecology and Regenerative Agriculture for Climate Resilience and Productivity, as well as of a BRICS Network on Digital Agriculture. The farmers who received the payouts were also felicitated at an event in Ludhiana — attended by scientists.

Punjab incidentally has seen a sharp decline in farm-fire incidents, from over 83,000 in 2020 to fewer than 5,000 in 2025, as per the ICAR. There is a pre-existing carbon credit scheme, launched in August 2024, as part of which Punjab pays farmers for raising and maintaining trees on agricultural land under an agro-forestry-based programme. Under the programme, farmers are required to maintain trees for at least five years, with the carbon benefit linked to the trees' growth and their subsequent use in products such as paper, furniture and plywood.

Under the current scheme, farmers earn credits for changing agricultural practices in ways that reduce greenhouse-gas emissions and increase or retain carbon in the soil. These can include the use of direct seeded rice, reduced or zero tillage, better residue management, and more efficient fertiliser use — measures that are particularly relevant in Punjab's rice-wheat-based agricultural system.

Dr Rabin Singh, deputy director general (Agricultural Extension), ICAR, said, "Carbon credits can provide farmers an additional economic incentive to adopt climate-smart practices. Our role is to educate farmers and ensure that these practices are properly documented and verified through field evidence and technology."

ICAR-ATARI Director Dr Parminder Singh said experts and field teams are helping farmers adopt the new practices and document them. "Satellite and remote-sensing systems, including geo-fencing,

are used to monitor fields and residue burning, while soil sampling can help assess changes in soil properties, including soil organic carbon," Dr M L Jat, Secretary, DARE (Department of Agriculture, Research, and Education), and Director General, ICAR, said.

At Sherpur Kalan near Jagraon, Baldev Singh (54), who grows wheat, paddy and vegetables on around 20 acres, including leased land, received Rs 6,070. He said he had kept his fields free from paddy stubble burning for around eight years.

At Bathinda's Tungwali, Gurpreet Singh (25), who farms around 8.5 acres, got Rs 9,075. He grows wheat and paddy, has put his fields through soil testing, uses recommended fertilisers, and says he has not burnt stubble for around five years. Bhim Singh received Rs 12,000. Farming around 90 acres, including eight acres of his land, he grows wheat and paddy and uses ex-situ residue management, with bales removed from fields. His fields are in Mithu Suresan village, Sirsa. Varinderpal Singh of Mandiand village in Ludhiana and Surendra Kumar of Mithanpura village in Sirsa received Rs 3,000 each.

Grow Indigo Executive Director Dr Usha Barwale said the programme was moving the focus beyond simply preventing stubble burning. According to officials at the firm, the programme is acting as a continuing process rather than a one-time payment, and farmers can continue adopting good practices.

Bihar woman, whose husband went to jail for her 'murder', found alive in Jharkhand

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, September 16

IN 2014, a man was called over by police to identify the body of a woman recovered from a canal in Bilhara's Rohat district. The man identified it as his sister Shakuntala Devi, who had been missing for several days.

Shakuntala had told her family that she was being harassed by her in-laws over dowry demands. A post-mortem was conducted, a murder case was registered on her brother's complaint, and Shakuntala's husband, Arun Mehta, along with other members of his family, spent years facing the consequences of the case, including time in jail and selling ancestral land to "settle the matter".

But a decade later: Shakuntala has been accused of fraud and criminal conspiracy. "About two months ago, Dilip Mehta learnt that his daughter-in-law had been seen in a village in Jharkhand," said their counsel, advocate Shah Nawaz Ahmed.

"Dilip and some others went there. They recognised the woman," Ahmed said. "But, they were too scared to say anything to her at the time."

The family, subsequently, approached Rohtas Superintendent of Police (SP) Raj. Police traced the woman to Labharia village in Garhwa district in the neighbouring state. She was brought back to Rohtas and produced before a court in Sasaram.

Rohtas SP told *The Indian Express* that Shakuntala has been arrested and sent to judicial custody. "She had been living as Kanti Devi and was residing with a man identified as 'Shanku Singh'," an officer said.

"Shakuntala had married Arun Mehta in 2002," Ahmed said, claiming that their domestic life was ridden with "repeated disputes". According to Ahmed, Shakuntala left home in 2014 without informing the



Shakuntala Devi, who had been living in Jharkhand as Kanti Devi, has been arrested. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

family. Her in-laws searched for her but could not trace her. "On August 20 that year, her brother approached the police to report her missing," Ahmed said. What began as a dowry-related complaint against Arun and his family turned into a far more serious criminal case.

Two days after the case was registered, a woman's body was found in a canal near Khanda village under Dehri Mufassil police station. Shakuntala's brother and a local chowkidar reportedly identified the body as hers. Arun, his father Dilip and his brother Govind Kumar were among those arrested in connection with the case.

The Mehta family alleged that the "matter" was eventually settled through a compromise. "Shakuntala's family sought Rs 8 lakh for the settlement. Dilip Mehta's roughly three-and-a-half-katha parcel of ancestral land had to be sold to raise the money," Ahmed claimed.

"The case is now being investigated from scratch. We are trying to establish whose body was recovered earlier and how it came to be identified as Shakuntala's..." an officer said.

• NAG HAS ACTED IN AT LEAST 300 FILMS ACROSS KANNADA, HINDI AND OTHER SOUTH INDIAN LANGUAGES

Dadasaheb Phalke Award to be conferred on actor Anant Nag

Kiran Parashar
Bengaluru, September 16

VETERAN ACTOR Anant Nag is set to be conferred the Dadasaheb Phalke Award, India's highest honour in cinema, at the 72nd National Film Awards ceremony in Kevadia, Gujarat, on September 22, the government said on Wednesday.

The 78-year-old actor, who received the Padma Bhushan last year, has had a career spanning more than five decades. In this time, Nag has acted in at least 300 films across Kannada, Hindi and other South Indian languages, and was also active in theatre.

His other accolades include five Filmfare Awards, five Karnataka State Best Actor Awards, the Karnataka Rajyotsava Award, Karnataka Sahitya Academy Award and Karnataka State Lifetime Achievement Award.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi congratulated Nag in a post on X on Wednesday, say-

ing his "effortless performances, remarkable versatility and brilliance" have left a strong mark on Indian cinema, particularly Kannada cinema. "In whichever role he has played, he [Nag] brought rare depth and authenticity. This is indeed a richly deserved honour for a truly distinguished artist," Modi wrote.

Nag will be the second Kannada artiste to receive the Dadasaheb Phalke Award after Raj Kumar, and the seventh Indian to receive both the Padma Bhushan and Dadasaheb Phalke Award.

The actor broke into the scene at a time when action movies and energetic dance numbers were the norm. However, audiences resonated with Nag's ordinary man representations and his naturalistic acting. His incredible versatility earned him the 'evergreen hero' status.

Nag was born on September 4, 1948, in Mumbai as Anant S Nagaraj (also called Nagara-



The 78-year-old actor was conferred the Padma Bhushan in 2025

katti). A student of St Xavier's School in Mumbai, Nag was introduced to theatre and influenced by English plays. He performed in productions directed by Satyadev Dubey, Girish Karnad and Amol Palekar. Over roughly five years, he acted in Konkani, Kannada, Marathi and Hindi productions.

It was in 1973 that he made his film debut with the Kannada film *Sankalpata*. That same year, Nag appeared in Shyam Benegal's *Ankur*. Both films brought him critical recognition at the Karnataka State Film Awards.

Through the 1970s and 80s, Nag became a central figure in the parallel cinema movement, appearing in Shyam Benegal's nationally acclaimed films *Nishant*, *Blupanti*, *Manthan* and *Kalyan*. He also worked with directors such as MS Sathyan and Girish Karnad.

While establishing himself in Kannada cinema, his brother Shankar, who was seven years younger, joined him. The two worked together on several films, including *Minchina Ora*, *Accident*, *Anthima Chhatra* and *Ramarajadalli Rakshasaru*.

Incidentally, this period coincided with an experimental phase in Kannada cinema. Many consider it to be the industry's golden age. Indeed, of the four state awards that Nag

won for 'Best Actor', three were received during the 80s.

Beyond parallel cinema, Nag's comedy films were also a sensation in the state. They included *Ganeshana Maduve*, *Gauri Ganesh*, *Golmaal Radhakrishna* and *Manelli Ill Beed-Hilli Hulli*, among others.

Later, in 1986, Nag played the lead in *Malgudi Days*, the television series that caught the nation's attention and won several awards.

When all was going great came the biggest lull in Nag's life. On September 30, 1990, his brother Shankar died in a road accident. By then, the brothers had invested heavily in Sanket Studio, which incurred huge losses. Nag has said he spent much of his later years repaying the loans.

Outside of cinema, Nag, influenced by socialist ideas during his years in Mumbai, became involved with the Janata Party in the 1980s. He was nominated to the Karnataka Legislative Council from 1988

to 1994, and later, elected to the Karnataka Legislative Assembly from Malleshwaram and became Bengaluru development minister.

He began distancing himself from politics in 1996 after miscreants tried to attack him while he was taking his daughter to school. Since then, he has largely restricted himself to acting and preferred to not do public events.

In 2023, Nag celebrated the Golden Jubilee of his 50-year career in cinema. Two years later, in 2025, the Centre honoured him with the Padma Bhushan, the third-highest civilian award in India, for his contribution to the arts.

He married film actress Gayatri in 1987. The couple have a daughter. Aditi, who has stayed away from the film industry, a Carnatic singer by passion, Nag has also written a biographical book in Kannada — *Nanna Thamma Shankara* (My Brother Shankara), published in 2010.

RBI HAS REJECTED TATA SONS' REQUEST TO SURRENDER ITS CORE INVESTMENT COMPANY REGISTRATION

IPO, Chandra exit, AGM impasse on Tata Sons board meet agenda

George Mathew
Mumbai, September 16

THE TATA Sons board is scheduled to meet on September 17 amid three critical issues facing the holding company of the Tata group—the Reserve Bank of India's decision to push it towards listing, Chairman N Chandrasekaran's decision to step down and the continuing impasse over the company's annual general meeting (AGM).

The board meeting is expected to be a tense affair, with the question of N Chandrasekaran's continuation likely to trigger a fresh round of intense discussions within the board.

Some directors are understood to be keen on his continuation, while the board remains divided over whether he should be given an extension.

The issue, however, goes beyond the boardroom. Tata Trusts, which collectively hold a controlling stake in Tata Sons, have the power to veto the decision. But the Trusts themselves are facing divisions over several issues, making a consensus on Chandrasekaran's future far from straightforward.

The result is a potentially delicate balancing act for Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts. He will have to navigate differences within the Tata Sons board as well as among the trustees, while simultaneously dealing with the unresolved issues surrounding the company's AGM and the RBI's decision on Tata Sons' regulatory status and listing.

"It will be a tough time for Noel Tata to sort out the differences and find a way forward," sources said. The RBI has rejected Tata Sons' request to surrender its Core Investment Company registration, bringing the long-pending question of its stock-market listing back into focus. Tata Sons had sought deregistration from the regulatory framework.

The RBI has also filed a caveat in the Bombay High Court concerning the potential mandatory listing, indicating that it wants to be heard before any order is passed on the matter.

The board is also expected to discuss Chandrasekaran's exit. He informed the board in August that he would not seek a third term as Tata Sons chair-

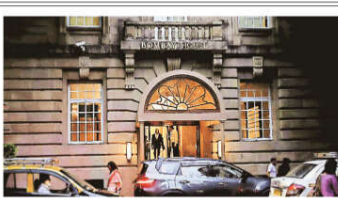
● BALANCING ACT

● Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, stares at a tricky situation. He will have to navigate differences within the Tata Sons board as well as among the trustees, while simultaneously dealing with the unresolved issues surrounding the company's AGM and the RBI's decision on Tata Sons' regulatory status and listing

● The AGM itself has become a major procedural hurdle. The August 18 meeting was adjourned for lack of quorum after the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), which holds

man. His current five-year tenure ends on February 20, 2027.

His directorship, however, was due for renewal at the August 18 AGM. He needs to remain a director to continue as chairman until the end of his current term. The AGM itself has become a major procedural hurdle. The August 18 meeting was adjourned for lack of quo-



Chandrasekaran will not seek third term as Tata Sons chairman. REUTERS

23.56% of Tata Sons, could not provide the required shareholder representation because of a restraining order issued by the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner.

● Today's meeting will therefore have to consider the listing issue alongside the leadership transition and the steps needed to convene the unfinished AGM.

rum after the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), which holds 23.56% of Tata Sons, could not provide the required shareholder representation because of a restraining order issued by the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner. Under Tata Sons' Articles of Association, at least five members must be personally present for a quorum, including

an authorised representative jointly nominated by the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and SRTT. The restriction on SRTT's board proceedings has prevented such a joint nomination. Today's meeting will therefore have to consider the listing issue alongside the leadership transition and the steps needed to convene the unfinished AGM.

India sets terms to advance talks on WTO plurilateral agreements

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, September 16

AFTER STAUNCH opposition to plurilateral pacts at the World Trade Organisation's (WTO) 14th Ministerial Conference in Cameroon earlier this year, India on Wednesday offered its proposal on WTO reforms which could help insert plurilateral agreements within the WTO framework, India's submission to the WTO's General Council showed.

Plurilateral trade agreements are negotiated and implemented by exclusive groups rather than by all WTO members, and India has been concerned that such pacts would act against the interests of developing nations, including India, as a bunch of developed nations have been opposing India's public stockholding programme on grounds that they are distorting trade.

Significantly softening its position on plurilateral pacts, India said that a "common understanding" of safeguards for plurilateral initiatives can serve all members and provide predictability.

"A common understanding on safeguards can provide greater predictability to proponents and ensure non-participation does not prejudice the rights or interests of non-participating members in matters concerning the WTO framework," India told WTO.

India stressed that "special and differential treatment" should remain central to WTO rule-making and that the pursuit of plurilateral initiatives should not result in the "marginalisation of development



on their subject matter, design and intended institutional relationship with the WTO, plurilateral initiatives may have implications for existing rights and obligations of the members, the conduct of WTO work, the negotiating interests of Members, or the operation of the multilateral trading system," the India's statement read.

"While non-participation should remain a legitimate exercise of a member's rights, it should not prejudice the rights or interests of non-participating members in matters concerning the WTO framework," India told WTO.

India stressed that "special and differential treatment" should remain central to WTO rule-making and that the pursuit of plurilateral initiatives should not result in the "marginalisation of development

● CHANGING STANCE

● Significantly softening its position on plurilateral pacts, India said a "common understanding" of safeguards for plurilateral initiatives can serve all members and provide predictability

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● Plurilateral trade agreements are negotiated and implemented by exclusive groups rather than by all WTO members

priorities or divert attention and negotiating resources from issues of particular interest to developing and least-developed members.

"Without procedural safeguards, proliferation of plurilateral initiatives and agreements could put a strain on WTO resources and limited budget. Members may face challenges in authorising the allocation of WTO budget and other resources to service these initiatives and any resulting agreements. Scarce resources would be diverted from required mandated uses, including technical assistance and capacity building," India's proposal flagged.

The change in India's position came after the BRICS summit and its recent bilateral with China.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NITI AAYOG'S EV ADOPTION INDEX Delhi ranks first, only 2 large states among top performers in EV list

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, September 16

DELHI HAS topped NITI Aayog's India Electric Mobility Index (IEMI) 2025 for the development of the e-mobility ecosystem and the adoption of electric vehicles (EVs) on Indian roads.

It is followed by Maharashtra and Karnataka, the only two of the 17 large states to feature among the top performers in EV implementation, according to the report released on Wednesday.

IEMI is a composite Index, which assesses the policy framework and implementation outcomes for e-mobility at the state-level. NITI Aayog developed the index in collaboration with WRI India. The report covers three themes: transport electrification progress, charging infrastructure readiness, and EV research and innovation status.

According to the index, the composite scores on performance across all 36 states and Union Territories (UTs) ranges from 10 to 84, and a median score of 40.

Delhi bagged the highest score of 84, followed by Maharashtra (78), Karnataka (73), Chandigarh (71), and Goa (65). When compared to the 2024 index, Delhi and Maharashtra maintained the top two positions, while Karnataka moved to the third place after overtaking Chandigarh, while Goa climbed ten spots to secure fifth position.

Notably, Madhya Pradesh recorded a substantial im-

provement, moving from the 23rd to seventh rank.

The index further shows that eight large states—Tamil Nadu, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Haryana, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh—have qualified as frontrunners, meaning they scored 50-64 out of 100. The other seven large states such as Chhattisgarh, West Bengal, Bihar, Kerala, Jharkhand, Punjab, and Gujarat were emerging performers with a score of 35-49.

EV progress and gaps

The report also shows that Delhi, Chandigarh, and Maharashtra were the only UTs and states to qualify as top performers in transport electrification progress, which is assigned the highest weightage of 50% in index calculation. It evaluates market absorption, consumer acceptance, and demand-side momentum by measuring how effectively EVs are being adopted and supported across the states.

In the Charging Infrastructure Readiness (30% weightage), Karnataka recorded the highest score nationwide at 97, closely followed by Goa (92) and Maharashtra (91).

This captures charger-to-vehicle ratio, subsidies for charging infrastructure, building bye laws for charging, power availability among other metrics. Delhi also achieved the top score of 94 in the EV Research and Innovation Status (20% weightage) category.

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US CENTRAL BANK LIFTS KEY RATE BY 25 BPS TO 3.75-4%

Fed hikes rates, sees more tightening to tame inflation

Reuters
Washington, September 16

THE FEDERAL Reserve raised interest rates on Wednesday and flagged further increases in borrowing costs in coming months, with new US central bank chief Kevin Warsh joining a unanimous decision that effectively acknowledges the Trump administration's inability to control inflation.

While President Donald Trump had promised to lower prices on his watch, the combined impact of his global import tariffs, an energy shock following the start of the US-Israeli war with Iran, and capital spending from the artificial intelligence boom has kept price pressures intense enough that the Fed felt it needed to raise its benchmark overnight interest rate by a quarter of a percentage point to the 3.75%-4.00% range.

New policy projections showed 16 of 18 policymakers anticipate at least one more quarter-percentage-point hike by the end of this year, with only two of them seeing rates remaining stable from here.

Warsh apparently again did not submit a rate projection. It's the first policy shift under the new Fed chief, who took office in late May after being selected by Trump with an expectation that he would cut rates.

The Fed's new policy statement and economic projections, to the contrary, show a central bank opening the door on tighter monetary policy through next year, with the policy rate rising to the 4.00%-4.25% range by the end of this year and ending 2027 at the same level.

"Today's policy action will support a timelier return to the Committee's 2% goal," the central bank said in its policy statement after the end of a two-day meeting.

The statement withheld any forward guidance about coming policy decisions,



Raising rates will fly in the face of what Donald Trump envisioned when he named Warsh to lead the Fed earlier this year. REUTERS

as is Warsh's preference, the decision is likely to ease doubts that the Fed chief would hold off on tighter policy out of deference to Trump, a lingering question during his first months in office.

The statement dropped a previous reference attributing current elevated inflation to "supply shocks" particularly in the energy sector, a nod to concerns among policymakers, including Warsh, that price pressures were too broad for comfort.

Warsh is scheduled to hold a press conference beginning at 2:30 pm EDT (8:30 GMT) to elaborate on the decision.

All Eyes on Warsh

The rate increase was announced less than two months ahead of midterm elections that will determine whether Trump's Republicans maintain control of Congress for the final two years of his presidency.

The Republicans are facing an uphill battle with voters angry about gasoline prices that are about a third higher than a year ago and interest rates on home mortgages that have been rising steadily this year. The average rate on a 30-

year fixed-rate mortgage is approaching 7%. Policymakers' new quarterly economic projections marked up estimates of inflation, as measured by the Personal Consumption Expenditures Price Index, to 3.7% versus the 3.6% projected at the Fed's June meeting. Inflation is not projected to return to the 2% target until 2029, a year later than previously expected.

Economic growth was marked up slightly from 2.2% to 2.3%, while the unemployment rate is seen ending the year at 4.1%, versus the 4.3% projected in June.

Warsh's characterisation at his press conference of the logic behind the rate increase and the likelihood of further action will be important in shaping the reaction in financial markets that have been raising yields on long-term US Treasury bonds.

The rate hike on Wednesday was widely expected, but investors will be looking for further information from the Fed chief about what might prompt additional increases in borrowing costs.

Warsh has pledged to lower inflation back to 2% "clearly and at sufficient speed" by raising rates as needed.

● BRIEFLY

Tax policy debate must go beyond sectoral interests: FM

New Delhi: Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday said tax policy discussions must look beyond sectoral interests and focus on the larger requirements of India's economy, including creating a system that is fair, pre-

dictable and supportive of investment and innovation. Speaking at the Eighth International Tax Conference on 'New Age Taxation' here, Sitharaman said tax reforms undertaken in recent years were aimed at simplifying compliance, reducing litigation and providing greater certainty to taxpayers. The event was organised by International Tax Research and Analysis Foundation. PTI

● MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
74,336.45	23,217.60	₹1,52,362	₹95.96
332.63	99.00		
0.45%	0.43%	Silver	Oil
		₹21,337	\$131.19

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INM BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF SEPTEMBER 16, 2026

● SOME SAY IT COULD LEAD TO A RETURN TO DIFFERENTIAL PRICING FOR CASH AND DIGITAL PAYMENTS, OR A RENEWED PUSH BY SHOPKEEPERS TO GET CUSTOMERS TO PAY IN CASH

'Rug pulled from under us': As UPI's free ride ends, traders brace for the hit

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, September 16

NEHRU PLACE, Delhi's biggest electronics market, is bracing for a hit. From October 15, eligible merchants will pay an additional fee on UPI payments above Rs 2,000, and on the ground here, almost no one thinks they will be able to pass that cost on to customers.

At his laptop repair shop, one trader thinks he already knows who will ultimately pay for the new cost attached to UPI.

Almost all of his customers, the trader at the laptop repair shop said, currently pay by UPI. But in a market where buyers haggle over a few hundred rupees and shop around freely, he sees no room to add a surcharge. At least for now. For the

record, the Union Finance Ministry said Tuesday banks have been "advised" to ensure that merchants do not pass on the cost to customers.

Businesses, already operating on thin margins, fear they will have to absorb the 0.4% Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions above Rs 2,000 themselves because passing it on risks driving customers elsewhere, even as UPI has become too deeply embedded in everyday transactions to simply stop accepting it. Some say the result could be a return to differential pricing for cash and digital payments, or a renewed push by shopkeepers to get customers to pay in cash.

"We don't see any other option but to silently accept that our margins are going to take a



Nehru Place is Delhi's largest electronics market, also dubbed as IT hardware hub of the country. SOUMYARENDRA BARIK

hit," the laptop repair shop owner said.

"99% of our customers pay via UPI, and I cannot ask them to pay more to cover for the MDR, as they will simply walk away to another shop".

At another shop selling computer peripherals, its owner likened UPI to a "hook". The government, he said, spent years encouraging merchants and customers to get accustomed to a payment mech-

anism that carried no MDR. Now that it has become embedded in everyday commerce, he feels traders are being left in the lurch.

The fears are larger than those of isolated shopkeepers. According to the Retailers Association of India (RAI), the 0.4% MDR "could undo years of progress" made in getting the country's smallest shopkeepers to adopt digital payments—especially just ahead of the festive season. "During the festive season, a large share of transactions cross the Rs 2,000 mark, and the moment a fee attaches itself to digital payment, cash becomes the path of least resistance," warned Kumar Rajagopal, CEO of RAI.

Rajagopal said the matter will be taken up with NPCI and the Ministry of Finance, with a

key objective being to pair any charge on merchants with incentives that keep small shopkeepers inside the formal payment system, rather than pushing them out.

Victim of own success

The grievance with the revised MDR framework announced on Tuesday is rooted partly in UPI's own success.

"UPI led to people not carrying much cash, and that made it so ubiquitous. Now, customers just expect to pay via UPI, it's almost out of habit now. So, it will be unfair to expect that they carry enough cash when they visit the market from here on... The government has really pulled the rug from under us," the peripherals shop owner said. Outside another computer repair store,

a group of technicians predicted that the old cash-versus-digital divide would resurface, as some traders would look to pass the cost on rather than quietly absorb it.

"Differential pricing for payment in cash and UPI will make a comeback," said another shopkeeper, predicting customers who pay by UPI will be charged more, while shops quietly steer buyers back toward cash. The palpable frustration across the market has crystallised into calls to revoke the decision to introduce the MDR fee on UPI. The All Delhi Computer Traders Association (ADCTA), led by its Nehru Place unit, has demanded an immediate rollback of the charge, arguing traders were first coaxed into adopting UPI and shouldn't now be made to pay

for it. ADCTA general secretary Saran Singh said traders were already grappling with economic headwinds and falling business.

Senior Vice-President KS Oswal said the market was already under pressure, and an added charge now would only deepen traders' troubles.

ADCTA President Mahinder Aggarwal called on the government to take traders' concerns seriously and withdraw the charge at once, warning that the burden could eventually dent government revenue too.

The government on Tuesday announced the MDR regime for UPI transactions, exempting person-to-person payments from the levy irrespective of the transaction amount.

Court video clips: SC asks petitioner to seek lockdown under IT Act

New Delhi: The Supreme Court Wednesday asked a petitioner alleging violation of its order banning the uploading of court video clips on social media to first approach online intermediaries to have the content taken down before seeking judicial intervention.

A three-judge bench, presided over by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant, heard a plea by lawyer Bhanu Pratap Mehta who said video clips of his appearance in a bail matter were posted online in violation of the Supreme Court's July 24 order.

During Wednesday's hearing, the petitioner's counsel told the bench also comprising Justices Jyotsna Bagchi and V Mohana that clips of the lawyer appearing in court were uploaded on August 20, following an apparent to direct violation of the court's prohibition. **ENS**

Centre bans Pak-based Shahzad Bhatti terror network under UAPA

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, September 16

THE MINISTRY of Home Affairs (MHA) on Wednesday declared the Pakistan-based Shahzad Bhatti Network (SBN) a "terrorist organisation" under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA).

Citing Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "vision of zero tolerance against terror", Home Minister Amit Shah said in a post on X: "The group is involved in smuggling of arms, explosives and narcotics across borders, apart from inciting youths and petty criminals into terrorism. Targeting India's democratic structure and the fabric of communal harmony, the syndicate also published hateful digital content."

A Gazette notification issued by the MHA invoked Section 35 of the UAPA to add the SBN to

the First Schedule of the law, which lists banned terrorist organisations.

Source said the decision follows a nationwide crackdown on an alleged SBN-linked network last month, days before Independence Day. Security agencies detained 253 people across 14 states, and recovered explosives, firearms and surveillance equipment. According to officials, the recoveries included IEDs, grenades bearing Pakistan Ordnance Factory markings, pistols, live cartridges and CCTV cameras that were allegedly used for espionage.

Saying that the SBN was "involved in terrorism and has participated in various acts of terrorism in India", the government notification said it is "an organisation whose objective involve gullible youth and local criminals to smuggle arms, explosives and narcotics

Bhatti has been accused of using social media to lure youngsters, and is suspected to be linked to the grenade attack at the residence of YouTuber Rozar Sandhu in Jalandhar in March last year

from across the border, and through terrorist activities, pose a serious threat to the democratic system, communal harmony, and internal security of the country".

"SBN is promoting terrorism through violent activities that disrupt public order and, by

using various digital communication platforms to disseminate provocative messages, posing a serious challenge to the integrity of the nation," it said.

According to the notification, the SBN is involved in "radicalising gullible youth" by offering allurements, motivating them for anti-national activities, and mobilising resources for anti-national acts in collusion with other banned outfits and similarly designated entities.

According to sources, the SBN is a Pakistan-based, ISI-backed terror syndicate linked to grenade, IED and petrol bomb attacks, targeted killings, and surveillance of police, defence and religious sites.

Officials said the network is suspected to have paid local consultants to conduct reconnaissance and install CCTV cameras for espionage.

"Bhatti, who is believed to move between Dubai and Pakistan, faces allegations related to bomb-making and supply of illegal arms and ammunition to India, Dubai, the US and Canada. He is said to be close to Balochistan-based gangster Farukh Khokhar," said an official. Bhatti has been accused of using social media to lure youngsters, and is suspected to be linked to the grenade attack at the residence of YouTuber, Rozar Sandhu, in Jalandhar in March last year. He is also suspected to be behind a threat issued to actor Mithun Chakraborty in November 2024.

The government notification on Wednesday cited criminal cases against suspected SBN operatives under various laws including the UAPA, Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Arms Act, Explosives Act and Information Technology Act.

SC allows head of Kashi Math to pursue recovery of valuables

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 16

THE SUPREME COURT on Tuesday dismissed Raghavendra Thirtha Swami's appeal challenging a Kerala High Court judgment that allowed Kashi Math Samsthan head Samyaminthra Thirtha Swami to continue execution proceedings to recover Math valuables from him amid an ongoing succession dispute.

A bench of Justices Arvind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi dismissed the special leave petition challenging the high court's August 3 order. "We do not find any good ground to entertain this petition. The special leave petition is, accordingly, dismissed," the court said in its September order.

The Samsthan headquartered in Varanasi is popularly referred to as Gowda Saraswat Brahmin Kashi Math.

Appearing for the respondent Samyaminthra Thirtha Swami, senior advocate Guru Krishna Kumar and advocate Lakshmesh S Kamath contended that the Kerala High Court was right in allowing him to replace the original decree holder even without the sanction of the Tirupati court, which had granted the original decree.

The high court order allowed Samyaminthra Thirtha Swami to be substituted in the execution proceedings in place of his predecessor, Math head and original decree holder Sudhindra Thirtha Swami, following the latter's demise in January 2017.

Matter in court since 2000

The litigation has its genesis in a dispute on the headship and administration of the Samsthan between Sudhindra Thirtha Swami and Raghavendra Thirtha Swami, who claimed to be the "identified successor".

In 2000, Raghavendra Thirtha Swami filed a suit before the additional district court, Tirupati, seeking a declaration that he was the lawful 21st head of the Math. He also sought a per-

manent injunction restraining Sudhindra Thirtha Swami and the Tirumala branch of the Math from interfering with the Samsthan's affairs and administration.

The trial court dismissed the suit on January 28, 2009, permanently restraining Raghavendra Thirtha Swami from interfering with the administration and affairs of the Samsthan and asked him to hand over all duties, religious articles, and other properties of the Samsthan to Sudhindra Thirtha Swami.

Raghavendra Thirtha Swami challenged this before the High Court of Judicature at Hyderabad, which dismissed the appeal and affirmed the trial court order on June 1, 2015.

From Tirupati to Ernakulam

In the proceedings that followed, the execution was transferred to the additional district court, Ernakulam, after Raghavendra Thirtha Swami raised objections to the territorial jurisdiction of the Tirupati court. This was upheld by the Kerala High Court on September 5, 2011.

During the pendency of the proceedings, the original decree-holder, Sudhindra Thirtha Swami, passed away on January 16, 2017, at Haridwar.

As per his will, Samyaminthra Thirtha Swami was nominated as his successor. Raghavendra Thirtha Swami, however, disputed the will's validity, legal effect, and enforceability.

Samyaminthra Thirtha Swami subsequently approached the Ernakulam court, seeking to replace Sudhindra Thirtha Swami in the execution proceedings. But the court ruled that he should first approach the Tirupati court, which had passed the original decree, and obtain an order substituting him as decree-holder.

On appeal, the high court, by its August 3, 2026 order, set aside the trial court order and permitted Samyaminthra Thirtha Swami to replace Sudhindra Thirtha Swami in the execution proceedings.

Aaditya denies knowing Disha Salian, calls charges 'evidence-free'

Express News Service
Mumbai, September 16

DAYS AFTER the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) registered an FIR into the death of celebrity manager Disha Salian and listed him among those whose roles are to be investigated, Shiv Sena (UBT) MLA Aaditya Thackeray on Wednesday denied ever knowing or meeting her and termed the allegations an "evidence-free" attempt at character assassination.

In a post on X, Thackeray said his name had been linked to the case for nearly six years without evidence and alleged that the campaign was driven by political and personal motives.

"Let's cut through the noise and talk about facts, once again: I have never met or known Disha Salian. Linking my name to this tragic case constantly is a deliberate, evidence-free attempt at character



Aaditya Thackeray

assassination by a few individuals with clear political and personal motives, for almost 6 years," he said.

Thackeray said the fresh inquiry should be allowed to proceed without political interference or a "media trial", adding that television debates would not change the facts. He also said attempts to use the case politically would not deter him from pursuing what he described as the truth.

The CBI registered the FIR

on September 14 following the Bombay High Court's September 2 order directing an investigation into Salian's death. The FIR names several people, including Thackeray, actor Sooraj Pancholi, Rhea Chakraborty and Dino Morea, among others, whose roles are to be investigated.

The High Court, while ordering the probe, had specifically said that no person should be treated as an accused unless sufficient material was gathered against them during the investigation.

Salian, who had worked as Sushant Singh Rajput's celebrity manager, died in Mumbai in June 2020, days before the actor's death. Allegations linking the two cases have since featured repeatedly in political and media debates.

In a second post on Wednesday, Thackeray said those seeking to use the allegations to silence him would not succeed.



Flood Assessment

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Bihar CM Samrat Choudhary inspect flood-hit villages near Hajipur on Wednesday. After visiting Terasia and Saranpur villages, Chouhan said, "This is the worst flood so far. I have been informed that the water level this time is nearly one foot higher than what it was during the 2016 floods. I also witnessed the losses suffered by farmers." **PII**

'India has made enough overtures... Now it's up to Bangladesh'

Pinak Ranjan Chakravarty, former Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh, spoke to **Shubhajit Roy**, Diplomatic Editor at *The Indian Express*, on September 3 about the turbulence in India-Bangladesh ties and their possible trajectory. Edited excerpts:



Give us some context on this new BNP government led by Tarique Rahman.

Bangladesh is a very important country for us, with almost 180 million people. We share a 4,096 km border. Its history is marked by political turbulence, right from 1975 when Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was killed along with his family.

The two years we saw under Muhammad Yunus were disastrous. Criminals and terrorists were freed and minority communities suffered. He was being dictated to by the Jamaat-e-Islami, which had taken over the student movement. The election that happened was also flawed because the Awami League was not allowed to participate. This government is under a lot of pressure as the economic conditions have worsened. There is a shortage of electricity, cooking gas, fuel etc.

How is the current Bangladesh Nationalist Party government similar to or different from the Khaleda Zia government?

You really cannot apply that template of those years... and compare it with today. The BNP is a mosaic of business lobbies, pro-Pakistan lobbies, Jamaat-e-Islami lobbies. It has a few subdued people who want good relations with India.

Sheikh Hasina being in exile in India has become a factor in bilateral ties. There must have been some pretty intense discussions in Dhaka. I think the anti-Indian lobby must have won out and prevented him (Rahman) from coming to India [for the BRICS summit].

India cannot be wished away by Bangladesh, or replaced by any other country because of our shared civilisational heritage. Millions of Bangladeshis come to India for medical treatment. There is a huge amount of trade and connectivity. This is a relationship



that one can only ignore at one's peril.

How do you assess the Indian approach towards the Tarique Rahman government?

India's policies towards Bangladesh, and other neighbors, has been that we will deal with whichever government is in power. We have dealt earlier with military dictators, with caretaker governments and with elected governments. India will not stop the normal relationship that goes on, in terms of people-to-people, business-to-business, education, etc.

Why is Sheikh Hasina key for India?

We had a good relationship with her government. There was no reason for the Indian

government to say, no, you can't bring Hasina here. The Bangladesh President, who has been a senior BNP leader, said that Hasina being in Delhi should not affect our bilateral ties. I think that was the general approach that everybody felt would be followed. But some lobbies have gained ground and said that Hasina must be handed over.

Bangladesh has made several requests. But extradition is a judicial process and the Bangladesh government has not tried to initiate one. If Hasina is willing to go back, the government will not stop her. But India will want to know what they do with her. There are people, like the Jamaat-e-Islami, who want to kill her upon arrival.

AUDIENCE QUESTIONS

How is Indian political discourse on Bangladesh perceived in Dhaka? Does this create a cycle that complicates the efforts to reset relations?

I think the asymmetry between India and Bangladesh is an issue. Bangladeshis resent that India is seen as trying to dominate it. They see India as a dominating factor in their own politics, which is not reciprocal in Indian politics.

Economic migration happens from Bangladesh, as well as minority Hindu mi-

gration linked to persecution and land grabbing. Politics in our country, particularly in certain areas, is dominated by the illegal migration issue because people are worried about demographic change. It's also a matter of some worry for the Indian government.

Where do you see the India-Bangladesh relations in the next one to two decades?

Our geography is such that there is no escape from cooperation. There may be ir-



Pinak Ranjan Chakravarty (left) at the Explained.Live session with Shubhajit Roy

How has her August 5 address queered the pitch for a visit by Rahman?

I felt the government of India could have advised her. But today, amid social media, can you stop anybody from talking? How do we confine her? She's not in custody or prison in India. She said she would like to go back, whatever the consequences she faces.

Is it possible to repair the ties?

It is definitely possible, but it will require two hands to clap. India has made enough overtures. Now it's up to Dhaka. They can say we will keep the relationship at a low key. Perfectly all right. We have seen such attitudes before. India will be mainly looking at basic pillars of the relationship. Bangladesh's main

problem today is economic. We are providing fuel and electricity to the extent we can.

Give us a sense of the stakes in the security and strategic aspect of the ties

The worry is the release of a large number of Islamists and terrorists, who are reorganising. The UN has brought out a report talking about the revival of Al-Qaeda in Bangladesh. And the country has a history of Islamic extremism, which Hasina had managed to control. A revival of that kind of extremism, which will naturally spill over into India, will be utilised and exploited by Pakistan.

Where do river water-sharing agreements stand?

We share 54 rivers and have only one agreement which is due to expire in December (the Ganga water treaty). The Teesta agreement did not happen... because West Bengal objected. The immediate issue is the Ganga water treaty. There will be hard bargaining. Bangladesh may ask for more guaranteed flows of water, which may be very difficult for India to accept. Per capita water availability is not growing (climate change and shrinking glaciers are a factor) and demand is rising.

China, US and Pakistan are the three major actors in the relationship. How do you see their role in Bangladesh and impact on India

China did not even recognize Bangladesh till about 1977. Its first stepping stone was the army, providing a lot of free arms. Around 80% of Bangladesh's military hardware now comes from China. Bangladesh has joined the Belt and Road initiative, through which China aims to create strategic influence and get a foothold. China is Bangladesh's largest trading partner.

China also seeks a corridor into the Bay of Bengal. It has one through Myanmar but the country is disturbed by conflict. So it seeks another corridor, perhaps, through Myanmar into Bangladesh. This is where the Americans come in: they don't want that to happen.

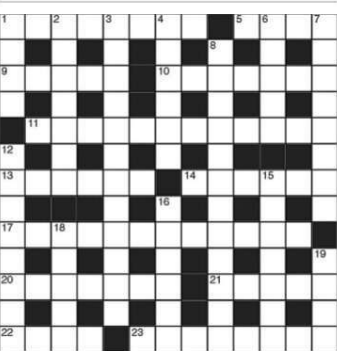
Pakistan has a one-point foreign policy and that is how to harm India. They want to convince Bangladesh to join hands with them. I doubt if Bangladesh will fall into that trap, because that would sour relations with India.



SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE VIDEO

CROSSWORD

6096



- ACROSS**
1 Fit names anyhow into list (8)
5 They may be full of beer in making attacks (4)
9 Show regret about evening being cut short (5)
10 Completely split; see for example below (7)
11 It's kept from going astray by crooks (5,2,5)
13 An afterthought on a vehicle for travellers on foot (6)
14 One not in a union (6)
17 Lessen stress by sorting out lack of sleep (12)
20 Recommend a barrister (7)
21 A foreigner on a bad line (5)
22 Celebrate far above worldly things (4)
23 Travellers in South Africa (8)
- DOWN**
1 Only 1 object to a note (4)
2 The short story is an original form to the French (7)
3 United Nations add lustre (6,6)
4 Dog is a close companion (6)
6 A French feat that's excessive (5)
7 Fought against being declared redundant (8)
8 It normally completes the written enquiry (8,4)
12 Is good at drawing? (8)
18 Rages if source of heat is changed (3,4)
16 Good man in a new role looking after horses (6)
18 He got men moving in time (5)
19 Persons less than honest (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6095 ACROSS: 1 Regarding, 8 Annoy, 9 Reserve, 10 Sinned, 11 Atoned, 12 Emphatic, 15 Extended, 18 Louise, 20 Traits, 21 Scoffer, 22 Extra, 23 Dissenter **DOWN:** 2 ERECT, 3 Ageing, 4 Dividend, 5 Garish, 6 Inanity, 7 Syndicate, 11 Absentees, 13 Padlocks, 14 Stealth, 16 Not bad, 17 Puffin, 19 Siege

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

We need men who can dream of things that _____
- John F Kennedy (5,4)

CMEE

IPVER

APTNYR

AEERVW

SOLUTIONS: Eternce, Viper, Pntry, Weaver
ANSWER: We need men who can dream of things that never wake up

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

SUDOKU 6444
9 7 8 6 5 2 4
7 8 9 2
1 5 9 8
4 2 3 7
6 1 2 9
5

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6443
1 8 6 5 7 2 3 4 9
4 2 3 8 6 9 5 7 1
5 7 9 3 1 4 8 2 6
2 9 8 7 5 1 6 3 4
3 6 1 9 4 8 7 5 2
7 4 5 6 2 3 9 1 8
6 3 4 2 9 5 1 8 7
9 5 2 1 8 7 4 6 3
8 1 7 4 3 6 2 9 5

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person namely **Hari Shanker S/o Late Sh. Bal Kishan R/o H. No. N 13/78 Kabir Nagar R. P. Bhag Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No 850/23 U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act PS: Bharat Nagar, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Hari Shanker** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Hari Shanker** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Hari Shanker** accused of **FIR No 850/23 U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act PS: Bharat Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.12.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Anuradha Jindal
ACJM, Room No. 101, 1st Floor
Rohini Court, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrP
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Roop Chand @ Pappu S/o Mangey Ram R/o H.No. 128, Gali No-07, West Sant Nagar, Barani, Delhi-84**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 362/2008, U/s 406/420/467/468/471/506/120B/34 IPC, PS Timarpur, North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Roop Chand @ Pappu** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Roop Chand @ Pappu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that **Roop Chand @ Pappu** the accused of **FIR No. 362/2008, U/s 406/420/467/468/471/506/120B/34 IPC, PS Timarpur, North Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.10.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Karanbir Singh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
(Central), Court No.-26,
Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

NORTHERN RAILWAY TENDER NOTICE

S. No.	Name of work with its location	Approx. cost of work	EMD amount	Completion Period of work
(A)	Repair to vacant flats of college lane, Tikki Bridge Railway Colony in the S/o SSEEWBH under ADENE-III.	Rs. 1,49,99,740.17	Rs. 3,00,00,000	06 Months
(B)	Annual General repair, White wash & Painting of Type-I, II, V flats at College lane and Tikki Bridge and service building in colony in the S/o SSEEWBH under ADENE-III.	Rs. 1,49,99,592.75	Rs. 3,00,00,000	12 Months
(C)	Annual General repair, White wash & Painting of Type-I, II, IV, VI flats at Anand Vihar Railway Colony in the S/o SSEEWBH under ADENE-III.	Rs. 1,34,39,694.98	Rs. 2,70,00,000	12 Months

Date and Time for Opening & Closing date of tender on **08.10.2026 at 15:00 hrs.**
Website particular notice board location complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc.
Above tender available on website i.e. <http://www.irreps.gov.in>
No: 128-V/269/O.E.T/NT No. 16 (A, B, C), 27/WE/ Dated:- 10.09.2026 3199/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Name of work and its location: 111-SERGE-5-GU-2026-27
Improvement of illumination to enhance the security arrangement at around the railway stations over Delhi Division.
Approx. cost of the works in: Rs. 1,96,01,175.00/-
Address of the office: Sr. Div. Elect Engineer/General, CRM Office, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi, 110055
Earning money: Rs. 3,32,000.00/-
Last Date & Time of submission of tender: 08.10.2026, 13.00 Hrs.
Opening of tender: 08.10.2026, 13.00 Hrs.
Website & notice board: www.irreps.gov.in & Sr. Div. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi.
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 3263/2026

Purvanchal Vidyut Vitran Nigam Ltd., SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER (MM-II) Vidyut Nagar, BLW, Varanasi
E-Tender Notice and Brief Description of Work
Name of Material
1. EAV-62/2026-27, SELECTION OF A CONSULTANT FOR NABL (ISO/IEC 17025:2017) ACCREDITATION, GAP ANALYSIS, DOCUMENTATION, CALIBRATION AND TRAINING SUPPORT FOR THE HI-TECH TEST LABORATORY, P.V.V.N., VARANASI.
Tender Fee: Rs. 118,000, Earnest Money: Rs. 5,000.00
Last date & Time for submission of tender document: 28, September 2026, 15:00 Hrs.
Further details and all other information can be seen at website www.etenderup.nic.in
"Save Electricity in the interest of Nation"
R.No.- 1467/Date: 15.09.2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrP / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Mohd. Ashraf S/o Akram R/o: H.No. K-444, Sunder Nagar, Nand Nagar, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 978/2022, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS Jahangirpuri, North-West Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mohd. Ashraf** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mohd. Ashraf** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that **Mohd. Ashraf** the said accused of **FIR No. 978/2022, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, PS Jahangirpuri, North-West Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.10.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07,
North, Court No.-06, Ground Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Ashok Kumar Sirodhi** Director of M/s Saha Infra Pvt. Ltd. R/o E-13, Sector-30, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh also at Flat No. 4, Plot No. 194-A, Ward No. 2, Hill View Apartment, Mehrauli, South Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC No. 2386/2020 U/s 138 NI Act, PS Karol Bagh, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Ashok Kumar Sirodhi** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ashok Kumar Sirodhi** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Ashok Kumar Sirodhi** in **CC No. 2386/2020 U/s 138 NI Act, PS Karol Bagh, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.10.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Urv Guptra
Judicial Magistrate First Class NI ACT-01
Room No. 201, C/26
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/13103/CD/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY TENDER NOTICE
Invitation of Tenders through E-Tendering (E-Procurement System)
Sr.DMM, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110051, for and on behalf of the president of India invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:
S. No. Tender No. Brief Description Qty. Closing Date
1. 93266135 Industrial Accessory Image as per specifications attached. 02 Nos 15/10/2026
Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.irreps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.
Sr. DMM/NSIL/P93266135/2026 Date:-16/09/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2198/26

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Rakhi W/o Shiv Charan R/o H.No. 112, G Block, Jahangirpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 2767/2021, U/s 138 NI Act at PS: Jahangir Puri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rakhi** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rakhi** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Rakhi** of **FIR No. 2767/2021, U/s 138 NI Act of PS: Jahangir Puri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **17.10.2026**.

Gaurav Dahiya
JMFC/NI Act Court
North District Rohini
New Delhi
DP/13116/NW/2026

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	MODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS (EMAIL)
1.	UHBVN	CONSTRUCTION OF NEW CIVIL SUPPLY CANALS AND OTHER CIVIL WORKS AT KV 36/TH NALTAHA PANIPAT.	TENDER CLOSING DATE: 26.09.2026	TENDER AMOUNT: RS. 1338850/- EMD: RS. 12086/-	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	0991460380 venkatsubramanian@gmail.com
2.	UHBVN	VARIOUS CIVIL WORKS LIKE REPAIR OF BUILDING AND FOUNDATION, EXTERIOR AND INTERIOR PAINT, DOOR AND WINDOWS GLASS WORK ETC. AT KV 35/TH S.P. RAJDA.	CLOSING DATE: 26.09.2026	TENDER AMOUNT: RS. 69415/- EMD: RS. 12086/-	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	0991460380 venkatsubramanian@gmail.com
3.	UHBVN	CONST. OF COMPLAINT CENTRE AT KV 36/TH AT NALTAHA PANIPAT.	CLOSING DATE: 26.09.2026	TENDER AMOUNT: RS. 1184350/- EMD: RS. 12086/-	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	0991460380 venkatsubramanian@gmail.com
4.	UHBVN	CONSTRUCTION OF COMPLAINT CENTRE BUILDING, STORE ROOM AND WASHROOM AT KV 36/TH ENGINEERING COLLEGE (DISTRICT), PANIPAT.	CLOSING DATE: 25.09.2026	TENDER AMOUNT: RS. 1387690/- EMD: RS. 26976/-	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	0991460380 venkatsubramanian@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No. 493554HRY

Sr. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	MODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS (EMAIL)
1.	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION FARIDABAD	SELECTION OF AGENCY FOR PROCESSING OF 600 TPD DAILY GENERATED MUNICIPAL SOLID WASTE FOR VILLAGE PARIKHAR FARIDABAD AT VILLAGE PARIKHAR FARIDABAD FOR A PERIOD OF 2 YEARS FURTHER EXTENDABLE UP TO 2 YEARS ON A YEAR-TO-YEAR BASIS. REGD.	15.09.2026 25.09.2026	20+ CRORES	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 memnandani@gmail.com
2.	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION FARIDABAD	ESTIMATE FOR CONSTRUCTION OF BOUNDARY WALL FOR LAND D WASTE POINT AT FISH MARKET NEAR SHARSHAH GATE SECTOR. 22 IN WARD NO. 04, BALABAR-GARHI, RECALL + 3	12.09.2026 19.09.2026	281 LACS	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 venm43@gmail.com
3.	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION FARIDABAD	PROVIDING AND LAYING OF P.W. 12.5 AT GALI NO. 1,2,3,4,5,6,7,8,9,10,11,12,13,14 IN BAKHOLA COLONY OF WARD NO. 32, + 1 WORKS	11.09.2026 21.09.2026	1,13,31,41,71	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 venm43@gmail.com
4.	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION FARIDABAD	ESTIMATE FOR REDEVELOPMENT OF MARKET SECTOR 14 UNDER MCF AREA IN WARD NO. 35 OLD FARIDABAD.	11.09.2026 21.09.2026	1,38,62,566/-	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 venm43@gmail.com
5.	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION FARIDABAD	RE-DEVELOPMENT OF MARKET SECTOR 9 WARD NO 37 FARIDABAD	11.09.2026 21.09.2026	1,35,36,745/-	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 venm43@gmail.com
6.	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION FARIDABAD	RE-DEVELOPMENT OF MARKET SECTOR - 8 IN WARD NO. 39 UNDER MCF AREA OLD FARIDABAD.	11.09.2026 21.09.2026	1,24,26,566/-	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 venm43@gmail.com
7.	MUNICIPAL CORPORATION FARIDABAD	SUPPLY OF WATER TANKERS FOR DRINKING, CAPACITY 5000 LTR. IN ACHERVS SOCIETY, SECTOR-40, BABALI WARD AND SANKU COLONY AT 2 BLOCK IN WARD NO. 19 (NEH), BAKHOLA, FARIDABAD. + 3 WORKS	14.09.2026 21.09.2026	89,77,314/-	https://tenders.hry.nic.in	01292411649 mcdmrat@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No. 493071HRY

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today is a wonderful day for learning and studying. Anything related to important papers, universities and higher education will flourish. This is a good time to sort through the details of a vacation itinerary. Tonight: Do something different.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Financial discussions will go well today. This is a wonderful day to get a loan or mortgage or to explore new aspects of dealing with shared property or anything that is jointly owned, including inheritances. Tonight: Check your finances.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is an excellent time for important discussions. You'll be generous, fair-minded and upbeat. But at the same time, you'll be realistic and grounded. Tonight: Listen to someone.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today promises success and productivity for you. Not only will you impress bosses and people in authority, you can do something to boost your income now or in the future. Work-related travel might occur for some of you. Tonight: Work.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): It's a lucky day for you! The Moon in your sign, favours all kinds of ventures, including business, publishing, higher education, medicine and the law, as well as doing what is important to you. Tonight: Play.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Relax at home if you can today. You might find it rewarding to explore personal issues, as well as your spiritual life. You will feel content. A serious discussion with an older family member about debt and shared property might take place. Tonight: Relax.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Your communication skills are great today. Short trips, visits with siblings, relatives and neighbours and a chance to learn or teach will please you. Serious discussions will be productive. Tonight: Listen.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): This is a good money day for you. You'll impress co-workers and clients. Not only you hard-working and productive right now, today you're also diplomatic and charming. Go for the gold! Tonight: Maintain your possessions.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): You are blessed today because the Moon is in your sign dancing beautifully with both Jupiter and Saturn, which gives you a wonderful sense of balance when dealing with both work and play. Explore opportunities to travel. Tonight: You're in charge.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Remember to be patient with partners and close friends. Travel opportunities and a chance to explore avenues in publishing, medicine and the law are favourable. Negotiations will favour you today. Tonight: Enjoy solitude.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Your communication skills are great today, so you'll enjoy chatting with friends and groups. Talking to members of the general public will also be successful. You have a nice balance between optimism and grounded commonsense today. Tonight: Be friendly.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Today, people will notice you more than usual. You will make a fabulous impression on co-workers as well as anyone who holds the purse strings. Travel and a chance to meet someone different will appeal. Tonight: Be kind and modest.